BOOKS

of

MACCABEES

In English

The First Book of the Maccabees

The First Book of the Maccabees is recognized as Deuterocanonical Scripture by the Roman Catholic, Greek Orthodox, and Russian Orthodox Churches.

1

After Alexander the Macedonian, the son of Philip, who came out of the land of Chittim, and struck Darius king of the Persians and Medes, it came to pass, after he had struck him, that he reigned in his place, in former time, over[a] Greece. He fought many battles, won many strongholds, killed the kings of the earth, went through to the ends of the earth, and took spoils of a multitude of nations. The earth was quiet before him. He was exalted. His heart was lifted up. He gathered together an exceedingly strong army and ruled over countries, nations, and principalities, and they paid him tribute. After these things he fell sick, and perceived that he was going to die. He called his honorable servants, which had been brought up with him from his youth, and he divided to them his kingdom while he was still alive. Alexander reigned twelve years, then he died. Then his servants ruled, each one in his place. They all put crowns upon themselves after he was dead, and so did their sons after them many years; and they multiplied evils in the earth. There came out of them a sinful root, Antiochus Epiphanes, son of Antiochus the king, who had been a hostage at Rome, and he reigned in[b] the one hundred thirty seventh year of the kingdom of the Greeks. In those days transgressors of the law came out of Israel and persuaded many, saying, "Let's go make a covenant with the[c] Gentiles around us; for since we were separated from them many evils have befallen us." That proposal was good in their eyes. Some of the people eagerly went to the king, and he authorized them to observe the ordinances of the [d] Gentiles. So [e] they built a gymnasium in Jerusalem according to the laws of the[f] Gentiles. They made themselves uncircumcised, forsook the holy covenant, joined themselves to the[g] Gentiles, and sold themselves to do evil. The kingdom was established in the sight of Antiochus, and he planned to reign over Egypt, that he might reign over both kingdoms. He entered into Egypt with a[h] great multitude, with chariots, with elephants, with cavalry, and with a great[i] navy. He made war against Ptolemy king of Egypt. Ptolemy was put to shame before him, and fled; and many fell wounded to death. They took possession of the strong cities in the land of Egypt, and he took the spoils of Egypt. Antiochus, after he had defeated Egypt, returned in[j] the one hundred forty third year, and went up against Israel and Jerusalem with a[k] great multitude, and entered presumptuously into the sanctuary, and took the golden altar, the lampstand for the light, and all its utensils. He took the table of the show bread, the cups for the drink offerings, the bowls, the golden censers, the veil, the crowns, and the gold decoration on the front of the temple. He peeled it all off. He took the silver, the gold, and the precious vessels. He took the hidden treasures which he found. When he had taken all of these, he went away into his own land. He made a great slaughter, and spoke very arrogantly. Great mourning came upon Israel, in every place where they were. The rulers and elders groaned. The virgins and young men were made feeble. The beauty of the women was changed. Every bridegroom took up lamentation. She who sat in the marriage chamber was mourning. The land was moved for its inhabitants, and all the house of Jacob was clothed with shame. [l]After two full years, the king sent a chief collector of tribute to the cities of Judah, and he came to Jerusalem with a[m] great multitude. He spoke words of peace to them in subtlety, and they believed him. Then he fell upon the city suddenly, struck it very severely, and destroyed many people of Israel. He took the spoils of the city, set it on fire, and pulled down its houses and its walls on every side. They led captive the women and the children, and seized the livestock. Then they fortified the city of David with a large, strong wall and with strong towers, and it became their citadel. They put a sinful nation, transgressors of the law, there, and they strengthened themselves in it. They stored up weapons and food, and gathering together the spoils of Jerusalem, they stored them there, and they became a great menace. It became a place to lie in wait against the sanctuary, and an evil adversary to Israel continually. They shed innocent blood on every side of the sanctuary, and defiled the sanctuary. The inhabitants of Jerusalem fled because of them. She became a habitation of foreigners. She became foreign to those who were born in her, and her children forsook her. Her sanctuary was laid waste like a wilderness,[n] her feasts were turned into mourning, her Sabbaths into reproach, and her honor into contempt. According to her glory, so was her dishonor multiplied, and her exaltation was turned into mourning. King Antiochus wrote to his whole kingdom that all should be one people, and that each should forsake his own laws. All the nations agreed according to the word of the king. Many of Israel consented to his worship, sacrificed to the idols, and profaned the Sabbath. The

[a] *1:1* That is, the Greek Empire. Compare **1** Maccabees **1:10** and **1** Maccabees **6:2**.
[b] *1:10* circa B.C. **176**.
[c] *1:11* Or, nations: and so throughout this book.
[d] *1:13* Or, nations: and so throughout this book.
[e] *1:14* See **2** Maccabees **4:9**, **12**.
[f] *1:14* Or, nations: and so throughout this book.
[g] *1:15* Or, nations: and so throughout this book
[h] *1:17* Gr. heavy.
[i] *1:17* Or, armament
[j] *1:20* circa B.C. **170**. See **2** Maccabees **5:11- 16**.
[k] *1:20* Gr. heavy.
[l] *1:29* See **2** Maccabees **5:24**.
[m] *1:29* Gr. heavy.
[n] *1:39* See **2** Maccabees **6:6**.

king sent letters by the hand of messengers to Jerusalem and the cities of Judah, that they should follow laws strange to the land, and should forbid whole burnt offerings and sacrifice and drink offerings in the sanctuary; and should profane the Sabbaths and feasts, and pollute the sanctuary and those who were holy; that they should build altars, and temples, and shrines for idols, and should sacrifice swine's flesh and unclean animals; and that they should leave their sons uncircumcised, that they should make their souls abominable with all manner of uncleanness and profanation; so that they might forget the law, and change all the ordinances. Whoever doesn't do according to the word of the king, he shall die. According to all these words wrote he to his whole kingdom. He appointed overseers over all the people, and he commanded the cities of Judah to sacrifice, city by city. From the people were gathered together to them many, everyone who had forsaken the law; and they did evil things in the land. They made Israel to hide themselves in every place of refuge which they had. On the fifteenth day of Chislev, in[a] the one hundred forty fifth year, they built an abomination of desolation upon the altar,[b] and in the cities of Judah on every side they built idol altars.[c] At the doors of the houses and in the streets they burned incense. They tore the books of the law which they found in pieces and set them on fire. Anyone who was found with any a book of the covenant, and if any consented to the law, the king's sentence delivered him to death. Thus did they in their might to Israel, to those who were found month by month in the cities. On the twenty-fifth day of the month they sacrificed upon the idol altar that was on top of the altar of burnt offering. [d]They put to death women who had circumcised their children, according to the commandment. They hung their babies around their necks, and their houses, and those who had circumcised them. Many in Israel were fully resolved and confirmed in themselves not to eat unclean things. [e]They chose to die, that they might not be defiled with the food, and that they might not profane the holy covenant; and they died. Exceedingly great wrath came upon Israel.

2

In those days Mattathias the son of John, the son of Simeon, a priest of the sons of Joarib, from Jerusalem rose up; and he lived at Modin. And he had five sons:[f] John, who was surnamed Gaddis; Simon, who was called Thassi; Judas, who was called Maccabaeus; Eleazar, who was called Avaran; and Jonathan, who was called Apphus. He saw the blasphemies that were committed in Judah and in Jerusalem, and he said, "Woe is me! Why was I born to see the destruction of my people and the destruction of the holy city, and to dwell there when it was given into the hand of the enemy, the sanctuary into the hand of foreigners? Her temple has become like a man who was glorious. Her vessels of glory are carried away into captivity. Her infants are slain in her streets. Her young men are slain with the enemy's sword. What nation has not inherited her palaces and taken possession of her spoils? Her adornment has all been taken away. Instead of a free woman, she has become a slave. Behold, our holy things, our beauty, and our glory are laid waste. The Gentiles have profaned them. Why should we live any longer?" Mattathias and his sons tore their clothes, put on sackcloth, and mourned exceedingly. And the king's officers who were enforcing the apostasy came into the city Modin to sacrifice. Many of Israel came to them, and Mattathias and his sons were gathered together. The king's officers answered and spoke to Mattathias, saying, "You are a ruler and an honorable and great man in this city, and strengthened with sons and kindred. Now therefore come first and do the commandment of the king, as all the nations have done, including the men of Judah and those who remain in Jerusalem. You and your house will be numbered among the king's[g] friends, and you and your sons will be honored with silver and gold and many gifts." And Mattathias answered and said with a loud voice, "If all the nations that are in the house of the king's dominion listen to him, to fall away each one from the worship of his fathers, and have made choice to follow his commandments, yet I and my sons and my kindred will walk in the covenant of our fathers. Far be it from us that we should forsake the law and the ordinances. We will not listen to the king's words, to turn aside from our worship, to the right hand, or to the left." When he had finished speaking these words, a Jew came in the sight of all to sacrifice on the altar which was at Modin, according to the king's commandment. Mattathias saw it, so his zeal was kindled, and his guts trembled, and he vented his wrath according to judgment, and ran and killed him upon the altar. He killed the king's officer, who compelled men to sacrifice, at the same time, and pulled down the altar. He was zealous for the law, even as Phinehas did to Zimri the son of Salu. Mattathias cried out in the city with a loud voice, saying, "Whoever is zealous for the law and

[a] *1:54* circa B.C. **168**. See **2** Maccabees **5:11**.
[b] *1:54* The two words rendered altar are different in the Greek: and so in **1** Maccabees **1:59**.
[c] *1:54* The two words rendered altar are different in the Greek: and so in **1** Maccabees **1:59**.
[d] *1:60* See **2** Maccabees **6:10**.
[e] *1:63* See **2** Maccabees **6:19** and **7:1**, etc.
[f] *2:2* Gr. Joannes.
[g] *2:18* See **1** Maccabees **3:38**; **10:10**, etc.; Compare **1** Maccabees **10:65**; **11:27**; **2** Maccabees **8:9**.

maintains the covenant, let him follow me!" He and his sons fled into the mountains, and left all that they had in the city. Then many who sought justice and judgment went down into the wilderness to live there— they, their children, their wives, and their livestock—because evils were multiplied upon them. It was told the king's officers and the forces that were in Jerusalem, the city of David, that certain men who had broken the king's commandment had gone down into the secret places in the wilderness; and many pursued after them, and having overtaken them, they encamped against them and set the battle in array against them on the Sabbath day. They said to them, "Enough of this! Come out and do according to the word of the king, and you will all live!" They said, "We won't come out. We won't do the word of the king, to profane the Sabbath day." Then the enemy hurried to attack them. They didn't answer them. They didn't cast a stone at them, or block their secret places, saying, "Let's all die in our innocence. Heaven and earth testify for us, that you put us to death unjustly." So they attacked them on the Sabbath, and they died—they, their wives, their children, and their livestock—in number a thousand souls of men. When Mattathias and his friends found out about it, and they mourned over them exceedingly. One said to another, "If we all do as our kindred have done, and don't fight against the Gentiles for our lives and our ordinances, they will quickly destroy us from off the earth." So they decided that day, saying, "Whoever comes against us to battle on the Sabbath day, let's fight against him, and we will in no way all die, as our kindred died in the secret places." Then a company of the Hasidaeans,[a] mighty men of Israel, everyone who offered himself willingly for the law, were gathered together to them. All those who fled from the evils were added to them, and supported them. They mustered an army, and struck sinners in their anger, and lawless men in their wrath. The rest fled to the Gentiles for safety. And Mattathias and his friends went around and pulled down the altars. They forcibly circumcised the boys who were uncircumcised, as many as they found in the coasts of Israel. They pursued the arrogant, and the work prospered in their hand. They rescued the law out of the hand of the Gentiles and out of the hand of the kings. They never allowed the sinner to triumph. The days of Mattathias drew near that he should die, and he said to his sons, "Now pride and scorn have gained strength. It is a season of overthrow and indignant wrath. Now, my children, be zealous for the law, and give your lives for the covenant of your fathers. Call to remembrance the deeds of our fathers which they did in their generations; and receive great glory and an everlasting name. Wasn't Abraham found faithful in temptation, and it was reckoned to him for righteousness? Joseph in the time of his distress kept the commandment, and became lord of Egypt. Phinehas our father, because he was exceedingly zealous, obtained the covenant of an everlasting priesthood. Joshua became a judge in Israel for fulfilling the word. Caleb obtained a heritage in the land for testifying in the congregation. David inherited the throne of a kingdom forever and ever for being merciful. Elijah was taken up into heaven because he was exceedingly zealous for the law. Hananiah, Azariah, and Mishael believed, and were saved out of the flame. Daniel was delivered from the mouth of lions for his innocence. "Thus consider from generation to generation that no one who put their trust in him will lack for strength. Don't be afraid of the words of a sinful man; for his glory will be dung and worms. Today he will be lifted up, and tomorrow he will in no way be found, because he has returned to dust, and his thought has perished. You, my children, be strong, and show yourselves men on behalf of the law; for in it you will obtain glory. Behold, Simon your brother, whom I know to be a man of counsel. Always listen to him. He shall be a father to you. Judas Maccabaeus has been strong and mighty from his youth. He shall be your captain and shall fight[b] the battle of the people. Rally around all the doers of the law, and avenge the wrong done to your people. Repay the Gentiles, and obey the commandments of the law." He blessed them, and was gathered to his ancestors. He died in[c] the one hundred forty sixth year, and his sons buried him in the tombs of his ancestors at Modin. All Israel made great lamentation for him.

3

His son Judas, who was called Maccabaeus, rose up in his place. All his kindred helped him, and so did all those who joined with his father, and they fought with gladness the battle of Israel. He got his people great glory, and put on a breastplate like a giant, and bound his warlike harness around him, and set battles in array, protecting the army with his sword. He was like a lion in his deeds, and like a lion's cub roaring for prey. He hunted and pursued the lawless, and he burned up those who troubled his people. The lawless shrunk back for fear of him, and all the workers of lawlessness were very troubled, and deliverance prospered in his hand. He angered many kings and made Jacob glad with his acts. His memory is blessed forever. He went through the cities of Judah, destroyed the ungodly[d] out of the land, and turned away wrath from Israel. He was renowned to

[a] *2:42* That is, Chasidim.

[b] *2:66* Some ancient authorities read you shall fight.

[c] *2:70* circa B.C. **167**.

[d] *3:8* Gr. out of it.

the utmost part of the earth. He gathered together those who were ready to perish. Apollonius gathered the Gentiles together with a great army from Samaria to fight against Israel. Judas learned of it, and he went out to meet him, struck him, and killed him. Many fell wounded to death, and the rest fled. They took their spoils, and Judas took Apollonius' sword, and he fought with it all his days. Seron, the commander of the army of Syria, heard that Judas had gathered a large company, including a body of faithful men who stayed with him, went out to war. He said, "I will make myself a name and get myself glory in the kingdom. I will fight against Judas and those who are with him, who despise the king's command. A mighty army of the ungodly went up with him to help him, to take vengeance on the children of Israel. He came near to the ascent of Bethhoron, and Judas went out to meet him with a small company. But when they saw the army coming to meet them, they said to Judas, "What? Shall we be able, being a small company, to fight against so great and strong a multitude? We for our part are faint, having tasted no food this day." Judas said, "It is an easy thing for many to be hemmed in by the hands of a few. With[a] heaven it is all one, to save by many or by few; for victory in battle stands not in the multitude of an army, but strength is from heaven. They come to us in fullness of insolence and lawlessness, to destroy us and our wives and our children, and to plunder us, but we fight for our lives and our laws. He himself will crush them before our face; but as for you, don't be afraid of them. Now when he had finished speaking, he rushed suddenly against Seron and his army, and they were defeated before him. They pursued them down the descent of Bethhoron to the plain, and about eight hundred men of them fell; but the rest fled into the land of the Philistines. The fear of Judas and his kindred, and the dread of them, began to fall on the nations around them. His fame reached the king, and every nation told of the battles of Judas. But when King Antiochus heard these words, he was full of indignation; and he sent and gathered together all the forces of his realm, an exceedingly strong army. He opened his treasury and gave his forces pay for a year, and commanded them to be ready for every need. He saw that the money was gone from his treasures, and that the tributes of the country were small, because of the dissension and disaster which he had brought upon the land, to the end that he might take away the laws which had been from the first days. He was afraid that he wouldn't have enough as at other times for the charges and the gifts which he used to give with a liberal hand, more abundantly than the kings who were before him. And he was exceedingly perplexed in his mind, and he determined to go into Persia, and to take the tributes of those countries, and to gather much money. He left Lysias, an honorable man, and one of royal lineage, to be over the affairs of the king from the river Euphrates to the borders of Egypt, and to bring up his son Antiochus, until he came again. He delivered to Lysias half of his forces and the elephants, and gave him charge of all the things that he would have done, and concerning those who lived in Judea and in Jerusalem, that he should send an army against them to root out and destroy the strength of Israel and the remnant of Jerusalem, and to take away their memory from the place, and that he should make foreigners live in all their territory, and should divide their land to them by lot. The king took the half that remained of the forces, and left Antioch, his royal city, in the one hundred forty seventh year;[b] and he passed over the river Euphrates, and went through the upper countries. Lysias chose Ptolemy the son of Dorymenes, Nicanor, and Gorgias, mighty men of the king's friends;[c] and with them, he sent forty thousand infantry and seven thousand cavalry to go into the land of Judah and to destroy it, according to the word of the king. They set out with all their army, and came and encamped near Emmaus in the plain country. The merchants of the country heard of their fame, and took silver and gold in large quantities, and fetters,[d] and came into the camp to take the children of Israel for slaves. Forces of Syria and of the land of the Philistines[e] joined with them. Judas and his kindred saw that evils were multiplied, and that the forces were encamping in their borders. They learned about the king's words which he had commanded, to destroy the people and make an end of them. Then they each said to his neighbor, "Let's repair the ruins of our people. Let's fight for our people and the holy place." The congregation was gathered together, that they might be ready for battle, and that they might pray and ask for mercy and compassion. Jerusalem was without inhabitant like a wilderness. There was none of her offspring who went in or went out. The sanctuary was trampled down. Children of foreigners were in the citadel. The Gentiles lived there. Joy was taken away from Jacob, and the pipe and the harp ceased. They gathered themselves together, and came to Mizpeh, near Jerusalem; for in Mizpeh there used to be a place of prayer for Israel. They fasted that day, put on sackcloth, put ashes on their heads, tore their clothes, and opened the book of the law, to learn about the things for which the Gentiles consulted the images of their idols. They brought the priests' garments, the first fruits, and the tithes. They

[a] *3:18* Some ancient authorities read the God of heaven.

[b] *3:37* circa B.C. **166**.

[c] *3:38* See **1** Maccabees **2:18**.

[d] *3:41* Most of the authorities read servants.

[e] *3:41* Gr. foreigners.

stirred up the Nazarites, who had accomplished their days. They cried aloud toward heaven, saying, "What should we do with these men? Where should we carry them away? Your holy place is trampled down and profaned. Your priests mourn in humiliation. Behold, the Gentiles are assembled together against us to destroy us. You know what things they imagine against us. How will we be able to stand against them, unless you help us?" They sounded with the trumpets, and gave a loud shout. And after this Judas appointed leaders of the people: captains of thousands, captains of hundreds, captains of fifties, and captains of tens. He said to those who were building houses, were betrothing wives, were planting vineyards, and were fearful, that they should return, each man to his own house, according to the law. The army marched out and encamped upon the south side of Emmaus. Judas said, "Arm yourselves and be valiant men! Be ready in the morning to fight with these Gentiles who are assembled together against us to destroy us and our holy place. For it is better for us to die in battle than to see the calamities of our nation and the holy place. Nevertheless, as may be the will in heaven, so shall he do.

4

Gorgias took five thousand infantry, a thousand chosen cavalry, and the army moved out at night, that it might fall upon the army of the Jews and strike them suddenly. The men of the citadel were his guides. Judas heard of this, and he and the valiant men moved, that he might strike the king's army which was at Emmaus while the forces were still dispersed from the camp. Gorgias came into the camp of Judas at night and found no man. He sought them in the mountains; for he said, "These men are running away from us." As soon as it was day, Judas appeared in the plain with three thousand men. However they didn't have the armor and swords they desired. They saw the camp of the Gentiles strong and fortified, with cavalry all around it; and these were expert in war. Judas said to the men who were with him, "Don't be afraid of their numbers, or when they charge. Remember how our fathers were saved in the Red sea, when Pharaoh pursued them with an army. Now let's cry to heaven, if he will have us, and will remember the covenant of our fathers, and destroy this army before our face today. Then all the Gentiles will know that there is one who redeems and saves Israel. The foreigners lifted up their eyes, and saw them coming near them. They went out of the camp to battle. Those who were with Judas sounded their trumpets and joined battle. The Gentiles were defeated, and fled into the plain. But all those in the rear fell by the sword. They pursued them to[a] Gazara, and to the plains of Idumaea, Azotus, and Jamnia. About three thousand of those men fell. Then Judas and his army returned from pursuing them; and he said to the people, "Don't be greedy for the spoils, because there is a battle before us. Gorgias and his army are near us on the mountain. But stand now against our enemies and fight against them, and afterwards take the spoils with boldness." While Judas was finishing this speech, a part of them appeared looking out from the mountain. They saw that their army had been put to flight, and that the Jews were burning the camp; for the smoke that was seen declared what was done. But when they perceived these things, they were very afraid. Perceiving also the army of Judas in the plain ready for battle, they all fled into the land of the[b] Philistines. Judas returned to plunder the camp, and they took much gold, silver, blue, sea purple, and great riches. Then they returned home, and sang a song of thanksgiving, and gave praise to heaven, because he is good, because his mercy endures forever. Israel had a great deliverance that day. The foreigners who had escaped came and told Lysias all the things that had happened. When he heard of it, he was confounded and discouraged, because the things he desired had not been done to Israel, nor had such things happened as the king commanded him. In the next year, he gathered together sixty thousand chosen infantry and five thousand cavalry, that he might subdue them. They came into Idumaea and encamped at Bethsura. Judas met them with ten thousand men. He saw that the army was strong, and he prayed and said, "Blessed are you, O Savior of Israel, who defeated the attack of the mighty warrior by the hand of your servant David, and delivered the army of the[c] Philistines into the hands of Jonathan the son of Saul, and of his armor bearer. Hem in this army in the hand of your people Israel, and let them be ashamed for their army and their cavalry. Give them faintness of heart. Cause the boldness of their strength to melt away, and let them quake at their destruction. Strike them down with the sword of those who love you, and let all who know your name praise you with thanksgiving." They joined in battle; and about five thousand men of Lysias' army fell. They fell down near them. But when Lysias saw that his troops were put to flight, and the boldness that had come upon those who were with Judas, and how they were ready either to live or to die nobly, he withdrew to Antioch, and gathered together hired soldiers, that he might come again into Judea with an even greater army. But Judas and his kindred said, "Behold, our enemies are defeated. Let's go up to cleanse the holy place and to rededicate it." All the army was gathered together, and they went up to

[a] *4:15* Gr. Gazera. | [b] *4:22* Gr. foreigners. | [c] *4:30* Gr. foreigners.

mount Zion. They saw the sanctuary laid desolate, the altar profaned, the gates burned up, shrubs growing in the courts as in a forest or as on one of the mountains, and the priests' chambers pulled down; and they tore their clothes, made great lamentation, put ashes upon their heads, fell on their faces to the ground, [a] blew with the solemn trumpets,[b] and cried toward heaven. Then Judas appointed certain men to fight against those who were in the citadel until he had cleansed the holy place. He chose blameless priests who were devoted to the law; and they cleansed the holy place and carried the defiled stones out to an unclean place. They deliberated what to do with the altar of burnt offerings, which had been profaned. A good plan came into their mind, that they should pull it down, lest it would be a reproach to them, because the Gentiles had defiled it. So they pulled down the altar and laid up the stones on the temple hill in a convenient place, until a prophet would come to give an answer concerning them. They took whole stones according to the law, and built a new altar like the former. They built the holy place and the inner parts of the house; and they consecrated the courts. They made new holy vessels, and they brought the lampstand, the altar of incense, and the table into the temple. They burned incense on the altar, and they lit the lamps that were upon the lampstand, and they gave light in the temple. They set loaves upon the table, hung up the curtains, and finished all the work which they had done. They rose up early in the morning, on the twenty-fifth day of the ninth month, which is the month Chislev, in[c] the one hundred forty eighth year, and offered sacrifice according to the law on the new altar of burnt offerings which they had made. At the time and day the Gentiles had profaned it, even then it was dedicated with songs, harps, lutes, and with cymbals. All the people fell on their faces, worshiped, and gave praise toward heaven, which had given them good success. They celebrated the dedication of the altar eight days, and offered burnt offerings with gladness, and sacrificed a sacrifice of deliverance and praise. They decorated the front of the temple with crowns of gold and small shields. They dedicated the gates and the priests' chambers, and made doors for them. There was exceedingly great gladness among the people, and the reproach of the Gentiles was turned away. Judas and his kindred and the whole congregation of Israel ordained that the days of the dedication of the altar should be kept in their seasons from year to year for eight days, from the twenty-fifth day of the month Chislev, with gladness and joy. At that time, they fortified mount Zion with high walls and strong towers around it, lest perhaps the Gentiles might come and trample them down, as they had done before. Judas stationed a garrison to guard it. They fortified Bethsura to keep it, that the people might have a stronghold near Idumaea.

5

It came to pass, when the Gentiles all around heard that the altar had been rebuilt and the sanctuary dedicated as before, they were exceedingly angry. They took counsel to destroy the race of Jacob that was in the midst of them, and they began to kill and destroy among the people. Judas fought against the children of Esau in Idumaea at Akrabattine, because they besieged Israel. He struck them with a great slaughter, humbled them, and took their spoils. He remembered the wickedness of the children of [d] Baean, who were a snare and a stumbling block to the people, lying in wait for them on the highways. They were shut up by him in the towers. He encamped against them, and destroyed them utterly, and burned with fire the towers of the place with all who were in them. He passed over to the children of Ammon, and found a mighty band and many people, with Timotheus for their leader. He fought many battles with them, and they were defeated before his face. He struck them, and took possession of Jazer and its villages,[e] and returned again into Judea. The Gentiles who were in Gilead gathered themselves together against the Israelites who were on their borders, to destroy them. They fled to the stronghold of Dathema, and sent letters to Judas and his kindred, saying, "The Gentiles who are around us are gathered together against us to destroy us. They are preparing to come and get possession of the stronghold where we fled for refuge, and Timotheus is the leader of their army. Now therefore come and deliver us from their hand, for many of us have fallen. All our kindred who were in the land of [f]Tubias have been put to death. They have carried their wives, their children, and their stuff into captivity. They destroyed about a thousand men there." While the letters were still being read, behold, other messengers came from Galilee with their clothes torn, bringing a similar report, saying, "People of Ptolemais, of Tyre, of Sidon, and all Galilee of the[g] Gentiles have gathered together to destroy us." Now when Judas and the people heard these words, a great congregation assembled together to determine what they should do for their kindred who were in distress and under attack. Judas said to Simon his brother, "Choose men and go deliver your kindred who are in Galilee, but Jonathan my brother and I will go into the land of Gilead." He left Joseph the son of

[a] *4:40* Compare Numbers **31:6**.
[b] *4:40* Gr. trumpets of signals.
[c] *4:52* circa B.C. **165**.
[d] *5:4* Compare **2** Maccabees **10:18- 23**.
[e] *5:8* Gr. daughters. Compare Numbers **21:25**.
[f] *5:13* Compare **2** Maccabees **12:17**.
[g] *5:15* Gr. foreigners.

Zacharias, and Azarias, as leaders of the people, with the remnant of the army, in Judea, to guard it. He commanded them, saying, "Take charge of this people, and fight no battle with the Gentiles until we return." Then three thousand men were assigned to go into Galilee with Simon, but eight thousand men were assigned to Judas to go into the land of Gilead. Simon went into Galilee and fought many battles with the Gentiles, and the Gentiles were defeated before him. He pursued them to the gate of Ptolemais. About three thousand men of the Gentiles fell, and he took their spoils. They took to them those who were in Galilee and in Arbatta, with their wives, their children, and all that they had, and brought them into Judea with great gladness. Judas Maccabaeus and his brother Jonathan passed over the Jordan, and went three days' journey in the wilderness. They met with the Nabathaeans, and these met them in a peaceful manner and told them all things that had happened to their kindred in the land of Gilead, and how many of them were shut up in Bosora, Bosor, Alema, [a] Casphor, Maked, and[b] Carnaim—all these cities are strong and large— and how they were shut up in the rest of the cities of the land of Gilead, and that tomorrow they planned to encamp against the strongholds, and to take them, and to destroy all these men in one day. Judas and his army turned suddenly by the way of the wilderness to Bosora; and he took the city, and killed all the males with the edge of the sword, took all their spoils, and burned the city with fire. He left there at night, and went until he came to the stronghold. When the morning came, they lifted up their eyes and saw many people who couldn't be counted, bearing ladders and engines of war, to take the stronghold; and they were fighting against them. Judas saw that the battle had begun, and that the cry of the city went up to heaven, with trumpets and a great sound, and he said to the men of his army, "Fight today for your kindred!" Then he went out behind them in three companies. They sounded with their trumpets and cried out in prayer. And the army of Timotheus perceived that it was Maccabaeus, and they fled from before him. He struck them with a great slaughter. About eight thousand men of them fell on that day. He turned away to Mizpeh and fought against it, took it, killed all its males, took its spoils, and burned it with fire. From there he marched and took[c] Casphor, Maked, Bosor, and the other cities of the land of Gilead. Now after these things, Timotheus gathered another army and encamped near Raphon beyond the brook. Judas sent men to spy on the army; and they brought him word, saying, "All the Gentiles who are around us are gathered together to them, an exceedingly great army. They have hired Arabians to help them, and are encamped beyond the brook, ready to come against you to battle." So Judas went to meet them. Timotheus said to the captains of his army when Judas and his army drew near to the brook of water, "If he crosses over to us first, we won't be able to withstand him, for he will certainly defeat us; but if he is afraid, and encamps beyond the river, we will cross over to him, and defeat him." Now when Judas came near to the water brook, he caused the scribes of the people to remain by the brook, and commanded them, saying, "Allow no man to encamp, but let all come to the battle." Then he crossed over the first against them, and all the people after him; and all the Gentiles were defeated before his face, and threw away their weapons, and fled to the temple at [d] Carnaim. They took the city and burned the temple with fire, together with all who were in it. Carnaim was subdued. They couldn't stand any longer before the face of Judas. Judas gathered together all Israel, those who were in the land of Gilead, from the least to the greatest, with their wives, their children, and their stuff, an exceedingly great army, that they might come into the land of Judah. They came as far as Ephron, and this same city was large and very strong. It was on the road where they were going. They couldn't turn away from it on the right hand or on the left, but needed to pass through the middle of it. The people of the city shut them out and blocked the gates with stones. Judas sent to them with words of peace, saying, "We will pass through your land to go into our own land, and no one will harm you. We will only pass by on our feet." But they wouldn't open to him. Then Judas commanded proclamation to be made in the army, that each man should encamp in the place where he was. So the men of the army encamped, and fought against the city all that day and all that night, and the city was delivered into his hands. He destroyed all the males with the edge of the sword, razed the city, took its plunder, and passed through the city over those who were slain. They went over the Jordan into the great plain near Bethshan. And Judas gathered together those who lagged behind and encouraged the people all the way through, until he came into the land of Judah. They went up to mount Zion with gladness and joy, and offered whole burnt offerings, because not so much as one of them was slain until they returned in peace. In the days when Judas and Jonathan were in the land of Gilead, and Simon his brother in Galilee before Ptolemais, Joseph the son of Zacharias, and Azarias, rulers of the army, heard of their exploits and of the war, and what things they had done. They said, "Let's also get us a name, and

[a] *5:26* Compare **2** Maccabees **12:13**.

[b] *5:26* compare **2** Maccabees **12:21**.

[c] *5:36* See **1** Maccabees **5:26**

[d] *5:43* See **1** Maccabees **5:26**.

let's go fight against the Gentiles who are around us."
So they gave orders to the men of the army that was
with them, and went toward Jamnia. Gorgias and his
men came out of the city to meet them in battle.
Joseph and Azarias were put to flight, and were
pursued to the borders of Judea. About two thousand
men of Israel fell on that day. There was a great
overthrow among the people, because they didn't
listen to Judas and his kindred, thinking to do some
exploit. But they were not of the family of those men
by whose hand deliverance was given to Israel. The
man Judas and his kindred were glorified
exceedingly in the sight of all Israel, and of all the
Gentiles, wherever their name was heard of. Men
gathered together to them, acclaiming them. Judas
and his kindred went out and fought against the
children of Esau in the land toward the south. He
struck Hebron and its villages,[a] pulled down its
strongholds, and burned its towers all around. He
marched to go into the land of the[b] Philistines, and
he went through[c] Samaria. In that day certain priests,
desiring to do exploits there, were slain in battle,
when they went out to battle unadvisedly. But Judas
turned toward Azotus, to the land of the[d] Philistines,
pulled down their altars, burned the carved images of
their gods with fire, took the plunder of their cities,
and returned into the land of Judah.

6

King Antiochus was traveling through the upper
countries; and he heard that in Elymais in Persia
there was a city renowned for riches, for silver and
gold, and that the temple which was in it was
exceedingly rich, and that in it were golden shields,
breastplates, and weapons which Alexander, son of
Philip, the Macedonian king, who reigned first
among the Greeks, left behind there. So he came and
tried to take the city and to pillage it; and he was not
able, because his plan was known to them of the city,
and they rose up against him in battle. He fled and
returned to Babylon with great disappointment. Then
someone came into Persia bringing him news that the
armies which went against the land of Judah had
been put to flight, and that Lysias went first with a
strong army and was put to shame before them, and
that they had grown strong because of weapons,
power, and a supply of plunder which they took from
the armies that they had cut off, and that they had
pulled down the abomination which he had built
upon the altar that was in Jerusalem, and that they
had surrounded the sanctuary with high walls, as
before, and also Bethsura, his city. It came to pass,
when the king heard these words, he was astonished
and moved exceedingly. He laid himself down on his
bed, and fell sick for grief, because it had not turned
out for him as he had planned. He was there many
days, because great grief continually gripped him,
and he realized that he would die. He called for all
his[e] friends, and said to them, "Sleep departs from
my eyes, and my heart fails because of worry. I said
in my heart, 'To what suffering I have come! How
great a flood it is that I'm in, now! For I was gracious
and loved in my power.' But now I remember the
evils which I did at Jerusalem, and that I took all the
vessels of silver and gold that were in it, and sent out
to destroy the inhabitants of Judah without a cause. I
perceive that it is because of this that these evils have
come upon me. Behold, I am perishing through great
grief in a strange land." Then he called for Philip,
one of his[f] friends, and set him over all his kingdom.
He gave him his crown, his robe, and his signet ring,
so that he could guide Antiochus his son, and nourish
him up that he might be king. Then King Antiochus
died there in the one hundred forty-ninth year.[g]
When Lysias learned that the king was dead, he set
up Antiochus his son to reign, whom he had
nourished up being young, and he called his name
Eupator. Those who were in the citadel kept
hemming Israel in around the sanctuary, and always
sought to harm them and to strengthen the Gentiles.
Judas planned to destroy them, and called all the
people together to besiege them. They were gathered
together, and besieged them in[h] the one hundred
fiftieth year, and he made mounds to shoot from, and
engines of war. Some of those who were hemmed in
came out, and some of the ungodly men of Israel
were joined to them. They went to the king, and said,
"How long will you not execute judgment, and
avenge our kindred? We were willing to serve your
father and to live by his words, and to follow his
commandments. Because of this, the children of our
people besieged the citadel[i] and were alienated from
us; but as many of us as they could catch, they killed,
and plundered our inheritances. Not against us only
did they stretch out their hand, but also against all
their borders. Behold, they are encamped this day
against the citadel at Jerusalem to take it. They have
fortified the sanctuary and Bethsura. If you don't
quickly prevent them, they will do greater things than
these, and you won't be able to control them. When
the king heard this, he was angry, and gathered
together all his[j] friends, the rulers of his army, and
those who were over the cavalry. Bands of hired
soldiers came to him from other kingdoms and from
islands of the sea. The number of his forces was one
hundred thousand infantry, and twenty thousand
cavalry, and thirty-two elephants trained for war.

[a] *5:65* Gr. daughters. Compare Numbers **21:25**.
[b] *5:66* Gr. foreigners.
[c] *5:66* Or, Marisa See Josephus, Antiquities **12:8**. **6**, and **2** Maccabees **12:35**.
[d] *5:68* Gr. foreigners.
[e] *6:10* See **1** Maccabees **2:18**.
[f] *6:14* See **1** Maccabees **2:18**.
[g] *6:16* Circa B.C. **164**.
[h] *6:20* circa B.C. **163**.
[i] *6:24* Gr. it.
[j] *6:28* See **1** Maccabees **2:18**.

They went through Idumaea, and encamped against Bethsura, and fought against it many days, and made engines of war. The Jews came out and burned them with fire, and fought valiantly. Judas marched away from the citadel and encamped at Bethzacharias, near the king's camp. The king rose early in the morning, and marched his army[a] at full speed along the road to Bethzacharias. His forces made themselves ready to battle and sounded their trumpets. They offered the elephants the juice of grapes and mulberries, that they might prepare them for the battle. They distributed the animals among the phalanxes. They set by each elephant a thousand men armed with coats of mail and helmets of brass on their heads. Five hundred chosen cavalry were appointed for each elephant. These were ready beforehand, wherever the elephant was. Wherever the elephant went, they went with it. They didn't leave it. Strong, covered wooden towers were upon them, one upon each elephant, fastened upon it with secure harnesses. Upon each were four valiant men who fought upon them, beside his Indian driver. The rest of the cavalry he set on this side and that side on the two flanks of the army, striking terror into the enemy, and protected by the phalanxes. Now when the sun shone upon the shields of gold and brass, the mountains lit up, and blazed like flaming torches. A part of the king's army was spread upon the high hills and some on the low ground, and they went on firmly and in order. All who heard the noise of their multitude, the marching of the multitude, and the rattling of the weapons trembled; for the army was exceedingly great and strong. Judas and his army drew near for battle, and six hundred men of the king's army fell. Eleazar, who was called Avaran, saw one of the animals armed with royal breastplates, and it was taller than all the animals, and the king seemed to be on it. He gave his life to deliver his people, and to get himself an everlasting name. He ran upon him courageously into the midst of the phalanx, and killed on the right hand and on the left, and they parted away from him on this side and on that. He crept under the elephant, and stabbed it from beneath, and killed it. The elephant fell to the earth upon him, and he died there. They saw the strength of the kingdom and the fierce attack of the army, and turned away from them. But the soldiers of the king's army went up to Jerusalem to meet them, and the king encamped toward Judea and toward mount Zion. He made peace with the people of Bethsura. He came out of the city because they had no food there to endure the siege, because it was a Sabbath to the land. The king took Bethsura, and appointed a garrison there to keep it. He encamped against the sanctuary many days; and set there mounds to shoot from, and engines of war, and machines for throwing fire and stones, and weapons to throw darts, and slings. The Jews also made engines of war against their engines, and fought for many days. But there was no food in the sanctuary, because it was the seventh year, and those who fled for safety into Judea from among the Gentiles had eaten up the rest of the stores. There were only a few people left in the sanctuary, because the famine prevailed against them, and they were scattered, each man to his own place. Lysias heard that Philip, whom Antiochus the king, while he was yet alive, appointed to raise his son Antiochus to be king, had returned from Persia and Media, and with him the forces that went with the king, and that he was seeking to take control of the government. He made haste, and gave orders to depart. He said to the king and the leaders of the army and to the men, "We get weaker daily, our food is scant, the place where we encamp is strong, and the affairs of the kingdom lie upon us. Now therefore let's negotiate with these men, and make peace with them and with all their nation, and covenant with them, that they may walk after their own laws, as before; for because of their laws which we abolished they were angered, and did all these things." The speech pleased the king and the princes, and he sent to them to make peace; and they accepted it. The king and the princes swore to them. On these conditions, they came out from the stronghold. Then the king entered into mount Zion. He saw the strength of the place, and broke the oath which he had sworn, and gave orders to pull down the wall all around. Then he left in haste and returned to Antioch, and found Philip master of the city. He fought against him, and took the city by force.

7

In the one hundred fifty first year,[b] Demetrius the son of Seleucus came out of Rome, and went up with a few men to a city by the sea, and reigned there. It came to pass, when he would go into the house of the kingdom of his fathers, that the army laid hands on Antiochus and Lysias, to bring them to him. The thing became known to him, and he said, "Don't show me their faces!" So the army killed them. Then Demetrius sat upon the throne of his kingdom. All the lawless and ungodly men of Israel came to him. Alcimus was their leader, desiring to be high priest. They accused the people to the king, saying, "Judas and his kindred have destroyed all your friends, and have scattered us from our own land. Now therefore send a man whom you trust, and let him go and see all the destruction which he has brought on us and the king's country, and how he has punished them and all who helped them." So the king chose

[a] *6:33* Or, itself eager for the fight

[b] *7:1* circa B.C. **162**.

Bacchides, one of the king's[a] friends, who was ruler in the country beyond the river, and was a great man in the kingdom, and faithful to the king. He sent him and that ungodly Alcimus, whom he made the high priest; and he commanded him to take vengeance upon the children of Israel. They marched away and came with a great army into the land of Judah. He sent messengers to Judas and his kindred with words of peace deceitfully. They paid no attention to their words; for they saw that they had come with a great army. A group of scribes gathered together to Alcimus and Bacchides to seek just terms. The[b] Hasidaeans were the first among the children of Israel who sought peace from them, for they said, "One who is a priest of the seed of Aaron has come with the army, and he will do us no wrong." He spoke with them words of peace, and swore to them, saying, "We won't seek to harm you or your friends." They trusted him. Then he seized sixty men of them, and killed them in one day, according to the word which was written, [c] The flesh of your saints and their blood was shed all around Jerusalem, and there was no one to bury them. The fear and the dread of them fell upon all the people, for they said, "There is neither truth nor justice in them; for they have broken the covenant and the oath which they swore." Bacchides withdrew from Jerusalem, and encamped in Bezeth. He sent and seized many of the deserters who were with him, and some of the people, and he killed them, throwing them into a large pit. He placed Alcimus in charge of the country and left with him a force to aid him. Then Bacchides went away to the king. Alcimus struggled to maintain his high priesthood. All those who troubled their people joined him, and they took control of the land of Judah, and did great damage in Israel. Judas saw all the wrongs that Alcimus and his company had done among the children of Israel, even more than the Gentiles. He went out into all the borders of Judea and took vengeance on the men who had deserted from him, and they were restrained from going out into the country. But when Alcimus saw that Judas and his company had grown strong, and knew that he was not able to withstand them, he returned to the king, and brought evil accusations against them.
[d]Then the king sent Nicanor, one of his honorable princes, a man who hated Israel and was their enemy, and commanded him to destroy the people. Nicanor came to Jerusalem with a great army. He sent to Judas and his kindred deceitfully with words of peace, saying, "Let there be no battle between me and you; I will come with a few men, that I may see your faces in peace." He came to Judas, and they saluted one another peaceably. The enemies were ready to seize Judas by violence. This was known to Judas, that he came to him with deceit, and he was very afraid of him, and would see his face no more. Nicanor found out that his plan was disclosed; and he went out to meet Judas in battle beside Capharsalama. About five hundred men of Nicanor's army fell, and the rest fled into the city of David. After these things, Nicanor went up to mount Zion. Some of the priests came out of the sanctuary, with some of the elders of the people, to salute him peaceably, and to show him the whole burned sacrifice that was being offered for the king. He mocked them, laughed at them, derided them shamefully,[e] spoke arrogantly, and swore in a rage, saying, "Unless Judas and his army are now delivered into my hands, it shall be that, if I return safely, I will burn up this house!" And he went out in a great rage. The priests entered in, and stood before the altar and the temple; and they wept, and said, "You chose this house to be called by your name, to be a house of prayer and supplication for your people. Take vengeance on this man and his army, and let them fall by the sword. Remember their blasphemies, and don't allow them to live any longer." Then Nicanor went out from Jerusalem and encamped in Bethhoron, and there the Syrian army met him. Judas encamped in Adasa with three thousand men. Judas prayed and said, "When those who came from the king blasphemed, your angel went out, and struck among them one hundred eighty-five thousand. Even so, crush this army before us today, and let all the rest know that he has spoken wickedly against your sanctuary. Judge him according to his wickedness." On the thirteenth day of the month Adar, the armies met in battle. Nicanor's army was defeated, and he himself was the first to fall in the battle. Now when his army saw that Nicanor had fallen, they threw away their weapons and fled. They pursued them a day's journey from Adasa until you come to[f] Gazara, and they sounded an alarm after them with the signal trumpets. Men came out of all the surrounding villages of Judea, and outflanked them. These turned them back on those, and they all fell by the sword. There wasn't one of them left. The Jews took the spoils and the booty, and they cut off Nicanor's head and his right hand, which he had stretched out so arrogantly, and brought them, and hung them up beside Jerusalem. The people were exceedingly glad, and they kept that day as a day of great gladness.
[g]They ordained to keep this day year by year on the thirteenth day of Adar. So the land of Judah had rest a few days.

8

Judas heard of the fame of the Romans, that they are valiant men, and have pleasure in all who join

[a] *7:8* See **1** Maccabees **2:18**.
[b] *7:13* That is, Chasidim.
[c] *7:17* Psalms **79:2**, **3**.
[d] *7:26* See **2** Maccabees **14:12**.
[e] *7:34* Gr. polluted them.
[f] *7:45* Gr. Gazera.
[g] *7:49* See **2** Maccabees **15:36**.

themselves to them, and make friends with all who come to them, and that they are valiant men. They told him of their wars and exploits which they do among the Gauls, and how they conquered them, and forced them to pay tribute; and what things they did in the land of Spain, that they might take control of the silver and gold mines which were there; and how by their policy and persistence they conquered all the place (and the place was exceedingly far from them), and the kings who came against them from the uttermost part of the earth, until they had defeated them, and struck them severely; and how the rest give them tribute year by year. Philip, and Perseus, king of Chittim, and those who lifted up themselves against them, they defeated in battle, and conquered them. Antiochus also, the great king of Asia, came against them to battle, having one hundred twenty elephants, with cavalry, chariots, and an exceedingly great army, and he was defeated by them. They took him alive, and decreed that both he and those who reigned after him should give them a great tribute, and should give hostages, and a parcel of land from the best of their provinces: the countries of India, Media, and Lydia. They took them from him, and gave them to King Eumenes. Judas heard how the Greeks planned to come and destroy them, but this became known to them, and they sent against them a general who fought against them, and many of them fell down wounded to death, and they made captive their wives and their children, and plundered them, and conquered their land, and pulled down their strongholds, and plundered them, and brought them into bondage to this day. The remaining kingdoms and islands, as many as rose up against them at any time, they destroyed and made them to be their servants; but with their friends and those who relied on them they stayed friends. They conquered the kingdoms that were near and those that were far off, and all that heard of their fame were afraid of them. Moreover, whoever they desired to help and to make kings, these they make kings; and whoever they desired, they depose. They are exalted exceedingly. For all this, none of them ever put on a crown, neither did they clothe themselves with purple, as a display of grandeur. Judas heard how they had made for themselves a senate house, and day by day, three hundred twenty men sat in council, consulting always for the people, to the end they might be well governed, and how they commit their government to one man year by year, that he should rule over them, and control all their country, and all are obedient to that one, and there is neither envy nor emulation among them. So Judas chose Eupolemus the son of John, the son of Accos, and Jason the son of Eleazar, and sent them to Rome, to establish friendship and alliance with them, and that they should free the yoke from themselves; for they saw that the kingdom of the Greeks kept Israel in bondage. Then they went to Rome, a very long journey, and they entered into the senate house, and said, "Judas, who is also called Maccabaeus, and his kindred, and the people of the Jews, have sent us to you, to make an alliance and peace with you, and that we might be registered as your allies and friends." This thing was pleasing to them. This is the copy of the writing which they wrote back again on tables of brass, and sent to Jerusalem, that it might be with them there for a memorial of peace and alliance: "Good success be to the Romans, and to the nation of the Jews, by sea and by land forever. May the sword and the enemy be far from them. But if war arises for Rome first, or any of their allies in all their dominion, the nation of the Jews shall help them as allies, as the occasion shall indicate to them, with all their heart. To those who make war upon them, they shall not give supplies, food, weapons, money, or ships, as it has seemed good to Rome, and they shall keep their ordinances without taking anything in return. In the same way, moreover, if war comes first upon the nation of the Jews, the Romans shall willingly help them as allies, as the occasion shall indicate to them; and to those who are fighting with them, there shall not be given food, weapons, money, or ships, as it has seemed good to Rome. They shall keep these ordinances, and that without deceit. According to these terms, the Romans made a treaty with the Jewish people. But if hereafter the one party and the other shall determine to add or diminish anything, they shall do it at their pleasure, and whatever they add or take away shall be ratified. Concerning the evils which King Demetrius is doing to them, we have written to him, saying, 'Why have you made your yoke heavy on our friends and allies the Jews? If therefore they plead any more against you, we will do them justice, and fight with you on sea and on land.'"

9

Demetrius heard that Nicanor had fallen with his forces in battle, and he sent Bacchides and Alcimus again into the land of Judah a second time, and the right wing of his army with them. They went by the way that leads to Gilgal, and encamped against Mesaloth, which is in Arbela, and took possession of it, and killed many people. The first month of the one hundred fifty-second year, [a] they encamped against Jerusalem. Then they marched away and went to Berea with twenty thousand infantry and two thousand cavalry. Judas was encamped at Elasa with three thousand chosen men. They saw the multitude of the forces, that they were many, and they were

[a] *9:3* circa B.C. **161**.

terrified. Many slipped away out of the army. There were not left of them more than eight hundred men. Judas saw that his army slipped away and that the battle pressed upon him, and he was very troubled in spirit, because he had no time to gather them together, and he became faint. He said to those who were left, "Let's arise and go up against our adversaries, if perhaps we may be able to fight with them." They tried to dissuade him, saying, "There is no way we are able; but let's rather save our lives now. Let's return again with our kindred, and fight against them; but we are too few." Judas said, "Let it not be so that I should do this thing, to flee from them. If our time has come, let's die in a manly way for our kindred's sake, and not leave a cause of reproach against our honor." The army marched out from the camp, and stood to encounter them. The cavalry was divided into two companies, and the slingers and the archers went before the army, and all the mighty men that fought in the front of the battle. Bacchides was in the right wing. The phalanx advanced on the two parts, and they blew with their trumpets. The men by Judas' side sounded with their trumpets, and the earth shook with the shout of the armies, and the battle was joined, and continued from morning until evening. Judas saw that Bacchides and the strength of his army were on the right side, and all that were brave in heart went with him, and the right wing was defeated by them, and he pursued after them to the mount Azotus. Those who were on the left wing saw that the right wing was defeated, and they turned and followed in the footsteps of Judas and of those who were with him. The battle became desparate, and many on both sides fell wounded to death. Judas fell, and the rest fled. Jonathan and Simon took Judas their brother, and buried him in the tomb of his ancestors at Modin. They wept for him. All Israel made great lamentation for him, and mourned many days, and said, "How is the mighty fallen, the savior of Israel!" The rest of the acts of Judas, and his wars, and the valiant deeds which he did, and his greatness, are not written; for they were exceedingly many. It came to pass after the death of Judas, that the lawless emerged within all the borders of Israel. All those who did iniquity rose up. In those days there was an exceedingly great famine, and the country went over to their side. Bacchides chose the ungodly men and made them rulers of the country. They inquired and searched for the friends of Judas, and brought them to Bacchides, and he took vengeance on them and used them despitefully. There was great suffering in Israel, such as was not since the time prophets stopped appearing to them. All the friends of Judas were gathered together, and they said to Jonathan, "Since your brother Judas has died, we have no man like him to go out against our enemies and Bacchides, and among those of our nation who hate us. Now therefore we have chosen you this day to be our prince and leader in his place, that you may fight our battles." So Jonathan took the governance upon him at that time, and rose up in the place of his brother Judas. When Bacchides found out, he tried to kill him. Jonathan, and Simon his brother, and all who were with him, knew it; and they fled into the wilderness of Tekoah, and encamped by the water of the pool of Asphar. Bacchides found this out on the Sabbath day, and came—he and all his army—over the Jordan. Jonathan sent his brother, a leader of the multitude, and implored his friends the Nabathaeans, that they might store their baggage, which was much, with them. The children of Jambri came out of Medaba, and seized John and all that he had, and went their way with it. But after these things, they brought word to Jonathan and Simon his brother that the children of Jambri were celebrating a great wedding, and were bringing the bride, a daughter of one of the great nobles of Canaan, from Nadabath with a large escort. They remembered John their brother, and went up, and hid themselves under the cover of the mountain. They lifted up their eyes and looked, and saw a great procession with much baggage. The bridegroom came out with his friends and his kindred to meet them with timbrels, musicians, and many weapons. They rose up against them from their ambush and killed them, and many fell wounded to death. The remnant fled into the mountain, and the Jews took all their spoils. So the wedding was turned into mourning, and the voice of their musicians into lamentation. They avenged fully the blood of their brother, and turned back to the marshes of the Jordan. Bacchides heard it, and he came on the Sabbath day to the banks of Jordan with a great army. Jonathan said to his company, "Let's stand up now and fight for our lives, for things are different today than they were yesterday and the day before. For, behold, the battle is before us and behind us. Moreover the water of the Jordan is on this side and on that side, and marsh and thicket. There is no place to escape. Now therefore cry to heaven, that you may be delivered out of the hand of your enemies." So the battle was joined, and Jonathan stretched out his hand to strike Bacchides, and he turned away back from him. Jonathan and those who were with him leapt into the Jordan, and swam over to the other side. The enemy didn't pass over the Jordan against them. About a thousand men of Bacchides' company fell that day; and he returned to Jerusalem. They built strong cities in Judea, the stronghold that was in Jericho, and Emmaus, Bethhoron, Bethel, Timnath, Pharathon, and Tephon, with high walls and gates and bars. He set garrisons in them to harass Israel. He fortified the city

Bethsura, Gazara, and the citadel, and put troops and stores of food in them. He took the sons of the chief men of the country for hostages, and put them under guard in the citadel at Jerusalem. And in the one hundred fifty-third year,[a] in the second month, Alcimus gave orders to pull down the wall of the inner court of the sanctuary. He also pulled down the works of the prophets. He began to pull down. At that time was Alcimus stricken, and his works were hindered; and his mouth was stopped, and he was taken with a palsy, and he could no more speak anything and give orders concerning his house. Alcimus died at that time with great torment. Bacchides saw that Alcimus was dead, and he returned to the king. Then the land of Judah had rest for two years. Then all the lawless men took counsel, saying, "Behold, Jonathan and his men are dwelling at ease and in security. Now therefore we will bring Bacchides, and he will capture them all in one night. They went and consulted with him. He marched out and came with a great army, and sent letters secretly to all his allies who were in Judea, that they should seize Jonathan and those who were with him; but they couldn't, because their plan was known to them. Jonathan's men seized about fifty of the men of the country who were authors of the wickedness, and he killed them. Jonathan, Simon, and those who were with him, went away to Bethbasi, which is in the wilderness, and he built up that which had been pulled down, and they made it strong. Bacchides found out about it, and he gathered together all his multitude, and sent orders to those who were of Judea. He went and encamped against Bethbasi and fought against it many days, and made engines of war. Jonathan left his brother Simon in the city, and went out into the country, and he went with a few men. He struck Odomera and his kindred, and the children of Phasiron in their tents. They began to strike them, and to go up with their forces. Then Simon and those who were with him went out of the city, and set the engines of war on fire, and fought against Bacchides, and he was defeated by them. They afflicted him severely; for his counsel and expedition was in vain. They were very angry with the lawless men who gave him counsel to come into the country, and they killed many of them. Then he decided to depart into his own land. Jonathan learned of this and sent ambassadors to him, to the end that they should make peace with him, and that he should restore to them the captives. He accepted the thing, and did according to his words, and swore to him that he would not seek his harm all the days of his life. He restored to him the captives which he had taken before out of the land of Judah, and he returned and departed into his own land, and didn't come any more into their borders. Thus the sword ceased from Israel. Jonathan lived at Michmash. Jonathan began to judge the people; and he destroyed the ungodly out of Israel.

10

In the one hundred sixtieth year,[b] Alexander Epiphanes, the son of Antiochus, went up and took possession of Ptolemais. They received him, and he reigned there. King Demetrius heard about this, and he gathered together exceedingly great forces, and went out to meet him in battle. Demetrius sent a letter to Jonathan with words of peace, so as to honor him. For he said, "Let's go beforehand to make peace with them, before he makes peace with Alexander against us; for he will remember all the evils that we have done against him, and to his kindred and to his nation." So he gave him authority to gather together forces, and to provide weapons, and that he should be his ally. He also commanded that they should release the hostages that were in the citadel to him. Jonathan came to Jerusalem, and read the letter in the hearing of all the people, and of those who were in the citadel. They were very afraid when they heard that the king had given him authority to gather together an army. Those in the citadel released the hostages to Jonathan, and he restored them to their parents. Jonathan lived in Jerusalem and began to build and renew the city. He commanded those who did the work to build the walls and encircle Mount Zion with[c] square stones for defense; and they did so. The foreigners who were in the strongholds which Bacchides had built fled away. Each man left his place and departed into his own land. Only at Bethsura, there were left some of those who had forsaken the law and the commandments, for it was a place of refuge to them. King Alexander heard all the promises which Demetrius had sent to Jonathan. They told him of the battles and the valiant deeds which he and his kindred had done, and of the troubles which they had endured. So he said, "Could we find another man like him? Now we will make him our[d] friend and ally." He wrote a letter and sent it to him, in these words, saying, "King Alexander to his brother Jonathan, greetings. We have heard of you, that you are a mighty man of valour, and worthy to be our[e] friend. Now we have appointed you this day to be high priest of your nation, and to be called the king's[f] friend, and to take our side, and to keep friendship with us." He also sent to him a purple robe and a

[a] *9:54* circa B.C. **160**.
[b] *10:1* circa B.C. **153**.
[c] *10:11* So the versions and Josephus. Gr. four-foot stones.
[d] *10:16* See **1** Maccabees **2:18**. Compare **1** Maccabees **10:65**.
[e] *10:19* See **1** Maccabees **2:18**. Compare **1** Maccabees **10:65**.
[f] *10:20* See **1** Maccabees **2:18**. Compare **1** Maccabees **10:65**.

golden crown. And Jonathan put on the holy garments in the seventh month of the one hundred sixtieth year,[a] at the feast of tabernacles; and he gathered together forces and provided weapons in abundance. When Demetrius heard these things, he was grieved and said, "What is this that we have done, that Alexander has gotten ahead of us in establishing friendship with the Jews to strengthen himself? I also will write to them words of encouragement and of honor and of gifts, that they may be with me to aid me." So he sent to them this message: "King Demetrius to the nation of the Jews, greetings. Since as you have kept your covenants with us, and continued in our friendship, and have not joined yourselves to our enemies, we have heard of this, and are glad. Now continue still to keep faith with us, and we will repay you with good in return for your dealings with us. We will grant you many immunities and give you gifts. "Now I free you and release all the Jews from the tributes, from the salt tax, and from the crown levies. Instead of the third part of the seed, and instead of half of the fruit of the trees, which falls to me to receive, I release it from this day and henceforth, so that I will not take it from the land of Judah, and from the three districts which are added to it from the country of Samaria and Galilee, from this day forth and for all time. Let Jerusalem be holy and free, with her borders, tithes, and taxes. I yield up also my authority over the citadel which is at Jerusalem, and give it to the high priest, that he may appoint in it men whom he chooses to keep it. Every soul of the Jews who has been carried captive from the land of Judah into any part of my kingdom, I set at liberty without payment. Let all officials also cancel the taxes on their livestock. "All the feasts, the Sabbaths, new moons, appointed days, three days before a feast, and three days after a feast, let them all be days of immunity and release for all the Jews who are in my kingdom. No man shall have authority to exact anything from any of them, or to trouble them concerning any matter. "Let there be enrolled among the king's forces about thirty thousand men of the Jews, and pay shall be given to them, as is due to all the king's forces. Of them, some shall be placed in the king's great strongholds, and some of them shall be placed over the affairs of the kingdom, which are positions of trust. Let those who are over them and their rulers be of themselves, and let them walk after their own laws, even as the king has commanded in the land of Judah. "The three districts that have been added to Judea from the country of Samaria, let them be annexed to Judea, that they may be reckoned to be under one ruler, that they may not obey any other authority than the high priest's. As for Ptolemais and its land, I have given it as a gift to the sanctuary that is at Jerusalem, for the expenses of the sanctuary. I also give every year fifteen thousand shekels of silver from the king's revenues from the places that are appropriate. And all the additional funds which those who manage the king's affairs didn't pay as in the first years, they shall give from now on toward the works of the temple. Besides this, the five thousand shekels of silver which they received from the uses of the sanctuary from the revenue year by year is also released, because it belongs to the priests who minister there. Whoever flees to the temple that is at Jerusalem, and within all of its borders, whether one owe money to the king, or any other matter, let them go free, along with all that they have in my kingdom. For the building and renewing of the structures of the sanctuary, the expense shall also be given out of the king's revenue. For the building of the walls of Jerusalem and fortifying it all around, the expense shall also be given out of the king's revenue, also for the building of the walls in Judea." Now when Jonathan and the people heard these words, they gave no credence to them, and didn't accept them, because they remembered the great evil which he had done in Israel, and that he had afflicted them very severely. They were well pleased with Alexander, because he was the first who spoke words of peace to them, and they were allies with him always. King Alexander gathered together great forces and encamped near Demetrius. The two kings joined battle, and the army of Alexander fled; and Demetrius followed after him, and prevailed against them. He strengthened the battle exceedingly until the sun went down; and Demetrius fell that day. Alexander sent ambassadors to Ptolemy king of Egypt with this message: "Since I have returned to my kingdom, and am seated on the throne of my fathers, and have established my dominion, and have overthrown Demetrius, and have taken possession of our country— yes, I joined the battle with him, and he and his army were defeated by us, and we sat on the throne of his kingdom— now also let's make friends with one another. Give me now your daughter as my wife. I will be joined with you, and will give both you and her gifts worthy of you." Ptolemy the king answered, saying, "Happy is the day you returned to the land of your ancestors and sat on the throne of their kingdom. Now I will do to you as you have written, but meet me at Ptolemais, that we may see one another; and I will join with you, even as you have said." So Ptolemy went out of Egypt, himself and Cleopatra his daughter, and came to Ptolemais in the one hundred sixty-second year.[b] King Alexander met him, and he gave him his daughter Cleopatra, and celebrated her wedding at Ptolemais with great

[a] *10:21* circa B.C. **153**.

[b] *10:57* circa B.C. **151**.

pomp, as kings do. King Alexander wrote to Jonathan, that he should come to meet him. He went with pomp to Ptolemais, and met the two kings. He gave them and their friends[a] silver and gold, and many gifts, and found favor in their sight. Some malcontents out of Israel, men who were transgressors of the law, gathered together against him to complain against him; but the king paid no attention to them. The king commanded that they take off Jonathan's garments and clothe him in purple, and they did so. The king made him sit with him, and said to his princes, "Go out with him into the midst of the city, and proclaim that no man may complain against him of any matter, and let no man trouble him for any reason." It came to pass, when those who complained against him saw his honor according to the proclamation, and saw him clothed in purple, they all fled away. The king gave him honor, and enrolled him among his chief friends,[b] and made him a captain and governor of a province.

Then Jonathan returned to Jerusalem with peace and gladness. In the one hundred sixty-fifth year,[c] Demetrius, son of Demetrius, came out of Crete into the land of his ancestors. When King Alexander heard of it, he grieved exceedingly and returned to Antioch. Demetrius appointed Apollonius, who was over Coelesyria, and he gathered together a great army, and encamped against Jamnia, and sent to Jonathan the high priest, saying, "You alone lift up yourself against us, but I am ridiculed and in reproach because of you. Why do you assume authority against us in the mountains? Now therefore, if you trust in your forces, come down to us into the plain, and let's match strength with each other there; for the power of the cities is with me.

Ask and learn who I am, and the rest who help us. They say, 'Your foot can't stand before our face; for your ancestors have been put to flight twice in their own land.' Now you won't be able to withstand the cavalry and such an army as this in the plain, where is there is no stone or pebble, or place to flee." Now when Jonathan heard the words of Apollonius, he was moved in his mind, and he chose ten thousand men, and went out from Jerusalem; and Simon his brother met him to help him. Then he encamped against Joppa. The people of the city shut him out, because Apollonius had a garrison in Joppa. So they fought against it. The people of the city were afraid, and opened to him; and Jonathan became master of Joppa. Apollonius heard about that, and he gathered an army of three thousand cavalry, and a great army, and went to Azotus as though he were on a journey, and at the same time advanced onward into the plain, because he had a multitude of cavalry which he trusted. He pursued him to Azotus, and the armies joined battle.[d] Apollonius had secretly left a thousand cavalry behind them. Jonathan learned that there was an ambush behind him. They surrounded his army, and shot their arrows at the people, from morning until evening; but the people stood fast, as Jonathan commanded them; and the enemy's horses grew tired. Then Simon brought forward his army and joined battle with the phalanx (for the cavalry were exhausted), and they were defeated by him and fled. The cavalry were scattered in the plain. They fled to Azotus and entered into Beth-dagon, their idol's temple, to save themselves. Jonathan burned Azotus and the cities around it and took their spoils. He burned the temple of Dagon and those who fled into it with fire. Those who had fallen by the sword plus those who were burned were about eight thousand men. From there, Jonathan left and encamped against Ascalon. The people of the city came out to meet him with great pomp. Jonathan, with those who were on his side, returned to Jerusalem, having many spoils. It came to pass, when King Alexander heard these things, he honored Jonathan even more. He sent him a gold buckle, as the custom is to give to the king's kindred. He gave him Ekron and all its land for a possession.

11

Then the king of Egypt gathered together great forces, as the sand which is by the sea shore, and many ships, and sought to make himself master of Alexander's kingdom by deceit, and to add it to his own kingdom. He went out into Syria with words of peace, and the people of the cities opened their gates to him and met him; for King Alexander's command was that they should meet him, because he was his father-in-law. Now as he entered into the cities of Ptolemais, he set his forces for a garrison in each city.

But when he came near to Azotus, they showed him the temple of Dagon burned with fire, and Azotus and its pasture lands destroyed, and the bodies cast out, and those who had been burned, whom he burned in the war, for they had made heaps of them in his way. They told the king what Jonathan had done, that they might cast blame on him; but the king kept silent. Jonathan met the king with pomp at Joppa, and they greeted one another, and they slept there. Jonathan went with the king as far as the river that is called Eleutherus, then returned to Jerusalem.

But King Ptolemy took control of the cities along the sea coast, to Selucia which is by the sea, and he devised evil plans concerning Alexander. He sent ambassadors to King Demetrius, saying, "Come! Let's make a covenant with one another, and I will

[a] *10:60* See **1** Maccabees **2:18**. Compare **1** Maccabees **10:65**.

[b] *10:65* See **1** Maccabees **11:27**; **2** Maccabees **8:9**. Compare **1** Maccabees **2:18**; **10:16**, etc.

[c] *10:67* circa B.C. **148**.

[d] *10:78* Most of the authorities here repeat after him.

give you my daughter whom Alexander has, and you shall reign over your father's kingdom; for I regret that I gave my daughter to him, for he tried to kill me. He accused him, because he coveted his kingdom. Taking his daughter from him, he gave her to Demetrius, and was estranged from Alexander, and their enmity was openly seen. Ptolemy entered into Antioch, and put on himself the crown of Asia. He put two crowns upon his head, the crown of Egypt and that of Asia. But King Alexander was in Cilicia at that time, because the people of that region were in revolt. When Alexander heard of it, he came against him in war. Ptolemy marched out and met him with a strong force, and put him to flight. Alexander fled into Arabia, that he might be sheltered there; but King Ptolemy was triumphant. Zabdiel the Arabian took off Alexander's head, and sent it to Ptolemy. King Ptolemy died the third day after, and those who were in his strongholds were slain by the inhabitants of the strongholds. Demetrius became king in the one hundred sixty-seventh year.[a] In those days Jonathan gathered together the Judeans to take the citadel that was at Jerusalem. He made many engines of war to use against it. Some lawless men who hated their own nation went to the king and reported to him that Jonathan was besieging the citadel. He heard, and was angry, but when he heard it, he set out immediately, and came to Ptolemais, and wrote to Jonathan, that he should not besiege it, and that he should meet him and speak with him at Ptolemais with all speed. But when Jonathan heard this, he gave orders to continue the siege. He chose some of the elders of Israel and of the priests, and put himself in peril by taking silver, gold, clothing, and various other presents, and went to Ptolemais to the king. Then he found favor in his sight. Some lawless men of those who were of the nation made complaints against him, and the king did to him even as his predecessors had done to him, and exalted him in the sight of all his[b] friends, and confirmed to him the high priesthood, and all the other honors that he had before, and gave him preeminence among his[c] chief friends. And Jonathan requested of the king that he would make Judea free from tribute, along with the three[d] provinces and the country of Samaria, and promised him three hundred talents. The king consented, and wrote letters to Jonathan concerning all these things as follows: "King Demetrius to his brother Jonathan, and to the nation of the Jews, greetings. The copy of the letter which we wrote to Lasthenes our kinsman concerning you, we have written also to you, that you may see it. 'King Demetrius to Lasthenes his father, greetings. We have determined to do good to the nation of the Jews, who are our friends, and observe what is just toward us, because of their good will toward us. We have confirmed therefore to them the borders of Judea, and also the three governments of Aphaerema, Lydda, and Ramathaim (these were added to Judea from the country of Samaria), and all their territory to them, for all who do sacrifice in Jerusalem, instead of the king's dues which the king received of them yearly before from the produce of the earth and the fruits of trees. As for the other payments to us from henceforth, of the tithes and the taxes that pertain to us, and the salt pits, and the crown taxes due to us, all these we will give back to them. Not one of these grants shall be annulled from this time forth and forever. Now therefore be careful to make a copy of these things, and let it be given to Jonathan, and let it be set up on the holy mountain in a suitable and conspicuous place.'" When King Demetrius saw that the land was quiet before him, and that no resistance was made to him, he sent away all his troops, each man to his own place, except the foreign troops, which he had raised from the islands of the Gentiles. So all the troops of his fathers hated him. Now Tryphon was one of those who previously had been on Alexander's side, and he saw that all the forces murmured against Demetrius. So he went to Imalcue the Arabian, who was raising up Antiochus the young child of Alexander, and urgently insisted to him that he should deliver him to him, that he might reign in his father's place. He told him all that Demetrius had done, and the hatred with which his forces hated him; and he stayed there many days. Now Jonathan sent to King Demetrius, that he should remove the troops of the citadel from Jerusalem, and the troops who were in the strongholds; for they fought against Israel continually. Demetrius sent to Jonathan, saying, "I will not only do this for you and your nation, but I will greatly honor you and your nation, if I find an opportunity. Now therefore you shall do well if you send me men who will fight for me; for all my forces have revolted." So Jonathan sent him three thousand valiant men to Antioch. They came to the king, and the king was glad at their coming. The people of the city gathered themselves together into the midst of the city, to the number of one hundred and twenty thousand men, and they wanted to kill the king. The king fled into the court of the palace, and the people of the city seized the main streets of the city and began to fight. The king called the Jews to help him, and they were gathered together to him all at once, and they dispersed themselves in the city, and killed that day about one hundred thousand. They set the

[a] *11:19* circa B.C. **146**.
[b] *11:26* See **1** Maccabees **2:18**.
[c] *11:27* See **1** Maccabees **10:65**.
[d] *11:28* Gr. toparchies

city on fire, and seized many spoils that day, and saved the king. The people of the city saw that the Jews had taken control of the city as they pleased, and they became faint in their hearts, and they cried out to the king with supplication, saying, "Give us your right hand, and let the Jews cease from fighting against us and the city." They threw away their weapons and made peace. The Jews were glorified in the sight of the king, and before all who were in his kingdom. Then they returned to Jerusalem, having much plunder. So King Demetrius sat on the throne of his kingdom, and the land was quiet before him. He lied in all that he spoke, and estranged himself from Jonathan, and didn't repay him according to the benefits with which he had repaid him, and treated him very harshly. Now after this, Tryphon returned, and with him the young child Antiochus, who reigned and put on a crown. All the forces which Demetrius had sent away with disgrace were gathered to him, and they fought against him, and he fled and was routed. Tryphon took the elephants, and took control of Antioch. The young Antiochus wrote to Jonathan, saying, "I confirm to you the high priesthood, and appoint you over the four districts, and to be one of the king's[a] friends." He sent to him golden vessels and furniture for the table, and gave him permission to drink in golden vessels, and to be clothed in purple, and to have a golden buckle. He made his brother Simon governor from the Ladder of Tyre to the borders of Egypt. Jonathan went out and took his journey beyond the river and through the cities. All the forces of Syria gathered themselves to him to be his allies. He came to Ascalon, and the people of the city met him honorably. He departed from there to Gaza, and the people of Gaza shut him out. So he besieged it and burned its pasture lands with fire, and plundered them. The people of Gaza pleaded with Jonathan, and he gave them his right hand, and took the sons of their princes for hostages, and sent them away to Jerusalem. Then he passed through the country as far as Damascus. Then Jonathan heard that Demetrius' princes had come to Kedesh, which is in Galilee, with a great army, intending to remove him from his office. He went to meet them, but he left Simon his brother in the country. Simon encamped against Bethsura, and fought against it many days, and hemmed it in. They asked him to give them his right hand, and he gave it to them. He removed them from there, took possession of the city, and set a garrison over it. Jonathan and his army encamped at the water of Gennesareth, and early in the morning they marched to the plain of Hazor. Behold, an army of foreigners met him in the plain. They laid an ambush for him in the mountains, but they themselves met him face to face. But those who lay in ambush rose out of their places and joined battle. All those who were on Jonathan's side fled. Not one of them was left, except Mattathias the son of Absalom, and Judas the son of Chalphi, captains of the forces. Jonathan tore his clothes, put dirt on his head, and prayed. He turned again to them in battle, and routed them, and they fled. When the men on his side who had fled saw this, they returned to him and pursued with him to Kedesh to their camp, and they encamped there. About three thousand men of the foreigners fell on that day. Then Jonathan returned to Jerusalem.

12

Jonathan saw that the time was favorable for him, so he chose men and sent them to Rome to confirm and renew the friendship that they had with them. He also sent similar letters to the Spartans, and to other places. They went to Rome, entered into the senate house, and said, "Jonathan the high priest and the nation of the Jews have sent us to renew for them the friendship and the alliance, as in former time." They gave them letters to the men in every place, that they should provide safe conduct for them on their way to the land of Judah. This is the copy of the letters which Jonathan wrote to the Spartans: "Jonathan the high priest, and the senate of the nation, and the priests, and the rest of the people of the Jews, to their kindred the Spartans, greetings. Even before this time letters were sent to Onias the high priest from Arius,[b] who was reigning among you, to signify that you are our kindred, as the copy written below shows. Onias welcomed honorably the man who was sent and received the letters, wherein declaration was made of alliance and friendship. Therefore we also, even though we need none of these things, having for our encouragement the holy books which are in our hands, have undertaken to send that we might renew our brotherhood and friendship with you, to the end that we should not become estranged from you altogether; for a long time has passed since you sent your letter to us. We therefore at all times without ceasing, both in our feasts, and on the other convenient days, remember you in the sacrifices which we offer, and in our prayers, as it is right and proper to be mindful of kindred. Moreover, we are glad for your glory. But as for ourselves, many afflictions and many wars have encompassed us, and the kings who are around us have fought against us. We were unwilling to be troublesome to you, and to the rest of our allies and friends, in these wars; for we have the help which is from heaven to help us, and we have been delivered from our enemies, and our enemies have been humbled. We chose therefore

[a] *11:57* See **1** Maccabees **2:18**.

[b] *12:7* So the old Latin versions and Josephus: compare also ver. **20**. All the other authorities read Darius in this place.

Numenius the son of Antiochus and Antipater the son of Jason, and have sent them to the Romans, to renew the friendship that we had with them, and the former alliance. We commanded them therefore to go also to you, and to salute you, and to deliver you our letters concerning the renewing of friendship and our brotherhood. And now you will do well if you give us a reply." And this is the copy of the letters which they sent to Onias: "Arius king of the Spartans to Onias the chief priest, greetings. It has been found in writing, concerning the Spartans and the Jews, that they are kindred, and that they are of the descendants of Abraham. Now, since this has come to our knowledge, you will do well to write to us of your[a] prosperity. We moreover write on our part to you, that your livestock and goods are ours, and ours are yours. We do command therefore that they make report to you accordingly." Now Jonathan heard that Demetrius' princes had returned to fight against him with a greater army than before, so he marched away from Jerusalem, and met them in the country of Hamath; for he gave them no opportunity to set foot in his country. He sent spies into his camp, and they came again, and reported to him that they were preparing to attack them at night. But as soon as the sun was down, Jonathan commanded his men to watch, and to be armed, that all the night long they might be ready for battle. He stationed sentinels around the camp. The adversaries heard that Jonathan and his men were ready for battle, and they feared, and trembled in their hearts, and they kindled fires in their camp then withdrew. But Jonathan and his men didn't know it until the morning; for they saw the fires burning. Jonathan pursued after them, but didn't overtake them; for they had gone over the river Eleutherus. Then Jonathan turned toward the Arabians, who are called Zabadaeans, and struck them, and took their spoils. He came out from there, and came to Damascus, and took his journey through all the country. Simon went out, and took his journey as far as Ascalon, and the strongholds that were near it. Then he turned toward Joppa and took possession of it; for he had heard that they were planning to hand over the stronghold to Demetrius' men. He set a garrison there to guard it. Then Jonathan returned and called the elders of the people together. He planned with them to build strongholds in Judea, and to make the walls of Jerusalem higher, and to raise a great mound between the citadel and the city, to separate it from the city, that so it might be isolated, that its garrison might neither buy nor sell. They were gathered together to build the city. Part of the wall of the brook that is on the east side fell down, and he repaired the section called Chaphenatha. Simon also built Adida in the[b] plain country, made it strong, and set up gates and bars. And Tryphon sought to reign over Asia and to crown himself, and to stretch out his hand against Antiochus the king. He was afraid that Jonathan wouldn't allow him, and that he would fight against him; and he sought a way to seize him, that he might destroy him. So he marched out and came to Bethshan. Jonathan came out to meet him with forty thousand men chosen for battle, and came to Bethshan. Tryphon saw that he came with a great army, and he was afraid to stretch out his hand against him. He received him honorably, and commended him to all his[c] friends, and gave him gifts, and commanded his forces to be obedient to him, as to himself. He said to Jonathan, "Why have you put all this people to so much trouble, seeing there is no war between us? Now send them away to their homes, but choose for yourself a few men who shall be with you, and come with me to Ptolemais, and I will give it to you, and the rest of the strongholds and the rest of the forces, and all the king's officers. Then I will turn around and depart; for this is why I came." He put his trust in him, and did even as he said, and sent away his forces, and they departed into the land of Judah. But he reserved to himself three thousand men, of whom he left two thousand in Galilee, but one thousand went with him. Now as soon as Jonathan entered into Ptolemais, the people of Ptolemais shut the gates and seized him. They killed all those who came in with him with the sword. Tryphon sent troops and cavalry into Galilee, and into the Great Plain, to destroy all Jonathan's men. They perceived that he had been seized and had perished, along with those who were with him. They encouraged one another and went on their way close together, prepared to fight. Those who followed them saw that they were ready to fight for their lives, and turned back again. They all came in peace into the land of Judah, and they mourned for Jonathan and those who were with him, and they were very afraid. All Israel mourned with a great mourning. And all the Gentiles who were around them sought to destroy them utterly; for they said, "They have no ruler nor anyone to help them. Now therefore let's fight against them, and take away their memory from among men."

13

Simon heard that Tryphon had gathered together a mighty army to come into the land of Judah and destroy it utterly. He saw that the people were trembling in great fear. So he went up to Jerusalem and gathered the people together. He encouraged them, and said to them, "You yourselves know all the things that I, my kindred, and my father's house have done for the laws and the sanctuary, and the battles

[a] *12:22* Gr. peace | [b] *12:38* Gr. Sephela. | [c] *12:43* See **1** Maccabees **2:18**.

and the distresses which we have seen. Because of this, all my brothers have perished for Israel's sake, and I am left alone. Now be it far from me, that I should spare my own life in any time of affliction, for I am not better than my kindred. However, I will take vengeance for my nation, for the sanctuary, and for our wives and children, because all the Gentiles have gathered out of hatred to destroy us." The spirit of the people revived as soon as they heard these words. They answered with a loud voice, saying, "You are our leader in the place of Judas and Jonathan your brothers. Fight our battles, and we will do all that you tell us to do." He gathered together all the men of war, and hurried to finish the walls of Jerusalem. He fortified it all around. He sent Jonathan the son of Absalom, and with him a great army, to Joppa. He threw out those who were in it, and lived there. Tryphon left Ptolemais with a mighty army to enter into the land of Judah, and Jonathan was with him under guard. But Simon encamped at Adida, near the plain. Tryphon knew that Simon had risen up in the place of his brother Jonathan, and meant to join battle with him, so he sent ambassadors to him, saying, "It is for money which Jonathan your brother owed to the king's treasury, by reason of the offices which he had, that we are detaining him. Now send one hundred talents of silver and two of his sons for hostages, so that when he is released he may not revolt against us, and we will release him." Simon knew that they spoke to him deceitfully, but he sent to get the money and the children, lest perhaps he would arouse great hostility among the people, who might say, "Because I didn't send him the money and the children, he perished." So he sent the children and the hundred talents, but Tryphon lied, and didn't release Jonathan. After this, Tryphon came to invade the land and destroy it, and he went around by the way that leads to Adora. Simon and his army marched near him to every place, wherever he went. Now the people of the citadel sent to Tryphon ambassadors, urging him to come to them through the wilderness, and to send them food. So Tryphon prepared all his cavalry to come, but on that night a very heavy snow fell, and he didn't come because of the snow. He marched off and went into the land of Gilead. When he came near to Bascama, he killed Jonathan, and he was buried there. Then Tryphon turned back, and went away into his own land. Simon sent, and took the bones of Jonathan his brother, and buried him at Modin, the city of his fathers. All Israel made great lamentation over him, and mourned for him many days. Simon built a monument on the tomb of his father and his kindred, and raised it high so that it could be seen, with polished stone on the front and back. He also set up seven pyramids, one near another, for his father, his mother, and his four brothers. For these, he made an elaborate setting, erecting great pillars around them, and upon the pillars he made suits of armor for a perpetual memorial, and beside the suits of armor, he carved ships, so that they could be seen by all who sail on the sea. This is the tomb which he made at Modin. It remains to this day. Now Tryphon deceived the young King Antiochus and killed him, and reigned in his place. He put on himself the crown of Asia and brought a great calamity upon the land. Simon built up the strongholds of Judea, and walled them all around with high towers, great walls, gates, and bars; and he stored food in the strongholds. Simon chose men, and sent to King Demetrius with a request that he grant the country an immunity, because all that Tryphon did was to plunder. King Demetrius sent to him according to these words, and answered him, and wrote a letter to him, as follows: "King Demetrius to Simon the high priest and friend[a] of kings, and to the elders and nation of the Jews, greetings. The golden crown and the palm branch, which you sent, we have received. We are ready to make a steadfast peace with you, yes, and to write to our officers to release you from tribute. Whatever things we confirmed to you, they are confirmed. The strongholds, which you have built, let them be your own. As for any oversights and faults committed to this day, we forgive them, and the crown tax which you owed us. If there were any other tax collected in Jerusalem, let it be collected no longer. If any among you are qualified to be enrolled in our court, let them be enrolled, and let there be peace between us." In the one hundred seventieth year,[b] the yoke of the Gentiles was taken away from Israel. The people began to write in their instruments and contracts, "In the first year of Simon, the great high priest and captain and leader of the Jews." In those days Simon encamped against[c] Gazara, and surrounded it with troops. He made a seige engine, and brought it up to the city, and struck a tower, and captured it. Those who were in the engine leaped out into the city; and there was a great uproar in the city. The people of the city tore their clothes, and went up on the walls with their wives and children, and cried with a loud voice, asking Simon to give them[d] his right hand. They said, "Don't deal with us according to our wickednesses, but according to your mercy." So Simon was reconciled to them, and didn't fight against them; but he expelled them from the city and cleansed the houses where the idols were, and then entered into it with singing and giving praise. He removed all uncleanness out of it, and placed in it

[a] *13:36* See **1** Maccabees **2:18**.
[b] *13:41* circa B.C. **143**.
[c] *13:43* See **1** Maccabees **13:53** (compare **1** Maccabees **13:48**); **1** Maccabees **14:7**, **34**; **15:28**; **16:1**: also Josephus. All the authorities read Gaza in this verse.
[d] *13:45* Gr. right hands.

men who would keep the law, and made it stronger than it was before, and built a dwelling place for himself in it. But the people of the citadel in Jerusalem were hindered from going out and from going into the country, and from buying and selling. So they were very hungry, and a great number of them perished from famine. Then they cried out to Simon, that he should give them his right hand; and he gave it to them; but he expelled them from there, and he cleansed the citadel from its pollutions. He entered into it on the twenty-third day of the second month, in the one hundred seventy-first year,[a] with praise and palm branches, with harps, with cymbals, and with stringed instruments, with hymns, and with songs, because a great enemy had been destroyed out of Israel. Simon ordained that they should keep that day every year with gladness. He made the hill of the temple that was by the citadel stronger than before, and he lived there with his men. Simon saw that his son John was a man, so he made him leader of all his forces; and he lived in Gazara.

14

In the one hundred seventy-second year,[b] King Demetrius gathered his forces together, and went into Media to get help, that he might fight against Tryphon. When Arsaces, the king of Persia and Media, heard that Demetrius had come into his borders, he sent one of his princes to take him alive. He went and struck the army of Demetrius, and seized him and brought him to Arsaces, who put him under guard. The land had rest all the days of Simon. He sought the good of his nation. His authority and his honor was pleasing to them all his days. Amid all his honors, he took Joppa for a harbor, and made it an entrance for the islands of the sea. He enlarged the borders of his nation and took possession of the country. He gathered together a great number of captives, and took control of Gazara, Bethsura, and the citadel, and he removed its uncleannesses from it. There was no one who resisted him. They tilled their land in peace, and the land gave her increase, and the trees of the plains gave their fruit. The old men sat in the streets; they all conversed together about good things. The young men put on glorious and warlike apparel. He provided food for the cities and furnished them with means of defense, until the glory of his name was known to the end of the earth. He made peace in the land, and Israel rejoiced with great joy. Each man sat under his vine and his fig tree, and there was no one to make them afraid. No one was left in the land who fought against them. The kings were defeated in those days. He strengthened all those of his people who were humble. He searched out the law, and every lawless and wicked person he took away. He glorified the sanctuary, and added to the vessels of the temple. It was heard at Rome that Jonathan was dead, and even in Sparta, and they were exceedingly grieved. But as soon as they heard that his brother Simon was made high priest in his place, and ruled the country and the cities in it, they wrote to him on brass tablets to renew with him the friendship and the alliance which they had confirmed with his brothers Judas and Jonathan. These were read before the congregation at Jerusalem. This is the copy of the letters which the Spartans sent: "The rulers and the city of the Spartans, to Simon the high priest, to the elders, the priests, and the rest of the people of the Jews, our kindred, greetings. The ambassadors who were sent to our people reported to us about your glory and honor. We were glad for their coming, and we registered the things that were spoken by them in the public records[c] as follows: 'Numenius son of Antiochus, and Antipater son of Jason, the Jews' ambassadors, came to us to renew the friendship they had with us. It pleased the people to entertain the men honorably, and to put the copy of their words in the public records,[d] to the end that the people of the Spartans might have a record of them. Moreover they wrote a copy of these things to Simon the high priest.'" After this, Simon sent Numenius to Rome with a great shield of gold of weighing one thousand minas,[e] in order to confirm the alliance with them. But when the people heard these things, they said, "What thanks shall we give to Simon and his sons? For he and his brothers and the house of his father have made themselves strong, and have fought and chased away Israel's enemies, and confirmed liberty to Israel.[f]" So they wrote on tablets of brass, and set them on pillars on mount Zion. This is the copy of the writing: "On the eighteenth day of Elul, in the one hundred seventy-second year,[g] which is the third year of Simon the high priest, in Asaramel, in a great congregation of priests and people and princes of the nation, and of the elders of the country, it was proclaimed to us:[h] 'Since wars often occurred in the country, Simon the son of Mattathias, the son of the sons of Joarib, and his brothers, put themselves in jeopardy and withstood the enemies of their nation, that their sanctuary and the law might be established, and glorified their nation with great glory. Jonathan rallied the nation, became their high priest, and was gathered to his people. Their enemies planned to invade their country, that they might destroy their

[a] *13:51* circa B.C. **142**.
[b] *14:1* circa B.C. **141**.
[c] *14:22* Gr. counsels of the people.
[d] *14:23* Gr. books that are appointed for the people.
[e] *14:24* **1**, **000** minas is about **499** kg or **1**, **098** pounds.
[f] *14:26* Gr. him.
[g] *14:27* circa B.C. **141**.
[h] *14:28* Gr. he made known.

country utterly, and stretch out their hands against their sanctuary. Then Simon rose up and fought for his nation. He spent much of his own money to arm the valiant men of his nation and give them wages. He fortified the cities of Judea and Bethsura that lies on the borders of Judea, where the weapons of the enemies were had been stored, and there he placed a garrison of Jews. He fortified Joppa which is upon the sea, and Gazara which is upon the borders of Azotus, where the enemies used to live, and placed Jews there, and set in there all things necessary for their restoration. The people saw Simon's faith,[a] and the glory which he resolved to bring to his nation, and they made him their leader and high priest, because he had done all these things, and for the justice and the faith which he kept to his nation, and because he sought by all means to exalt his people. In his days, things prospered in his hands, so that the Gentiles were taken away out of their country, and they also who were in the city of David, those who were in Jerusalem, who had made themselves a citadel, out of which they used to go, and polluted everything around the sanctuary, and did great damage to its purity. He placed Jews in it and fortified it for the safety of the country and the city, and made high the walls of Jerusalem. King Demetrius confirmed to him the high priesthood according to these things, and made him one of his friends,[b] and honored him with great honor; for he had heard that the Jews had been called by the Romans friends, allies, and kindred, and that they had met the ambassadors of Simon honorably; and that the Jews and the priests were well pleased that Simon should be their leader and high priest forever, until there should arise a faithful prophet; and that he should be governor over them, and should take charge of the sanctuary, to set them over their works, and over the country, and over the weapons, and over the strongholds; and that he should take charge of the sanctuary, and that he should be obeyed by all, and that all contracts in the country should be written in his name, and that he should be clothed in purple, and wear gold; and that it should not be lawful for any of the people or of the priests to nullify any of these things, or to oppose the words that he should speak, or to gather an assembly in the country without him, or to be clothed in purple, or wear a buckle of gold; but whoever should do otherwise, or nullify any of these things, he will be liable to punishment.'" All the people consented to ordain for Simon that he should do according to these words. So Simon accepted this, and consented to be high priest, and to be captain and governor[c] of the Jews and of the priests, and to be protector of all. They commanded to put this writing on tablets of brass, and to set them up within the precinct of the sanctuary in a conspicuous place, and moreover to put copies of them in the treasury, so that Simon and his sons might have them.

15

Antiochus son of Demetrius the king sent a letter from the islands of the sea to Simon the priest and[d] governor of the Jews, and to all the nation. Its contents follow: "King Antiochus to Simon the chief priest and[e] governor, and to the nation of the Jews, greetings. Whereas certain troublemakers have made themselves masters of the kingdom of our fathers, but my purpose is to claim the kingdom, that I may restore it as it was before; and moreover I have raised a multitude of foreign soldiers, and have prepared warships; moreover I plan to land in the country, that I may punish those who have destroyed our country, and those who have made many cities in the kingdom desolate; now therefore I confirm to you all the tax remissions which the kings who were before me remitted to you, and whatever gifts besides they remitted to you, and I permit you to coin money for your country with your own stamp, but that Jerusalem and the sanctuary should be free. All the weapons that you have prepared, and the strongholds that you have built, which you have in your possession, let them remain yours. Every debt owed to the king, and the things that will be owed to the king from henceforth and for evermore, let them be remitted to you. Moreover, when we have established our kingdom, we will glorify you and your nation and the temple with great glory, so that your glory will be made manifest in all the earth. In the one hundred seventy-fourth year,[f] Antiochus went into the land of his fathers; and all the forces came together to him, so that there were few men with Tryphon. King Antiochus pursued him, and he came, as he fled, to Dor, which is by the sea; for he knew that troubles had come upon him all at once, and that his forces had deserted him. Antiochus encamped against Dor, and with him one hundred twenty thousand men of war and eight thousand cavalry. He surrounded the city, and the ships joined in the attack from the sea. He harassed the city by land and sea, and permitted no one to go out or in. Numenius and his company came from Rome, having letters to the kings and to the countries, in which were written these things: "Lucius, consul of the Romans, to King Ptolemy, greetings. The Jews' ambassadors came to us as our friends and allies, to renew the old friendship and alliance, being sent from Simon the high priest, and from the people of the Jews. Moreover they brought a shield of gold

[a] *14:35* Some authorities read acts.
[b] *14:39* See **1** Maccabees **2:18**.
[c] *14:47* Gr. ethnarch.
[d] *15:1* Gr. ethnarch.
[e] *15:2* Gr. ethnarch.
[f] *15:10* circa B.C. **139**

weighing one thousand minas.[a] It pleased us therefore to write to the kings and to the countries, that they should not seek their harm or fight against them, their cities, and their country, or be allies with those who fight against them. Moreover, it seemed good to us to receive the shield from them. If therefore any troublemakers have fled from their country to you, deliver them to Simon the high priest, that he may take vengeance on them according to their law." He wrote the same things to King Demetrius, to Attalus, to Arathes, to Arsaces, to all the countries, to[b] Sampsames, to the Spartans, to Delos, to Myndos, to Sicyon, to Caria, to Samos, to Pamphylia, to Lycia, to Halicarnassus, to Rhodes, to Phaselis, to Cos, to Side, to Aradus, Gortyna, Cnidus, Cyprus, and Cyrene. They also wrote this copy to Simon the high priest. But King Antiochus encamped against Dor the second day, bringing his forces up to it continually, and making engines of war; and he shut up Tryphon from going in or out. Simon sent him two thousand chosen men to fight on his side, with silver, gold, and instruments of war in abundance. He would not receive them, but nullified all the covenants which he had made with him before, and was estranged from him. He sent to him Athenobius, one of his friends,[c] to confer with him, saying, "You hold possession of Joppa, Gazara, and the citadel that is in Jerusalem, cities of my kingdom. You have devastated their territory, and done great harm in the land, and control of many places in my kingdom. Now therefore hand over the cities which you have taken, and the tributes of the places which you have taken control of outside of the borders of Judea; or else give me for them five hundred talents of silver; and for the harm that you have done, and the tributes of the cities, another five hundred talents. Otherwise we will come and subdue you." Athenobius, the king's friend,[d] came to Jerusalem. When he saw the glory of Simon, the cupboard of gold and silver vessels, and his great attendance, he was amazed. He reported to him the king's words. Simon answered, and said to him, "We have not taken other men's land nor do we have possession of that which belongs to others, but of the inheritance of our fathers. However, it had been in possession of our enemies wrongfully for a while. But we, having opportunity, firmly hold the inheritance of our fathers. As for Joppa and Gazara, which you demand, they did great harm among the people throughout our country. We will give one hundred talents for them." Athenobius didn't answer even one word, but returned in a rage to the king, and reported to him these words, and the glory of Simon, and all that he had seen; and the king was exceedingly angry. Meanwhile, Tryphon embarked on board a ship, and fled to Orthosia. The king appointed Cendebaeus chief captain of the sea coast, and gave him troops of infantry and cavalry. He commanded him to encamp against Judea, and he commanded him to build up Kidron, and to fortify the gates, and that he should fight against the people; but the king pursued Tryphon. So Cendebaeus came to Jamnia and began to provoke the people, and to invade Judea, and to take the people captive and kill them. He built Kidron and stationed cavalry and infantry there, to the end that going out they might make raids on the highways of Judea, as the king had commanded him.

16

John went up from Gazara and told Simon his father what Cendebaeus was doing. Simon called his two oldest sons, Judas and John, and said to them, "I and my brothers and my father's house have fought the battles of Israel from our youth, even to this day; and things have prospered in our hands, that we have often delivered Israel. But now I am old, and you moreover, by his mercy, are of a sufficient age. Take the place of me and my brother, and go out and fight for our nation; and let the help which is from heaven be with you. He chose out of the country twenty thousand men of war and cavalry, and they went against Cendebaeus, and slept at Modin. Rising up in the morning, they went into the plain, and, behold, a great army of infantry and cavalry came to meet them. There was a brook between them. He encamped near them, he and his people. He saw that the people were afraid to pass over the brook, and he passed over first. When the men saw him, they passed over after him. He divided the people, and placed the calvary in the midst of the infantry; but the enemies' cavalry were exceedingly many. They sounded the trumpets; and Cendebaeus and his army were put to flight, and many of them fell wounded to death, but those who were left fled to the stronghold. At that time Judas, John's brother, was wounded; but John pursued after them until he came to Kidron, which Cendebaeus had built. They fled to the towers that are in the fields of Azotus; and he burned it with fire. About two thousand men men of them fell. Then he returned into Judea in peace. Ptolemy the son of Abubus had been appointed governor over the plain of Jericho, and he had much silver and gold; for he was the high priest's son-in-law. His heart was lifted up, and he planned to make himself master of the country, and he made deceitful plans against Simon

[a] *15:18* **1**, **000** minas is about **499** kg. or about **1**, **098** pounds.

[b] *15:23* Some authorities read Sampsaces: the Latin versions have Lampsacus.

[c] *15:28* See **1** Maccabees **2:18**.

[d] *15:32* See **1** Maccabees **2:18**.

and his sons, to do away with them. Now Simon was visiting the cities that were in the country, and attending to their needs. He went down to Jericho—himself with Mattathias and Judas his sons—in the one hundred seventy-seventh year,[a] in the eleventh month, which is the month Sebat. The son of Abubus received them deceitfully into the little stronghold that is called Dok, which he had built, and made them a great banquet, and hid men there. When Simon and his sons had drunk freely, Ptolemy and his men rose up, took their weapons, rushed in against Simon in the banqueting place, and killed him, his two sons, and some of his servants. He committed a great iniquity, and repaid evil for good. Ptolemy wrote these things and sent to the king, that he should send him forces to aid him, and should deliver him their country and the cities. He sent others to Gazara to do away with John. To the captains of thousands, he sent letters to come to him, that he might give them silver, gold, and gifts. He sent others to take possession of Jerusalem and the temple hill. One ran before to Gazara, and told John that his father and kindred had perished, and he has sent to kill you also. When he heard, he was greatly shocked. He seized the men who came to destroy him and killed them; for he perceived that they were seeking to destroy him. And the rest of the acts of John and of his wars and of his valiant deeds which he did, and of the building of the walls which he built, and of his achievements, behold, they are written in the chronicles [b] of his high priesthood, from the time that he was made high priest after his father.

[a] *16:14* circa B.C. **136**.

[b] *16:24* Gr. book of days.

The Second Book of the Maccabees

The Second Book of the Maccabees is recognized as Deuterocanonical Scripture by the Roman Catholic, Greek Orthodox, and Russian Orthodox Churches.

1

The kindred, the Jews who are in Jerusalem and those who are in the country of Judea, send greetings and good peace to the kindred, the Jews who are throughout Egypt. May God do good to you, and remember his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, his faithful servants, and give you all a heart to worship him and do his will with a strong heart and a willing soul. May God open your heart to his law and his statutes, and make peace, and listen to your requests, and be reconciled with you, and not forsake you in an evil time. Now we are praying for you here. In the reign of Demetrius, in the one hundred sixty-ninth year, we the Jews have already written to you in the suffering and in the distress that has come upon us in these years, from the time that Jason and his company revolted from the holy land and the kingdom, and set the gate on fire, and shed innocent blood. We prayed to the Lord, and were heard. We offered sacrifices and meal offerings. We lit the lamps. We set out the show bread.[a] Now see that you keep the days of the feast of tabernacles in the month Chislev in the one hundred eighty-eighth year. The people of Jerusalem and those who are in Judea, with the senate and Judas, to Aristobulus, King Ptolemy's teacher, who is also of the stock of the anointed priests, and to the Jews who are in Egypt, we send greetings and health. Having been saved by God out of great perils, as men arrayed against a king, we thank him greatly. For he threw out into Persia those who fought against us in the holy city. For when the prince had come there, with an army that seemed irresistible, they were cut to pieces in the temple of Nanaea by the treachery of Nanaea's priests. For Antiochus, on the pretense that he would marry her, came into the place, he and his friends who were with him, that they might take a large part of the treasures as a dowry. And when the priests of Nanaea's temple had set the treasures out, and he had come there with a small company within the wall of the sacred precinct, they locked the temple when Antiochus had come in. Opening the secret door of the panelled ceiling, they threw stones and struck down the prince. They cut him and his company in pieces, and cut off their heads, and threw them to the people who were outside. Blessed be our God in all things, who handed over those who had committed impiety. Since we are now about to celebrate the purification of the temple in the month Chislev, on the twenty-fifth day, we thought it necessary to notify you, so that you may also keep a feast of tabernacles, and remember the fire which was given when Nehemiah offered sacrifices, after he had built both the temple and the altar. For indeed when our fathers were about to be led into the land of Persia, the godly priests of that time took some of the fire of the altar, and hid it secretly in the hollow of a well that was without water, where they made sure that the place was unknown to anyone. Now after many years, when it pleased God, Nehemiah, having received a charge from the king of Persia, sent in quest of the fire the descendants of the priests who hid it. When they declared to us that they had found no fire, but thick liquid, he commanded them to draw some of it out and bring it to him. When the sacrifices had been offered, Nehemiah commanded the priests to sprinkle with that liquid both the wood and the things laid on it. When that was done and some time had passed, and the sun shone out, which before was hidden with clouds, a great blaze was kindled, so that all men marveled. The priests made a prayer while the sacrifice was being consumed—both the priests and all the others. Jonathan led and the rest responded, as Nehemiah did. The prayer was like this: "O Lord, Lord God, the Creator of all things, who are awesome, strong, righteous, and merciful, who alone are King and gracious, who alone supply every need, who alone are righteous, almighty, and eternal, you who save Israel out of all evil, who chose the ancestors and sanctified them, accept the sacrifice for all your people Israel, and preserve your own portion, and consecrate it. Gather together our scattered people, set at liberty those who are in bondage among the heathen, look upon those who are despised and abhorred, and let the heathen know that you are our God. Punish those who oppress us and in arrogance shamefully entreat us. Plant your people in your holy place, even as Moses said." Then the priests sang the hymns. As soon as the sacrifice was consumed, then Nehemiah commanded that the rest of the liquid be poured on large stones. When this was done, a flame was kindled; but when the light from the altar shone back, it went out. When the matter became known, and it was told the king of the Persians that, in the place where the priests who were led away had hid the fire, the liquid appeared which Nehemiah and those who were with him purified the sacrifice, then the king enclosed the place and made it sacred after he had investigated the matter. When the king would show favor to any, he would exchange many presents and give them some of this liquid. Nehemiah and those who were with him called this thing "Nephthar", which is by

[a] *1:8* Gr. loaves

interpretation, "Cleansing"; but most men call it Nephthai.

2

It is also found in the records that Jeremiah the prophet commanded those who were carried away to take some of the fire, as has been mentioned, and how that the prophet charged those who were carried away, having given them the law, that they should not forget the statutes of the Lord or be led astray in their minds when they saw images of gold and silver, and their adornment. With other such words exhorted he them, that the law should not depart from their hearts. It was in the writing that the prophet, being warned by God, commanded that the tabernacle and the ark should follow with him,[a] when he went out to the mountain where Moses had gone up and saw God's inheritance. Jeremiah came and found a cave, he brought the tabernacle, the ark, and the altar of incense into it; then he sealed the entrance. Some of those who followed with him came there that they might mark the way, and could not find it. But when Jeremiah learned about that, he rebuked them, saying, "The place shall be unknown until God gathers the people together again and shows mercy. Then the Lord will disclose these things, and the glory of the Lord shall be seen with the cloud, as it was also shown to Moses, also as Solomon implored that the place might be consecrated greatly, and it was also declared that he, having wisdom, offered a sacrifice of dedication, and of the finishing of the temple. As Moses prayed to the Lord and fire came down out of heaven and consumed the sacrifice, even so Solomon also prayed, and the fire came down and consumed the burnt offerings. [b] Moses said, 'Because the sin offering had not been eaten, it was consumed in like manner.' Likewise Solomon kept the eight days." The same things were reported both in the public archives and in Nehemiah's records, and also how he, founding a library, gathered together the books about the kings and prophets, and the writings of David, and letters of kings about sacred gifts. In like manner Judas also gathered together for us all those books that had been scattered by reason of the war, and they are still with us. If therefore you have need of them, send some people to bring them to you. Seeing then that we are about to celebrate the purification, we write to you. You will therefore do well if you celebrate the days. Now God, who saved all his people, and restored the heritage to all, with the kingdom, the priesthood, and the consecration, even as he promised through the law—in God have we hope, that he will soon have mercy upon us, and gather us together out of everywhere under heaven into his holy place; for he delivered us out of great evils, and purified the place. Now the things concerning Judas Maccabaeus and his brothers, the purification of the greatest temple, the dedication of the altar, and further the wars against Antiochus Epiphanes and Eupator his son, and the manifestations that came from heaven to those who fought with one another in brave deeds for the religion of the Jews; so that, being but a few, they seized the whole country, chased the barbarous multitudes, recovered again the temple renowned all the world over, freed the city, and restored the laws which were about to be overthrown, seeing the Lord became gracious to them with all kindness. These things which have been declared by Jason of Cyrene in five books, we will attempt to abridge in one book. For having in view the confused mass of the numbers, and the[c] difficulty which awaits those who would enter into the narratives of the history, by reason of the abundance of the matter, we were careful that those who choose to read may be attracted, and that those who wish us well may find it easy to recall, and that all readers may benefit. Although to us, who have taken upon ourselves the painful labor of the abridgement, the task is not easy, but a matter of sweat and sleeplessness, even as it is no light thing to him who prepares a banquet, and seeks the benefit of others. Nevertheless, for the sake of the gratitude of the many we will gladly endure the painful labor, leaving to the historian the exact handling of every particular, and again having no strength to fill in the outlines of our abridgement. For as the masterbuilder of a new house must care for the whole structure, and again he who undertakes to decorate and paint it must seek out the things fit for its adorning; even so I think it is also with us. To occupy the ground, and to indulge in long discussions, and to be curious in particulars, is fitting for the first author of the history; but to strive after brevity of expression, and to avoid a labored fullness in the treatment, is to be granted to him who would bring a writing into a new form. Here then let's begin the narration, only adding this much to that which has already been said; for it is a foolish thing to make a long prologue to the history, and to abridge the history itself.

3

When the holy city was inhabited with unbroken peace and the laws were kept very well because of the godliness of Onias the high priest and his hatred of wickedness, it came to pass that even the kings themselves honored the place and glorified the temple with the noblest presents, so that even King Seleucus of Asia bore all the costs belonging to the services of the sacrifices out of his own revenues. But a man named Simon of the tribe of Benjamin,

[a] *2:4* Gr. and when. The Greek text here is probably corrupt.

[b] *2:11* See Leviticus **10:16** and **9:24**.

[c] *2:24* Or, weariness

having been made guardian of the temple, disagreed with the high priest about the ruling of the market in the city. When he couldn't overcome Onias, he went to Apollonius of [a] Tarsus, who at that time was governor of Coelesyria and Phoenicia. He brought him word how that the treasury in Jerusalem was full of untold sums of money, so that the multitude of the funds was innumerable, and that they didn't pertain to the account of the sacrifices, but that it was possible that these should fall under the king's power. When Apollonius met the king, he informed him of the money about which he had been told. So the king appointed Heliodorus, who was his chancellor, and sent him with a command to accomplish the removal of the reported money. So Heliodorus set out on his journey at once, ostensibly to visit the cities of Coelesyria and Phoenicia, but in fact to execute the king's purpose. When he had come to Jerusalem and had been courteously received by the high priest of the city, he told him about the information which had been given, and declared why he had come; and he inquired if in truth these things were so. The high priest explained to him that there were in the treasury deposits of widows and orphans, and moreover some money belonging to Hyrcanus the son of Tobias, a man in very high place, not as that impious Simon falsely alleged; and that in all there were four hundred talents of silver and two hundred of gold, and that it was altogether impossible that wrong should be done to those who had put trust in the holiness of the place, and in the majesty and inviolable sanctity of the temple, honored over all the world. But Heliodorus, because of the king's command given him, said that in any case this money must be confiscated for the king's treasury. So having appointed a day, he entered in to direct the inquiry concerning these matters; and there was no small distress throughout the whole city. The priests, prostrating themselves before the altar in their priestly garments, and called toward heaven upon him who gave the law concerning deposits, that he should preserve these treasures safe for those who had deposited them. Whoever saw the appearance of the high priest was wounded in mind; for his countenance and the change of his color betrayed the distress of his soul. For a terror and a shuddering of the body had come over the man, by which the pain that was in his heart was plainly shown to those who looked at him. Those who were in the houses rushed out in crowds to make a universal supplication, because the place was about to come into dishonor. The women, girded with sackcloth under their breasts, thronged the streets. The virgins who were kept indoors ran together, some to the gates, others to the walls, and some looked out through the windows. All, stretching out their hands toward heaven, made their solemn supplication. Then it was pitiful to see the multitude prostrating themselves all mixed together, and the anxiety of the high priest in his great distress. While therefore they called upon the Almighty Lord to keep the things entrusted to them [b] safe and secure for those who had entrusted them, Heliodorus went on to execute that which had been decreed. But when he was already present there with his guards near the treasury, the Sovereign of spirits and of all authority caused a great manifestation, so that all who had presumed to come with him, stricken with dismay at the power of God, fainted in terror. For they saw a horse with a frightening rider, adorned with beautiful trappings, and he rushed fiercely and struck at Heliodorus with his forefeet. It seemed like he who sat on the horse had complete armor of gold. Two others also appeared to him, young men notable in their strength, and beautiful in their glory, and splendid in their apparel, who stood by him on either side, and scourged him unceasingly, inflicting on him many sore stripes. When he had fallen suddenly to the ground, and great darkness had come over him, his guards picked him up and put him on a stretcher, and carried him—this man who had just now entered with a great retinue and all his guard into the aforesaid treasury, himself now brought to utter helplessness, manifestly made to recognize the sovereignty of God. So, while he, through the working of God, speechless and bereft of all hope and deliverance, lay prostrate, they blessed the Lord who acted marvelously for his own place. The temple, which a little before was full of terror and alarm, was filled with joy and gladness after the Almighty Lord appeared. But quickly some of Heliodorus's familiar friends implored Onias to call upon the Most High to grant life to him who lay quite at the last gasp. The high priest, secretly fearing lest the king might come to think that some treachery toward Heliodorus had been perpetrated by the Jews, brought a sacrifice for the recovery of the man. But as the high priest was making the atoning sacrifice, the same young men appeared again to Heliodorus, arrayed in the same garments. They stood and said, "Give Onias the high priest great thanks, for for his sake the Lord has granted you life. See that you, since you have been scourged from heaven, proclaim to all men the sovereign majesty of God." When they had spoken these words, they vanished out of sight. So Heliodorus, having offered a sacrifice to the Lord and vowed [c] great vows to him who had saved his life, and having bidden Onias farewell, returned with his army to the king. He testified to all men the works of the greatest God, which he had seen with his eyes.

[a] *3:5* Greek Thraseas | [b] *3:22* Gr. safe with all security. | [c] *3:35* Gr. greatest.

When the king asked Heliodorus what sort of man was fit to be sent yet once again to Jerusalem, he said, "If you have any enemy or conspirator against the state, send him there, and you will receive him back well scourged, if he even escapes with his life; because truly there is some power of God in that place. For he who has his dwelling in heaven himself has his eyes on that place and helps it. Those who come to hurt it, he strikes and destroys." This was the history of Heliodorus and the keeping of the treasury.

4

The previously mentioned Simon, who had given information about the money against his country, slandered Onias, saying that it was he who had incited Heliodorus and had been the real cause of these evils. He dared to call him a conspirator against the state who was actually the benefactor of the city, the guardian of his fellow countrymen, and a zealot for the laws. When his hatred grew so great that even murders were perpetrated through one of Simon's approved agents, Onias, seeing the danger of the contention, and that [a] Apollonius the son of Menestheus, the governor of Coelesyria and Phoenicia, was increasing Simon's malice, appealed to the king, not to be an accuser of his fellow-citizens, but looking to the good of all the[b] people, both public and private; for he saw that without the king's involvement it was impossible for the state to obtain peace any more, and that Simon would not cease from his madness. When Seleucus was deceased, and Antiochus, who was called Epiphanes, succeeded to the kingdom, Jason the brother of Onias supplanted his brother in the high priesthood, having promised to the king at an audience three hundred sixty talents of silver, and out of another fund eighty talents. In addition to this, he undertook to assign one hundred fifty more, if it might be allowed him [c] through the king's authority to set him up a gymnasium and a body of youths to be trained in it, and to register the inhabitants of Jerusalem as citizens of Antioch. When the king had assented, and Jason had taken possession of the office, he immediately shifted those of his own race to the Greek way of life. Setting aside the royal ordinances of special favor to the Jews, granted by the means of John the father of Eupolemus, who went on the mission to the Romans to establish friendship and alliance, and seeking to overthrow the lawful ways of living, he brought in new customs forbidden by the law. For he eagerly established a gymnasium under the citadel itself, and caused the noblest of the young men to wear the Greek hat. Thus there was an extreme of hellenization, and an advance of a foreign religion, by reason of the exceeding profaneness of Jason, who was an ungodly man and not a high priest; so that the priests had no more any zeal for the services of the altar; but despising the sanctuary and neglecting the sacrifices, they hastened to enjoy that which was unlawfully provided in the wrestling arena, after the summons to the discus-throwing. They despised the honors of their fathers, and valued the prestige of the Greeks best of all. For this reason, severe calamity overtook them. The men whose ways of living they earnestly followed, and to whom they desired to be made like in all things, these became their enemies and punished them. For it is not a light thing to show irreverence to God's laws, but later events will make this clear. Now when certain games that came every fifth year were kept at Tyre, and the king was present, the vile Jason sent sacred envoys,[d] as being Antiochians of Jerusalem, bearing three hundred drachmas of silver to the sacrifice of Hercules, which even the bearers thereof thought not right to use for any sacrifice, because it was not fit, but to spend it for another purpose. Although the intended purpose of the sender this money was for the sacrifice of Hercules, yet on account of [e]present circumstances it went to the construction of trireme warships. Now when Apollonius the son of Menestheus was sent into Egypt for the [f] enthronement of Philometor as king, Antiochus, learning that Philometor had shown himself hostile toward the government, took precautions for the security of his realm. Therefore, going to Joppa, he travelled on to Jerusalem. Being magnificently received by Jason and the city, he was brought in with torches and shouting. Then he led his army down into Phoenicia. Now after a space of three years, Jason sent Menelaus, the previously mentioned Simon's brother, to carry the money to the king, and to make reports concerning some necessary matters. But he being commended to the king, and having been glorified by the display of his authority, secured the high priesthood for himself, outbidding Jason by three hundred talents of silver. After receiving the royal mandates, he returned bringing nothing worthy of the high priesthood, but having the passion of a cruel tyrant and the rage of a savage animal. So Jason, who had supplanted his own brother, was supplanted by another and driven as a fugitive into the country of the Ammonites, Menelaus had possession of the office; but of the money that had been promised to the king nothing

[a] *4:4* Compare **2** Maccabees **4:21**. See also **2** Maccabees **3:5**. The Greek as commonly read means Apollonius, as being the governor...Phoenicia, did rage, and increase etc.
[b] *4:5* Gr. multitude.
[c] *4:9* Gr. through his.
[d] *4:19* See ver. **9**.
[e] *4:20* Some authorities read the bearers.
[f] *4:21* The exact meaning of the Greek word is uncertain.

was regularly paid, even though Sostratus the governor of the citadel demanded it— for his job was the gathering of the revenues—so they were both called by the king to his presence. Menelaus left his own brother Lysimachus for his[a] deputy in the high priesthood; and Sostratus left Crates, who was over the Cyprians. Now while this was the state of things, it came to pass that the people of Tarsus and Mallus revolted because they were to be given as a present to Antiochis, the king's concubine. The king therefore quickly came to settle matters, leaving for his [b]deputy Andronicus, a man of high rank. Then Menelaus, supposing that he had gotten a favorable opportunity, presented to Andronicus certain vessels of gold belonging to the temple, which he had stolen. He had already sold others into Tyre and the neighboring cities. When Onias had sure knowledge of this, he sharply reproved him, having withdrawn himself into a sanctuary at Daphne, that lies by Antioch. Therefore Menelaus, taking Andronicus aside, asked him to kill Onias. Coming to Onias, and being persuaded to use treachery, and being received as a friend, Andronicus gave him his right hand with oaths and, though he was suspicious, persuaded him to come out of the sanctuary. Then, with no regard for justice, he immediately put him to death. For this reason not only Jews, but many also of the other nations, had indignation and displeasure at the unjust murder of the man. And when the king had come back from the places in Cilicia, the Jews who were in the city appealed to him against Andronicus (the Greeks also joining with them in hatred of the wickedness), urging that Onias had been wrongfully slain. Antiochus therefore was heartily sorry, and was moved to pity, and wept, because of the sober and well ordered life of him who was dead. Being inflamed with anger, he immediately stripped off Andronicus's purple robe, and tore off his under garments, and when he had led him round through the whole city to that very place where he had committed the outrage against Onias, there he put the murderer out of the way, the Lord rendering to him the punishment he had deserved. Now when many sacrileges had been committed in the city by Lysimachus with the consent of Menelaus, and when the report of them had spread abroad outside, the people gathered themselves together against Lysimachus, after many vessels of gold had already been stolen. When the multitudes were rising against him and were filled with anger, Lysimachus armed about three thousand men, and with unrighteous violence began the attack under the leadership of Hauran, a man far gone in years and no less also in folly. But when they perceived the assault of Lysimachus, some caught up stones, others logs of wood, and some took handfuls of the ashes that lay near, and they flung them all in wild confusion at Lysimachus and those who were with him. As a result, they wounded many of them, they killed some, and they forced the rest of them to flee, but the author of the sacrilege himself they killed beside the treasury. But about these matters, there was an accusation laid against Menelaus. When the king had come to Tyre, the three men who were sent by the senate pleaded the cause before him. But Menelaus, seeing himself now defeated, promised much money to Ptolemy the son of Dorymenes, that he might win over the king. Therefore Ptolemy taking the king aside into a cloister, as if to get some fresh air, convinced him to change his mind. He who was the cause of all the evil, Menelaus, he discharged from the accusations; but these hapless men, who, if they had pleaded even before Scythians, would have been discharged uncondemned, them he sentenced to death. Those who were spokesmen for the city and the families of Israel and the holy vessels soon suffered that unrighteous penalty. Therefore even certain Tyrians, moved with hatred of the wickedness, provided magnificently for their burial. But Menelaus, through the covetous dealings of those who were in power, remained still in his office, growing in wickedness, established as a great conspirator against his fellow-citizens.

5

Now about this time Antiochus made his second invasion into Egypt. It happened that throughout all the city, for almost forty days, cavalry appeared in the midst of the sky in swift motion, wearing robes woven with gold and carrying spears, equipped with troops for battle— drawing swords, squadrons of cavalry in array, encounters and pursuits of both armies, shaking shields, multitudes of lances, throwing of missiles, flashing of golden trappings, and putting on all sorts of armor. Therefore everyone prayed that the manifestation might have been given for good. When a false rumor had arisen that Antiochus was dead, Jason took not less than a thousand men, and suddenly made an assault upon the city. When those who were on the wall were being routed, and the city was at length nearly taken, Menelaus took refuge in the citadel. But Jason slaughtered his own citizens without mercy, not considering that good success against kinsmen is the greatest misfortune, but supposing himself to be setting up trophies over enemies, and not over fellow-countrymen. He didn't win control of the government, but receiving shame as the result of his conspiracy, he fled again as a fugitive into the country of the Ammonites. At last therefore he met

[a] *4:29* Gr. successor. | [b] *4:31* Gr. successor.

with a miserable end. Having been imprisoned at the court of Aretas the prince of the Arabians, fleeing from city to city, pursued by all men, hated as an rebel against the laws, and abhorred as the executioner of his country and his fellow citizens, he was cast ashore in Egypt. He who had driven many from their own country into exile perished in exile, having crossed the sea to the Lacedaemonians, hoping to find shelter there because they were[a] near of kin. He who had thrown out a multitude unburied had none to mourn for him. He didn't have any funeral at all and no place in the tomb of his ancestors. Now when news came to the king concerning that which was done, he thought that Judea was in revolt. So, setting out from Egypt in a rage, he took the city by force of weapons, and commanded his soldiers to cut down without mercy those who came in their way, and to kill those who went into their houses. Then there was killing of young and old, destruction of boys, women, and children, and slaying of virgins and infants. In a total of three days, eighty thousand were destroyed, of which forty thousand were slain in close combat, and no fewer were sold into slavery than slain. Not content with this, he presumed to enter into the most holy temple of all the earth, having Menelaus for his guide (who had proved himself a traitor both to the laws and to his country), even taking the sacred vessels with his polluted hands, and dragging down with his profane hands the offerings that had been dedicated by other kings to enhance the glory and honor of the place. Antiochus was lifted up in mind, not seeing that because of the sins of those who lived in the city the Sovereign Lord had been provoked to anger a little while, and therefore his eye was turned away from the place. But had it not been so that they were already bound by many sins, this man, even as Heliodorus who was sent by King Seleucus to view the treasury, would, as soon as he came forward, have been scourged and turned back from his daring deed. However the Lord didn't choose the nation for the place's sake, but the place for the nation's sake. Therefore also the place itself, having shared in the calamities that happened to the nation, did afterward share in its benefits; and the place which was forsaken in the wrath of the Almighty was, at the reconciliation of the great Sovereign, restored again with all glory. As for Antiochus, when he had carried away out of the temple one thousand eight hundred talents, he hurried away to Antioch, thinking in his arrogance that he could sail on land and walk on the sea, because his heart was lifted up. Moreover he left governors to afflict the race: at Jerusalem, Philip, by race a Phrygian, and in character more barbarous than him who set him there; and at Gerizim, Andronicus; and besides these, Menelaus, who worse than all the rest, exalted himself against his fellow-citizens. Having a malicious mind[b] toward the Jews[c] whom he had made his citizens, he sent that[d] lord of pollutions Apollonius with an army of twenty-two thousand, commanding him to kill all those who were of full age, and to sell the women and the boys as slaves. He came to Jerusalem, and pretending to be a man of peace, waited till the holy day of the Sabbath, and finding the Jews at rest from work, he commanded his men to parade fully armed. He put to the sword all those who came out to the spectacle. Running into the city with the armed men, he killed great multitudes. But Judas, who is also called Maccabaeus, with about nine others, withdrew himself, and with his company kept himself alive in the mountains like wild animals do. They continued feeding on what grew wild, that they might not be partakers of the defilement.

6

Not long after this, the king sent out [e]an old man of Athens to compel the Jews to depart from the laws of their fathers and not to live by the laws of God, and also to pollute the sanctuary in Jerusalem and to call it by the name of Olympian Zeus, and to call the sanctuary in Gerizim by the name of Zeus the Protector of foreigners, even as the people who lived in that place did. The visitation of this evil was harsh and utterly grievous. For the temple was filled with debauchery and reveling by the heathen, who [f] dallied with prostitutes, and had intercourse with women within the sacred precincts, and moreover brought inside things that were not appropriate. The altar was filled with those abominable things which had been prohibited by the laws. A man could neither keep the Sabbath, nor observe the feasts of their ancestors, nor so much as confess himself to be a Jew. On the day of the king's birth every month, they were led along with bitter constraint to eat of the sacrifices. When the feast of Dionysia came, they were compelled to go in procession in honor of Dionysus, wearing wreaths of ivy. A decree went out to the neighboring Greek cities, by the suggestion of Ptolemy, that they should observe the same conduct against the Jews, and should make them eat of the sacrifices, and that they should kill those who didn't choose to go over to the Greek rites. So the present misery was for all to see. For example, two women were brought in for having circumcised their children. These, when they had led them publicly around the city with the babes hung from their breasts, they

[a] *5:9* See **1** Maccabees **12:7**.
[b] *5:23* Some authorities read toward the Jews, he sent. The Greek text of this sentence is uncertain.
[c] *5:23* Compare **2** Maccabees **4:9**, **19**; **9:19**.
[d] *5:24* Gr. Μυσάρχην, which also may mean ruler of the Mysians.
[e] *6:1* Or, Geron an Athenian
[f] *6:4* Or, idled with their fellows

threw down headlong from the wall. Others who had run together into the caves nearby to keep the seventh day secretly, were betrayed to Philip and were all burned together, because their piety kept them from defending themselves, in view of the honor of that most solemn day. I urge those who read this book to not be discouraged because of the calamities, but recognize that these punishments were not for the destruction, but for the chastening of our race. For indeed it is a sign of great kindness that those who act impiously are not let alone for a long time, but immediately meet with retribution. For in the case of the other nations, the Sovereign Lord waits patiently to punish them until they have attained to the full measure of their sins; but not with us, that he may not take vengeance on us afterward,[a] when we have come to the[b] height of our sins. Therefore he never withdraws his mercy from us; but though he chastens with calamity, he doesn't forsake his own people. However let this that we have spoken suffice to remind you; but after a few words, we must come to the narrative. Eleazar, one of the principal scribes, a man already well advanced in years, and of a noble countenance, was compelled to open his mouth to eat swine's flesh. But he, welcoming death with honor rather than life with defilement, advanced of his own accord to the instrument of torture, but first spat out the flesh, as men ought to come who are resolute to repel such things as not even for the natural love of life is it lawful to taste. But those who had the charge of that forbidden sacrificial feast took the man aside, for the acquaintance which of old times they had with him, and privately implored him to bring flesh of his own providing, such as was proper for him to use, and to make as if he did eat of the flesh from the sacrifice, as had been commanded by the king; that by so doing he might be delivered from death, and so his ancient friendship with them might be treated kindly. But he, having formed a high resolve, and one that became his years, the dignity of old age, and the gray hairs[c] which he had reached with honor, and his excellent[d] education from a child, or rather the holy laws[e] of God's ordaining, declared his mind accordingly, bidding them to quickly send him to Hades. "For it doesn't become our years to dissemble," he said, "that many of the young should suppose that Eleazar, the man of ninety years, had gone over to an alien religion; and so they, by reason of my deception, and for the sake of this brief and momentary life, would be led astray because of me, and I defile and disgrace myself in my old age. For even if for the present time I would remove from me the punishment of men, yet whether I live or die, I wouldn't escape the hands of the Almighty. Therefore, by bravely parting with my life now, I will show myself worthy of my old age, and [f]leave behind a noble example to the young to die willingly and nobly a glorious death for the revered and holy laws." When he had said these words, he went immediately to the instrument of torture. [g] When they changed the good will they bore toward him a little before into ill will because these words of his were, as they thought, sheer madness, and when he was at the point to die with the[h] blows, he groaned aloud and said, "To the Lord, who has the holy knowledge, it is manifest that, while I might have been delivered from death, I endure severe pains in my body by being scourged; but in soul I gladly suffer these things because of my fear of him." So this man also died like this, leaving his death for an example of nobleness and a memorial of virtue, not only to the young but also to the great body of his nation.

7

It came to pass that seven brothers and their mother were at the king's command taken and shamefully handled with scourges and cords, to compel them to taste of the abominable swine's flesh. One of them made himself the spokesman and said, "What would you ask and learn from us? For we are ready to die rather than transgress the laws of our ancestors." The king fell into a rage, and commanded that pans and caldrons be heated. When these were immediately heated, he gave orders to cut out the tongue of him who had been their spokesman, and to scalp him, and to cut off his extremities, with the rest of his brothers and his mother looking on. And when he was utterly[i] maimed, the king gave orders to bring him to the fire, being yet alive, and to fry him in the pan. And as the smoke from the pan spread far, they and their mother also exhorted one another to die nobly, saying this: "The Lord God sees, and in truth is[j] entreated for us, as Moses declared in [k]his song, which witnesses against the people to their faces, saying, 'And he will have compassion on his servants.'" And when the first had died like this, they brought the second to the mocking; and they pulled off the skin of his head with the hair and asked him, "Will you eat, before your body is punished in every limb?" But he answered in the language of his ancestors and said to them, "No." Therefore he also underwent the next torture in succession, as the first had done. When he was at the last gasp, he said, "You, miscreant, release us out of this present life, but the King of the world

[a] *6:15* Or, when our sins have come to their height
[b] *6:15* Gr. end.
[c] *6:23* The Greek text appears to be corrupt.
[d] *6:23* Some authorities read manner of life.
[e] *6:23* Gr. legislation.
[f] *6:28* Gr. one that has left behind.
[g] *6:29* The Greek text of this verse is uncertain.
[h] *6:30* Or, blows
[i] *7:5* Gr. useless.
[j] *7:6* Or, comforted in
[k] *7:6* See Deuteronomy **31:21** and **32:36**.

will raise us who have died for his laws up to an everlasting renewal of life." After him, the third was made a victim of their mocking. When he was required, he quickly put out his tongue, and stretched out his hands courageously, and nobly said, "I got these from heaven. For his laws' sake I treat these with contempt. From him, I hope to receive these back again." As a result, the king himself and those who were with him were astonished at the young man's soul, for he regarded the pains as nothing. When he too was dead, they shamefully handled and tortured the fourth in the same way. Being near to death he said this: "It is good to die at the hands of men and look for the hope which is given by God, that we will be raised up again by him. For as for you, you will have no resurrection to life." Next after him, they brought the fifth and shamefully handled him. But he looked toward [a]the king and said, "Because you have authority among men, though you are corruptible, you do what you please. But don't think that our race has been forsaken by God. But hold on to your ways, and see how his sovereign majesty will torture you and your descendants!" After him they brought the sixth. When he was about to die, he said, "Don't be vainly deceived, for we suffer these things for our own doings, as sinning against our own God. Astounding things have come to pass; but don't think you that you will be unpunished, having tried to fight against God!" But above all, the mother was marvelous and worthy of honorable memory; for when she watched seven sons perishing within the space of one day, she bore the sight with a good courage because of her hope in the Lord. She exhorted each one of them in the language of their fathers, filled with a noble spirit and stirring up her woman's thoughts with manly courage, saying to them, "I don't know how you came into my womb. It wasn't I who gave you your [b]spirit and your life. It wasn't I who brought into order the first elements of each one of you. Therefore the Creator of the world, who shaped the first origin of man and devised the first origin of all things, in mercy gives back to you again both your [c]spirit and your life, as you now treat yourselves with contempt for his laws' sake." But Antiochus, thinking himself to be despised, and suspecting the reproachful voice, while the youngest was yet alive didn't only make his appeal to him by words, but also at the same time promised with oaths that he would enrich him and [d] raise him to high honor if he would turn from the ways of his ancestors, and that he would take him for his [e]friend and entrust him with public affairs. But when the young man would in no way listen, the king called to him his mother, and urged her to advise the youth to save himself. When he had urged her with many words, she undertook to persuade her son. But bending toward him, laughing the cruel tyrant to scorn, she spoke this in the language of her fathers: "My son, have pity upon me who carried you nine months in my womb, and nursed you three years, and nourished and brought you up to this age, and sustained you. I beg you, my child, to lift your eyes to the sky and the earth, and to see all things that are in it, and thus to recognize that God made them not of things that were, and that the race of men in this way comes into being. Don't be afraid of this butcher, but, proving yourself worthy of your brothers, accept your death, that in God's mercy I may receive you again with your brothers." But before she had finished speaking, the young man said, "What are you all waiting for? I don't obey the commandment of the king, but I listen to the commandment of the law that was given to our fathers through Moses. But you, who have devised all kinds of evil against the Hebrews, will in no way escape God's hands. For we are suffering because of our own sins. If for rebuke and chastening, our living Lord has been angered a little while, yet he will again be reconciled with his own servants. But you, O unholy man and of all most vile, don't be vainly lifted up in your wild pride with uncertain hopes, raising your hand against the heavenly children. For you have not yet escaped the judgment of the Almighty God who sees all things. For these our brothers, having endured a [f] short pain that brings everlasting life, have now [g] died under God's covenant. But you, through God's judgment, will receive in just measure the penalties of your arrogance. But I, as my brothers, give up both body and soul for the laws of our fathers, calling upon God that he may speedily become [h]gracious to the nation, and that you, amidst trials and plagues, may confess that he alone is God, and that in me and my brothers [i] you may bring to an end the wrath of the Almighty which has been justly brought upon our whole race." But the king, falling into a rage, handled him worse than all the rest, being exasperated at his mocking. So he also died pure, putting his whole trust in the Lord. Last of all, after her sons, the mother died. Let it then suffice to have said thus much concerning the sacrificial feasts and the extreme tortures.

8

But Judas, who is also called Maccabaeus, and those who were with him, making their way secretly into the villages, called to them their kindred. Taking to

[a] *7:16* Gr. him.
[b] *7:22* Or, breath
[c] *7:23* Or, breath
[d] *7:24* Gr. make him one that is counted happy.
[e] *7:24* See **2** Maccabees **8:9**.
[f] *7:36* Gr. short pain of ever-flowing life.
[g] *7:36* Gr. fallen. By the omission of one Greek letter the words would signify having endured a short pain, have now drunk of ever-flowing life under God's covenant.
[h] *7:37* Gr. propitious.
[i] *7:38* Some authorities read may be stayed.

them those who had continued in the Jews' religion, gathered together about six thousand. They called upon the Lord to look at the people who were oppressed by all, and to have compassion on the sanctuary that had been profaned by the ungodly men, and to have pity on the city that was suffering ruin and ready to be leveled to the ground, and to listen to the blood that cried out to him, and to remember the lawless destruction of the innocent infants, and concerning the blasphemies that had been committed against his name, and to show his hatred of wickedness. When Maccabaeus had trained his men for service, the heathen at once found him irresistible, for the wrath of the Lord was turned into mercy.
[a]Coming without warning, he set fire to cities and villages. And in winning back the most important positions, putting to flight no small number of the enemies, he especially took advantage of the nights for such assaults. His courage was loudly talked of everywhere. But when Philip saw the man gaining ground little by little, and increasing more and more in his success, he wrote to Ptolemy, the governor of Coelesyria and Phoenicia, that he should support the king's cause. Ptolemy quickly appointed Nicanor the son of Patroclus, one of the king's [b] chief friends, and sent him, in command of no fewer than twenty thousand of all nations, to destroy the whole race of Judea. With him he joined Gorgias also, a captain and one who had experience in matters of war. Nicanor resolved by the sale of the captive Jews to make up for the king the tribute of two thousand talents which he was to pay to the Romans. Immediately he sent to the cities upon the sea coast, inviting them to buy Jewish [c]slaves, promising to deliver seventy [d]slaves for a talent, not expecting the judgment that was to overtake him from the Almighty. News came to Judas concerning Nicanor's invasion. When he communicated to those who were with him the presence of the army, those who were cowardly and distrustful of God's judgment [e]ran away and left the country. Others sold all that they had left, and at the same time implored the Lord to deliver those who had been sold as slaves by the impious Nicanor before he ever met them, if not for their own sakes, then for the covenants made with their ancestors, and because he had called them by his holy and glorious name. So Maccabaeus gathered his men together, six thousand in number, and exhorted them not to be frightened by the enemy, nor to fear the great multitude of the heathen who came wrongfully against them, but to fight nobly, setting before their eyes the outrage that had been lawlessly perpetrated upon the holy place, and the torture of the city that had been turned to mockery, and further the overthrow of the way of life received from their ancestors. "For they," he said, "trust their weapons and daring deeds, but we trust in the almighty God, since he is able at a nod to cast down those who are coming against us, and even the whole world." Moreover, he recounted to them the help given from time to time in the days of their ancestors, both in the days of Sennacherib, when one hundred eighty-five thousand perished, and in the land of Babylon, in the battle that was fought against the[f] Gauls, how they came to the battle with eight thousand in all, with four thousand Macedonians, and how, the Macedonians being hard pressed, the [g]six thousand destroyed the hundred and twenty thousand because of the help which they had from heaven, and took a great deal of plunder. And when he had with these words filled them with courage and made them ready to die for the laws and their country, he divided his army into four parts. He appointed his brothers, Simon, Joseph, and Jonathan, to be leaders of the divisions with him, giving each the command of one thousand five hundred men. Moreover Eleazer also, having read aloud the sacred book, and having given as watchword, "THE HELP OF GOD", leading the first band himself, joined battle with Nicanor. Since the Almighty fought on their side, they killed more than nine thousand of the enemy, and wounded and[h] disabled most of Nicanor's army, and compelled them all to flee. They took the money of those who had come there to buy them as slaves. After they had pursued them for some [i]distance, they returned, being constrained by the time of the day; for it was the day before the Sabbath, and for this reason they made no effort to chase them far. [j] When they had gathered [k] the weapons of the enemy together, and had stripped off their spoils, they kept the Sabbath, greatly blessing and thanking the Lord who had saved them to this day, because he had begun to show mercy to them. After the Sabbath, when they had given some of the spoils to the [l] maimed, and to the widows and orphans, they distributed the rest among themselves and their children. When they had accomplished these things and had made a common supplication, they implored the merciful Lord to be wholly reconciled with his servants. Having had an encounter with the forces of Timotheus and Bacchides, they killed more than twenty thousand of them, and made themselves masters of exceedingly high strongholds, and divided

[a] *8:6* The Greek text of verses **6** and **7** is uncertain.
[b] *8:9* See **1** Maccabees **10:65**. Compare **2** Maccabees **1:14**; **7:24**; **10:13**; **14:11**; **1** Maccabees **2:18**.
[c] *8:11* Gr. bodies.
[d] *8:11* Gr. bodies.
[e] *8:13* The Greek text here is uncertain.
[f] *8:20* Gr. Galatians.
[g] *8:20* Some authorities read eight.
[h] *8:24* Gr. disabled in their limbs.
[i] *8:25* Or, while
[j] *8:27* The exact meaning of this clause is uncertain.
[k] *8:27* Gr. their weapons...the spoils of the enemy.
[l] *8:28* Or, wounded Gr. shamefully handled.

very much plunder, giving the [a]maimed, orphans, widows, and the aged an equal share with themselves. [b] When they had gathered the weapons [c] of the enemy together, they stored them all up carefully in the most strategic positions, and they carried the rest of the spoils to Jerusalem. They killed the [d]phylarch of Timotheus's forces, a most unholy man, and one who had done the Jews much harm. [e] As they celebrated the feast of victory in the [f] city of their fathers, they burned those who had set the sacred [g]gates on fire, including Callisthenes, who had fled into [h]a little house. So they received the proper reward for their impiety. The thrice-accursed Nicanor, who had brought the thousand merchants to buy the Jews as slaves, being through the help of the Lord humbled by them who in his eyes were held to be of least account, took off his glorious apparel, and passing through the country, [i]shunning all company like a fugitive slave, arrived at Antioch, [j] having, as he thought, had the greatest possible good fortune, though his army was destroyed. He who had taken upon himself to make tribute sure for the Romans by the captivity of the men of Jerusalem published abroad that the Jews had One who fought for them, and that [k] because this was so, the Jews were invulnerable, because they followed the laws ordained by him.

9

Now about that time, Antiochus retreated [l] in disorder from the region of Persia. For he had entered into the city called Persepolis, and he attempted to rob [m]a temple and to control the city. Therefore the multitudes rushed in and the people of the country turned to defend themselves with weapons; and it came to pass that Antiochus was put to flight by the people of the country and broke his camp with disgrace. While he was at Ecbatana, news was brought to him about what had happened to Nicanor and the forces of Timotheus. Being overcome by his anger, he planned to make the Jews suffer for the evil deeds of those who had put him to flight. Therefore, with judgment from heaven even now accompanying him, he ordered his charioteer to drive without ceasing until he completed the journey; for he arrogantly said this: "I will make Jerusalem a common graveyard of Jews when I come there." But the All-seeing Lord, the God of Israel, struck him with a [n]fatal and invisible stroke. As soon as he had finished speaking this word, an incurable pain of the bowels seized him, with bitter torments of the inner parts— and that most justly, for he had tormented other men's bowels with many and strange sufferings. But he in no way ceased from his rude insolence. No, he was filled with even more arrogance, breathing fire in his passion against the Jews, and giving orders to hasten the journey. But it came to pass moreover that he fell from his chariot as it rushed along, and having a grievous fall was tortured in all of the members of his body. He who had just supposed himself to have the waves of the sea at his bidding because he was so superhumanly arrogant, and who thought to weigh the heights of the mountains in a balance, was now brought to the ground and carried in a litter, [o] showing to all that the power was obviously God's, so that worms swarmed out of the impious man's body, and while he was still living in anguish and pains, his flesh fell off, and by reason of the stench all the army turned with loathing from his decay. The man who a little before supposed himself to touch the stars of heaven, no one could endure to carry because of his intolerable stench. Therefore he began in great part to cease from his arrogance, being broken in spirit, and to come to knowledge under the scourge of God, his pains increasing every moment. When he himself could not stand his own smell, he said these words: "It is right to be subject to God, and that one who is mortal should not think they are equal to God." The vile man vowed to the sovereign Lord, who now no more would have pity upon him, saying that the holy city, to which he was going in haste to lay it even with the ground and to [p]make it a common graveyard, he would declare free. Concerning the Jews, whom he had decided not even to count worthy of burial, but to cast them out to the animals with their infants for the birds to devour, he would make them all equal to citizens of Athens. The holy sanctuary, which before he had plundered, he would adorn with best offerings, and would restore all the sacred vessels many times multiplied, and out of his own revenues would defray the charges that were required for the sacrifices. Beside all this, he said that he would become a Jew and would visit every inhabited place, proclaiming the power of God. But when his sufferings did in no way cease, for the judgment of God had come upon him in righteousness, having given up all hope for himself, he wrote to the Jews the letter written below, having the nature of a supplication, to this effect: "To the

[a] *8:30* Or, wounded Gr. shamefully handled.
[b] *8:31* The exact meaning of this clause is uncertain.
[c] *8:31* Gr. of them.
[d] *8:32* That is, probably, the captain of an irregular auxiliary force. Some write Phylarches, as a proper name.
[e] *8:33* The Greek text here is perhaps corrupt.
[f] *8:33* Or, country
[g] *8:33* Or, porches
[h] *8:33* Or, a solitary hut
[i] *8:35* Gr. having made himself solitary.
[j] *8:35* Or, having won the greatest possible favor by reason of the destruction of his army
[k] *8:36* Or, because of this their way of life Gr. because of this manner.
[l] *9:1* Or, with dishonor
[m] *9:2* Or, temples
[n] *9:5* Gr. remediless.
[o] *9:8* Or, showing manifestly to all the power of God
[p] *9:14* Gr. build.

worthy Jewish citizens, Antiochus, king and general, wishes much joy and health and prosperity. May you and your children fare well, and may your affairs be as you wish. Having my hope in heaven, I remembered with affection your honor and good will. Returning out of the region of Persia, and being taken with an annoying sickness, I deemed it necessary to take thought for the common safety of all, not despairing of myself, but having great hope to escape from the sickness. But considering that my father also, at the time he led an army into the upper country, appointed his successor, to the end that, if anything fell out contrary to expectation, or if any unwelcome tidings were brought, the people in the country, knowing to whom the state had been left, might not be troubled, and, moreover, observing how the princes who are along the borders and neighbors to my kingdom watch for opportunities and look for the future event, I have appointed my son Antiochus to be king, whom I often entrusted and commended to most of you when I was hurrying to the upper provinces. I have written to him what is written below. I therefore urge you and beg you, having in your remembrance the benefits done to you in common and severally, to preserve your present good will, each of you, toward me and my son. For I am persuaded that he in gentleness and kindness will follow my purpose and treat you with moderation and kindness. So the murderer and blasphemer, having endured the most intense sufferings, even as he had dealt with other men, ended his life among the mountains by a most piteous fate in a strange land. Philip his foster brother took the body home and then, fearing the son of Antiochus, he withdrew himself to Ptolemy Philometor in Egypt.

10

Then Maccabaeus and those who were with him, the Lord leading them on, recovered the temple and the city. They pulled down the altars that had been built in the marketplace by the foreigners, and also the sacred enclosures. Having cleansed the sanctuary, they made another altar of sacrifice. [a]Striking flint and starting a fire, they offered sacrifices after they had ceased for two years, burned incense, lit lamps, and set out the show bread. When they had done these things, they fell prostrate and implored the Lord that they might fall no more into such evils; but that, if they ever did sin, they might be chastened by him with forbearance, and not be delivered to blaspheming and barbarous heathen. Now on the same day that the sanctuary was profaned by foreigners, upon that very day it came to pass that the sanctuary was cleansed, even on the twenty-fifth day of the same month, which is Chislev. They observed eight days with gladness in the manner of the feast of tabernacles, remembering how [b] not long before, during the feast of tabernacles, they were wandering in the mountains and in the caves like wild animals. Therefore carrying wands wreathed with leaves, and beautiful branches, and palm fronds also, they offered up hymns of thanksgiving to him who had successfully brought to pass the cleansing of his own place. They ordained also with a public statute and decree, for all the nation of the Jews, that they should observe these days every year. Such were the events of the end of Antiochus, who was called Epiphanes. Now we will declare what came to pass under Antiochus [c]Eupator, who proved himself a son of that ungodly man, and will summarize the main evils of the wars. For this man, when he succeeded to the kingdom, appointed one Lysias to be chancellor and supreme governor of Coelesyria and Phoenicia. For Ptolemy who was called Macron, setting an example of observing justice toward the Jews because of the wrong that had been done to them, endeavored to deal with them on peaceful terms. Whereupon being accused by the king's [d]friends before Eupator, and hearing himself called traitor at every turn because he had abandoned Cyprus which Philometor had entrusted to him, and had withdrawn himself to Antiochus Epiphanes, and [e] failing to uphold the honor of his office, he took poison and did away with himself. But when Gorgias was made governor of the district, he maintained a force of mercenaries, and at every turn kept up war with the Jews. Together with him the Idumaeans also, being masters of important strongholds, harassed the Jews; and received those who had taken refuge from Jerusalem, they endeavored to keep up the war. But Maccabaeus and his men, having made solemn supplication and having implored God to fight on their side, rushed upon the strongholds of the Idumaeans. Assaulting them vigorously, they took control of the positions, and kept off all who fought upon the wall, and killed those whom they encountered, killing no fewer than twenty thousand. Because no fewer than nine thousand had fled into two very strong towers having everything needed for a seige, Maccabaeus, having left Simon and Joseph, and also Zacchaeus and those who were with him, a force sufficient to besiege them, departed himself to places where he was most needed. But Simon and those who were with him, yielding to covetousness, were bribed by some of those who were in the towers, and receiving seventy thousand drachmas, let some

[a] *10:3* Gr. firing.
[b] *10:6* Or, not long before they kept the feast of tabernacles by wandering
[c] *10:10* That is, son of a good father.
[d] *10:13* See **2** Maccabees **8:9**
[e] *10:13* The Greek text here is corrupt.

of them slip away. But when word was brought to Maccabaeus of what was done, he gathered the leaders of the people together, and accused those men of having sold their kindred for money by setting their enemies free to fight against them. So he killed these men for having turned traitors, and immediately took possession of the two towers. Prospering with his weapons in everything he undertook, he destroyed more than twenty thousand in the two strongholds. Now Timotheus, who had been defeated by the Jews before, having gathered together foreign forces in great multitudes, and having collected the cavalry which belonged to Asia, not a few, came as though he would take Judea by force of weapons. But as he drew near, Maccabaeus and his men sprinkled dirt on their heads and girded their loins with sackcloth, in supplication to God, and falling down upon the step in front of the altar, implored him to become [a]gracious to them, and [b]be an enemy to their enemies and an adversary to their adversaries, as the law declares. Rising from their prayer they took up their weapons, and advanced some distance from the city. When they had come near to their enemies, they[c] halted. When the dawn was now breaking, the two armies joined in battle, the one part having this, beside virtue, for a pledge of success and victory, that they had fled to the Lord for refuge, the others making their passion their leader in the fight. When the battle became strong, there appeared out of heaven to their adversaries five splendid men on horses with bridles of gold, [d]and two of them, leading on the Jews, and taking Maccabaeus in the midst of them, and covering him with their own armor, guarded him from wounds, while they shot arrows and thunderbolts at the enemies. For this reason, they were blinded and thrown into confusion, and were cut to pieces, filled with bewilderment. Twenty thousand five hundred were slain, beside six hundred cavalry. Timotheus himself fled into a stronghold called Gazara, a fortress of great strength, [e]where Chaereas was in command. Then Maccabaeus and his men were glad and laid siege to the fortress for four days. Those who were within, trusting in the strength of the place, blasphemed exceedingly, and hurled out impious words. But at dawn of the fifth day, certain young men of Maccabaeus' company, inflamed with anger because of the blasphemies, assaulted the wall with masculine force and with [f]furious anger, and cut down whoever came in their way. Others climbing up in the same way, while the enemies were distracted with those who had made their way within, set fire to the towers, and kindled fires that burned the blasphemers alive, while others broke open the gates, and, having given entrance to the rest of the band, occupied the city. They killed Timotheus, who was hidden in a cistern, and his brother Chaereas, and Apollophanes. When they had accomplished these things, they blessed the Lord with hymns and thanksgiving, blessing him who provides great benefits to Israel and gives them the victory.

11

Now after a very little time, Lysias, the king's guardian, kinsman, and chancellor, being very displeased about the things that had happened, collected about eighty thousand infantry and all his cavalry and came against the Jews, planing to make the city a home for Greeks, and to levy tribute on the temple, as [g]on the other sacred places of the nations, and to put up the high priesthood for sale every year. He took no account of God's power, but was puffed up with his ten thousands of infantry, his thousands of cavalry, and his eighty elephants. Coming into Judea and approaching Bethsuron, which was a strong place and about five stadia [h] away from Jerusalem, he pressed it hard. When Maccabaeus and his men learned that he was besieging the strongholds, they and all the people with lamentations and tears made supplication to the Lord to send a good angel to save Israel. Maccabaeus himself took up weapons first, and exhorted the others to put themselves in jeopardy together with him and help their kindred; and they went out with him very willingly. As they were there, close to Jerusalem, a horseman appeared at their head in white apparel, brandishing[i] weapons of gold. They all together praised the merciful God, and were yet more strengthened in heart, being ready to [j]assail not only men but the wildest animals and walls of iron, they advanced in array, having him who is in heaven to fight on their side, for the Lord had mercy on them. Hurling themselves like lions against the enemy, they killed eleven thousand infantry and one thousand six hundred cavalry, and forced all the rest to flee. Most of them escaped wounded and naked. Lysias himself also escaped by shameful flight. But as he was a man not void of understanding, pondering the defeat which had befallen him, and considering that the Hebrews could not be overcome because the Almighty God fought on their side, he sent again and persuaded them to come to terms on condition that all their rights were acknowledged,

[a] *10:26* Gr. propitious.
[b] *10:26* See Exodus **23:22**.
[c] *10:27* Gr. were by themselves.
[d] *10:29* Some authorities read and leading on the Jews; who also, taking.
[e] *10:32* See ver. **37**.
[f] *10:35* Gr. passion as of wild animals.
[g] *11:3* Or, on all the sacred places of the heathen
[h] *11:5* One stadia was roughly **189** meters or **618** feet, so **5** stadia was about a little less than **1** km or a little more than half a mile.
[i] *11:8* Gr. a panoply.
[j] *11:9* Gr. wound.

and [a] promised that he would also persuade the king to become their friend. Maccabaeus gave consent upon all the conditions which Lysias proposed to him, being careful of the common good; for whatever requests Maccabaeus delivered in writing to Lysias concerning the Jews the king allowed. The letter written to the Jews from Lysias was to this effect: "Lysias to the [b]people of the Jews, greetings. John and Absalom, who were sent from you, having delivered the document written below, made request concerning the things written therein. Whatever things therefore needed to be brought before the king I declared to him, and what things were possible he allowed. If then you will all preserve your good will toward the government, I will also endeavor in the future to contribute to your good. Concerning this, I have given order in detail, both to these men and to those who are sent from me, to confer with you. Farewell. Written in the one hundred forty-eighth year, on the twenty-fourth day of the month [c]Dioscorinthius." And the king's letter contained these words: "King Antiochus to his brother Lysias, greetings. Seeing that our father passed to the gods having the wish that the subjects of his kingdom [d]should be undisturbed and give themselves to the care of their own affairs, we, having heard that the Jews do not consent to our father's purpose to turn them to the customs of the Greeks, but choose rather their own way of living, and make request that the customs of their law be allowed to them— choosing therefore that this nation also should be free from disturbance, we determine that their temple is to be restored to them, and that they live according to the customs that were in the days of their ancestors. You will therefore do well to send messengers to them and give them the right hand of friendship, that they, knowing our mind, may be of good heart, and gladly occupy themselves with the conduct of their own affairs." And to the nation, the king's letter was as follows: "King Antiochus to the senate of the Jews and to the other Jews, greetings. If you are all well, it is as we desire. We ourselves also are in good health. Menelaus informed us that your desire was to return home and follow your own business. They therefore who depart home up to the thirtieth day of Xanthicus shall have our [e] friendship, with full permission that the Jews use their own foods and observe their own laws, even as formerly. None of them shall be in any way molested for the things that have been done in ignorance. Moreover I have sent Menelaus also, that he may encourage you. Farewell. Written in the one hundred forty-eighth year, on the fifteenth day of Xanthicus." The Romans also sent to them a letter in these words: "Quintus Memmius and Titus Manius, ambassadors of the Romans, to the people of the Jews, greetings. In regard to the things which Lysias the king's kinsman granted you, we also give consent. But as for the things which he judged should be referred to the king, send someone promptly, after you have considered them, that we may publish such decrees as are appropriate for your case; for we are on our way to Antioch. Therefore send someone with speed, that we also may learn what is your mind. [f]Farewell. Written in the one hundred forty-eighth year, on the fifteenth day of Xanthicus.

12

So when this agreement had been made, Lysias departed to the king, and the Jews went about their farming. But some of the governors of districts, Timotheus and Apollonius the son of Gennaeus, and also Hieronymus and Demophon, and beside them Nicanor the governor of Cyprus, would not allow them to enjoy tranquillity and live in peace. Men of Joppa perpetrated this great impiety: they invited the Jews who lived among them to go with their wives and children into the boats which they had provided, as though they had no ill will toward them. When[g] the Jews,[h] relying on the public vote of the city, accepted the invitation, as men desiring to live in peace and suspecting nothing, they took them out to sea and drowned not less than two hundred of them. When Judas heard of the cruelty done to his fellow-countrymen, giving command to the men that were with him and calling upon God the righteous Judge, he came against the murderers of his kindred, and set the harbor on fire at night, burned the boats, and put to the sword those who had fled there. But when the town gates were closed, he withdrew, intending to come again to root out the whole community of the men of Joppa. But learning that the men of Jamnia intended to do the same thing to the Jews who lived among them, he attacked the Jamnites at night, and set fire to the harbor together with the fleet, so that the glare of the light was seen at Jerusalem, two hundred forty furlongs[i] distant. Now when they had drawn off nine furlongs[j] from there, as they marched against Timotheus, an army of Arabians attacked him, no fewer than five thousand infantry and five hundred cavalry. And when a hard battle had been fought, and Judas and his company, by the help of God, had good success, the nomads being overcome

[a] *11:14* The Greek text here is corrupt.
[b] *11:16* Gr. multitude.
[c] *11:21* This month name is not found elsewhere, and is perhaps corrupt.
[d] *11:23* Or, should not be disquieted but
[e] *11:30* Gr. right hand.
[f] *11:38* Gr. Be in good health.
[g] *12:4* Gr. they also.
[h] *12:4* Gr. after.
[i] *12:9* a furlong is about **201** meters or **220** yards, so **240** furlongs is about **48** km. or **30** miles
[j] *12:10* a furlong is about **201** meters or **220** yards, so **9** furlongs is about **1**. **8** km. or **1 1/8** miles

implored Judas to grant them friendship, promising to give him livestock, and to help [a]his people in all other ways. So Judas, thinking that they would indeed be profitable in many things, agreed to live in peace with them; and receiving pledges of friendship they departed to their tents. He also attacked a certain city, strong and fenced with earthworks and walls, and inhabited by a mixed multitude of various nations. It was named Caspin. Those who were within, trusting in the strength of the walls and their store of provisions, behaved themselves rudely toward Judas and those who were with him, railing, and furthermore blaspheming and speaking impious words. But Judas and his company, calling upon the great Sovereign of the world, who without rams and cunning engines of war hurled down Jericho in the times of Joshua, rushed wildly against the wall. Having taken the city by the will of God, they made unspeakable slaughter, so much that the adjoining lake, which was two furlongs[b] broad, appeared to be filled with the deluge of blood. When they had gone seven hundred fifty furlongs[c] from there, they made their way to Charax, to the Jews that are called [d]Tubieni. They didn't find Timotheus in that district, for he had by then departed from the district without accomplishing anything, but had left behind a very strong garrison in one place. But Dositheus and Sosipater, who were captains under Maccabaeus, went out and destroyed those who had been left by Timotheus in the stronghold, more than ten thousand men. Maccabaeus, arranging his own army in divisions, set [e]these two over the bands, and marched in haste against Timotheus, who had with him one hundred twenty thousand infantry and two thousand five hundred cavalry. When Timotheus heard of the approach of Judas, he at once sent away the women and the children with the baggage into the fortress called [f]Carnion; for the place was hard to besiege and difficult of access by reason of the narrowness of the approaches on all sides. When the band of Judas, who led the first division, appeared in sight, and when terror and fear came upon the enemy, because the manifestation of him who sees all things came upon them, they fled in every direction, carried this way and that, so that they were often injured by their own men, and pierced with the points of their own swords. Judas continued the pursuit more vigorously, putting the wicked wretches to the sword, and he destroyed as many as thirty thousand men. Timotheus himself, falling in with the company of Dositheus and Sosipater, implored them with much crafty guile to let him go with his life, because he had in his power the parents of many of them and the kindred of some. [g] "Otherwise, he said, little regard will [h] be shown to these." So when he had with many words confirmed the agreement to restore them without harm, they let him go that they might save their kindred. Then Judas, marching against [i]Carnion and the temple of Atergatis, killed twenty-five thousand people. After he had put these to flight and destroyed them, he marched against Ephron also, a strong city, [j]wherein were multitudes of people of all nations. Stalwart young men placed [k]on the walls made a vigorous defense. There were great stores of war engines and darts there. But calling upon the Sovereign who with might shatters the [l]strength of [m]the enemy, they took the city into their hands, and killed as many as twenty-five thousand of those who were in it. Setting out from there, they marched in haste against Scythopolis, which is six hundred furlongs[n] away from Jerusalem. But when the Jews who were settled there testified of the good will that the Scythopolitans had shown toward them, and of their kind treatment of them in the times of their misfortune, they gave thanks, and further exhorted them to remain well disposed toward the race for the future. Then they went up to Jerusalem, the feast of weeks being close at hand. But after the feast called Pentecost, they marched in haste against Gorgias the governor of Idumaea. He came out with three thousand infantry and four hundred cavalry. When they had set themselves in array, it came to pass that a few of the Jews fell. A certain Dositheus, one [o] of Bacenor's company, who was on horseback and was a strong man, pressed hard on Gorgias, and taking hold of his cloke dragged him along by main force. While he planned to take the accursed man alive, one of the Thracian cavalry bore down on him and disabled his shoulder, and so Gorgias escaped to [p]Marisa. When those who were with Esdris had been fighting long and were weary, Judas called upon the Lord to show himself, fighting on their side and leading in the battle. Then in the language of his ancestors he raised the battle cry joined with hymns. Then he rushed against Gorgias' troops when they were not expecting it, and put them to flight. Judas gathered his army and came to the city of [q]Adullam. As the seventh day was coming on, they purified

[a] *12:11* Gr. them.
[b] *12:16* a furlong is about **201** meters or **220** yards, so **2** furlongs is about **402** meters or **1/ 4** mile
[c] *12:17* a furlong is about **201** meters or **220** yards, so **750** furlongs is about **151** km. or **94** miles
[d] *12:17* That is, men of Tob: see Judges **11:3**, **2** Samuel **10:6**, and compare **1** Maccabees **5:13**.
[e] *12:20* Gr. them.
[f] *12:21* Compare Carnain, **1** Maccabees **5:26**, **43**, **44**.
[g] *12:24* Gr. and the result will be that these be disregarded. The Greek text here is perhaps corrupt.
[h] *12:24* Or, have been shown
[i] *12:26* Compare Carnain, **1** Maccabees **5:26**, **43**, **44**.
[j] *12:27* The Greek text here is perhaps corrupt.
[k] *12:27* Gr. in front of.
[l] *12:28* Some authorities read weight.
[m] *12:28* Or, his enemies
[n] *12:29* a furlong is about **201** meters or **220** yards, so **600** furlongs is about **121** km. or **75** miles
[o] *12:35* The Greek text is uncertain.
[p] *12:35* Compare **1** Maccabees **5:65**.
[q] *12:38* Gr. Odollam.

themselves according to the custom, and kept the Sabbath there. On the following day, [a]when it had become necessary, Judas and his company came to take up the bodies of those who had fallen, [b]and in company with their kinsmen to bring them back to the sepulchres of their ancestors. But under the garments of each one of the dead they found [c]consecrated tokens of the idols of Jamnia, which the law forbids the Jews to have anything to do with. It became clear to all that it was for this cause that they had fallen. All therefore, blessing the ways of the Lord, the righteous Judge, who makes manifest the things that are hidden, turned themselves to supplication, praying that the sin committed might be wholly blotted out. The noble Judas exhorted the multitude to keep themselves from sin, for they had seen with their own eyes what happened because of the sin of those who had fallen. When he had made a collection man by man to the sum of two thousand drachmas of silver, he sent to Jerusalem to offer a sacrifice for sin, doing very well and honorably in this, in that he took thought for the resurrection. For if he wasn't expecting that those who had fallen would rise again, it would be superfluous and idle to pray for the dead. But if he was looking forward to an honorable memorial of gratitude laid up for those who [d]die [e]in godliness, then the thought was holy and godly. Therefore he made the atoning sacrifice for those who had died, that they might be released from their sin.

13

In the one hundred forty-ninth year, news was brought to Judas and his company that Antiochus Eupator was coming with multitudes against Judea, and with him Lysias his guardian and chancellor, each having a Greek force of one hundred ten thousand infantry, five thousand three hundred cavalry, twenty-two elephants, and three hundred chariots armed with scythes. And Menelaus also joined himself with them, and with great hypocrisy encouraged Antiochus, not for the saving of his country, but because he thought that he would be set over the government. But the King of kings stirred up the anger of Antiochus against the wicked wretch. When Lysias informed him that this man was the cause of all the evils, the king commanded to bring him to Beroea, and to put him to death in the way customary in that place. Now there is in that place a tower that is fifty cubits high, full of ashes, and it had all around it a [f]circular rim sloping steeply on every side into the ashes. Here one who is guilty of sacrilege or notorious for other crimes is pushed down to destruction. By such a fate it happened that the breaker of the law, Menelaus, died, without obtaining so much as a grave in the earth, and that justly; for inasmuch as he had perpetrated many sins [g] against the altar, whose fire and whose ashes were holy, he received his death in ashes. Now the king,[h] infuriated in spirit, was coming with intent to inflict on the Jews the very worst of the sufferings that had been done in his father's time. But when Judas heard of these things, he commanded the multitude to call upon the Lord day and night, if ever at any other time, so now to help those who were at the point of being deprived of the law, their country, and the holy temple, and not to allow the people who had just begun to be revived to fall into the hands of those profane heathen. So when they had all done the same thing together, [i] begging the merciful Lord with weeping and fastings and prostration for three days without ceasing, Judas exhorted them and commanded they should join him. Having consulted privately with the elders, he resolved that before the king's army entered into Judea and made themselves masters of the city, they should go out and decide the matter by the help of [j]God. And committing the decision to the [k]Lord of the world, and exhorting those who were with him to contend nobly even to death for laws, temple, city, country, and way of life, he pitched his camp by Modin. He gave out to his men the watchword, "VICTORY IS GOD'S", with a chosen force of the bravest young men he attacked by the king's pavilion by night, and killed of his army as many as two thousand men, and [l]brought down the leading elephant with him who was in the [m]tower on him. At last they filled the [n]army with terror and alarm, and departed with good success. This had been accomplished when the day was just dawning, because of the Lord's protection that gave [o]Judas help. But the king, having had a taste of the exceeding boldness of the Jews, made strategic attacks on their positions, and on a strong fortress of the Jews at Bethsura. He advanced, was turned back, failed, and was defeated. Judas sent the things that were necessary to those who were within. But Rhodocus, from the Jewish ranks, made secrets known to the enemy. He was sought out, arrested, and shut up in prison. The king negotiated with them in Bethsura the second time, gave his hand, took theirs, departed, attacked the forces of Judas, was put to the worse, heard that Philip who had been left as

[a] *12:39* The Greek text here is uncertain.
[b] *12:39* Or, and to bring them back to be with their kinsmen in the sepulchres
[c] *12:40* Perhaps these were consecrated images of the idols.
[d] *12:45* Gr. fall asleep.
[e] *12:45* Or, on the side of godliness
[f] *13:5* Gr. contrivance or machine.
[g] *13:8* Gr. about.
[h] *13:9* Some authorities read indignant.
[i] *13:12* Gr. and implored.
[j] *13:13* Some authorities read the Lord.
[k] *13:14* Some authorities read Creator.
[l] *13:15* The Greek text here is probably corrupt.
[m] *13:15* Gr. house.
[n] *13:16* Gr. camp.
[o] *13:17* Gr. him.

chancellor in Antioch had become reckless, was confounded, made to the Jews an overture of peace, submitted himself and swore to acknowledge all their rights, came to terms with them and offered sacrifice, honored the sanctuary and the place, showed kindness and graciously received Maccabaeus, left Hegemonides governor from Ptolemais even to the [a] Gerrenians, and came to Ptolemais. The men of Ptolemais were displeased at the treaty, for they had exceedingly great indignation against the Jews. They desired to annul the articles of the agreement. Lysias [b]came forward to speak, made the best defense that was possible, persuaded, pacified, gained their good will, and departed to Antioch. This was the issue of the attack and departure of the king.

14

Three years later, news was brought to Judas and his company that Demetrius the son of Seleucus, having sailed into the harbor of Tripolis with a mighty army and a fleet, had taken possession of the country, having made away with Antiochus and his guardian Lysias. But one Alcimus, who had formerly been high priest, and had willfully polluted himself in the times when there was no mingling with the Gentiles, considering that there was no deliverance for him in any way, nor any more access to the holy altar, came to King Demetrius in about the one hundred fifty-first year, presenting to him a crown of gold and a palm, and beside these some of the festal olive boughs of the temple. For that day, he held his peace; but having gotten opportunity to further his own madness, being called by Demetrius into a meeting of his council, and asked how the Jews stood affected and what they intended, he answered: "Those of the Jews called [c] Hasidaeans, whose leader is Judas Maccabaeus, keep up war and are seditious, not allowing the kingdom to find tranquillity. Therefore, having laid aside my ancestral glory—I mean the high priesthood—I have now come [d]here, first for the genuine care I have for the things that concern the king, and secondly because I have regard also to my own fellow citizens. For through the unadvised dealing of those of whom I spoke before, our whole race is in no small misfortune. O king, having informed yourself of these things, take thought both for our country and for our race, which is surrounded by enemies, according to the gracious kindness with which you receive all. For as long as Judas remains alive, it is impossible for the government to find peace. When he had spoken such words as these, at once [e]the rest of the king's [f]friends, having ill will against Judas, inflamed Demetrius yet more. He immediately appointed Nicanor, who had been master of the elephants, and made him governor of Judea. He sent him out, giving him written instructions to kill Judas himself and to scatter those who were with him, and to set up Alcimus as high priest of the [g]great temple. Those in Judea who [h]had driven Judas into exile thronged to Nicanor in flocks, supposing that the misfortunes and calamities of the Jews would be successes to themselves. But when the Jews heard of Nicanor's advance and the assault of the heathen, they sprinkled dirt on their heads and made solemn prayers to him who had established his own people for evermore, and who always, making manifest his presence, upholds those who are his own heritage. [i]When the leader had given orders, he immediately set out from there and joined battle with them at a village called Lessau. But Simon, the brother of Judas, had encountered Nicanor, yet not till late, having been delayed by reason of the sudden consternation caused by his adversaries. Nevertheless Nicanor, hearing of the valor of those who were with Judas, and their courage in fighting for their country, shrank from bringing the matter to the decision of the sword. Therefore he sent Posidonius, Theodotus, and Mattathias to give and receive pledges of friendship. So when these proposals had been long considered, and the leader had made the [j]troops acquainted with them, and it appeared that they were all of like mind, they consented to the covenants. They appointed a day on which to meet together by themselves. A chariot came forward from each army. They set up seats of honor. Judas stationed armed men ready in convenient places, lest perhaps there should suddenly be treachery on the part of the enemy. They held a conference as was appropriate. Nicanor waited in Jerusalem, and did nothing to cause disturbance, but dismissed the flocks of people that had gathered together. He kept Judas always in his presence. He had gained a hearty affection for the man. He urged him to marry and have children. He married, settled quietly, and took part in common life. But Alcimus, perceiving the good will that was between them, [k]and having taken possession of the covenants that had been made, came to Demetrius and told him that Nicanor was disloyal to the government, for he had appointed that conspirator against his kingdom, Judas, to be his successor. The king, falling into a rage, and being exasperated by the false accusations of that most wicked man, wrote to

[a] *13:24* The form of this word is uncertain. Compare Girzites (or Gizrites), **1** Samuel **27:8**. One manuscript reads Gerarenes.
[b] *13:26* Gr. came forward to the tribune or judgment seat.
[c] *14:6* That is, Chasidim.
[d] *14:7* Some authorities read a second time.
[e] *14:11* Or, the king's friends likewise
[f] *14:11* See **2** Maccabees **8:9**.
[g] *14:13* Gr. greatest.
[h] *14:14* See **2** Maccabees **5:27**.
[i] *14:16* The Greek text of this verse and the next is corrupt.
[j] *14:20* Or, people Gr. multitudes.
[k] *14:26* Or, and the covenants that had been made, took occasion and came

Nicanor, signifying that he was displeased at the covenants, and commanding him to send Maccabaeus prisoner to Antioch in all haste. When this message came to Nicanor, he was confounded, and was very troubled at the thought of annulling the articles that had been agreed upon, the man having done no wrong; but because there was no opposing the king, he watched his time to execute this purpose by strategy. But Maccabaeus, when he perceived that Nicanor was behaving more harshly in his dealings with him, and that he had become ruler in his customary bearing, understanding that this harshness came not of good, gathered together not a few of his men, and concealed himself from Nicanor. But the other,[a] when he became aware that he had been bravely defeated by the strategy of Judas,[b] came to the great[c] and holy temple, while the priests were offering the usual sacrifices, and commanded them to hand over the man. When they declared with oaths that they had no knowledge where the man was whom he sought, he stretched out his right hand toward the sanctuary, and swore this oath: "If you won't deliver up to me Judas as a prisoner, I will level this [d]temple of God even with the ground, break down the altar, and I will erect here a temple to Dionysus for all to see. And having said this, he departed. But the priests, stretching forth their hands toward heaven, called upon him who always fights for our nation, in these words: "You, O Lord of the universe, who in yourself have need of nothing, were well pleased that a sanctuary of your habitation[e] should be set among us. So now, O holy Lord of all holiness, keep undefiled forever this house that has been recently cleansed." Now information was given to Nicanor against one Razis, an elder of Jerusalem, who was a lover of his countrymen and a man of very good report, and one called Father of the Jews for his good will. For in the former times when there was no mingling with the Gentiles, he had been accused of following the Jews' religion, and had risked body and life with all earnestness for the religion of the Jews. Nicanor, wishing to make evident the ill will that he bore against the Jews, sent above five hundred soldiers to seize him; for he thought by seizing him to inflict an injury on them. But when the [f]troops were at the point of taking the tower, and were forcing the door of the court, and asked for fire to burn the doors, he, being surrounded on every side, fell upon his sword, choosing rather to die nobly than to fall into the hands of the wicked wretches, and suffer outrage unworthy of his own nobleness. But since he missed his stroke through the excitement of the struggle, and the crowds were now rushing within the door, he ran bravely up to the wall and cast himself down bravely among the crowds. But as they quickly gave back, a space was made, and he fell on the middle of [g]his side. Still having breath within him, and being inflamed with anger, he rose up, and though his blood gushed out in streams and his wounds were grievous, he ran through the crowds, and standing upon a steep rock, when as his blood was now well near spent, he drew forth his bowels through the wound, and taking them in both his hands he shook them at the crowds. Calling upon him who is Lord of life and spirit to restore him [h]these again, he died like this.

15

But Nicanor, hearing that Judas and his company were in the region of Samaria, resolved to attack them with complete safety on the day of rest. When the Jews who were compelled to follow him said, "Don't destroy so savagely and barbarously, but give due glory to the day which he who sees all things has honored and hallowed above other days." Then the thrice-accursed wretch asked if there were a Sovereign in heaven who had commanded to keep the Sabbath day. When they declared, "There is the Lord, living himself as Sovereign in heaven, who told us observe the seventh day." He replied, "I also am a sovereign on the earth, who commands you to take up weapons and execute the king's business." Nevertheless he didn't prevail to execute his cruel plan. And Nicanor, [i] in his utter boastfulness and arrogance, had determined to set up a monument of complete victory over Judas and all those who were with him. But Maccabaeus still trusted unceasingly, with all hope that he should obtain help from the Lord. He exhorted his company not to be fearful at the assault of the heathen, but keeping in mind the help which in former times they had often received from heaven, so now also to look for the victory which would come to them from the Almighty, and encouraging them out of the law and the prophets, and reminding them of the conflicts that they had won, he made them more eager. And when he had aroused their courage, he gave them orders, at the same time pointing out the faithlessness of the heathen and their breach of their oaths. Arming each one of them, not so much with the sure defense of shields and spears as with the encouragement of good words, and moreover relating to them a dream worthy to be believed, he made them all exceedingly glad. The vision of that dream was this: Onias, he who had been high priest, a noble and good man, modest in bearing, yet gentle in manner and well-

[a] *14:31* Or, though he was conscious that he had been nobly defeated by
[b] *14:31* Gr. the man
[c] *14:31* Gr. greatest.
[d] *14:33* Or, chapel Gr. enclosure.
[e] *14:35* Gr. tabernacling.
[f] *14:41* Or, people Gr. multitudes.
[g] *14:44* Or, the void place
[h] *14:46* Some authorities read the same.
[i] *15:6* Gr. carrying his neck high.

spoken, and trained from a child in all points of virtue, with outstretched hands invoking blessings on the whole body of the Jews. Then he saw a man appear, of venerable age and exceeding glory, and the dignity around him was wonderful and most majestic. Onias answered and said, "This is the lover of the kindred, he who prays much for the people and the holy city: Jeremiah the prophet of God. Jeremiah stretched out his right hand and delivered to Judas a gold sword, and in giving it addressed him thus: "Take this holy sword, a gift from God, with which you shall strike down the adversaries." Being encouraged by the words of Judas, which were noble and effective, and able to incite to virtue and to stir the souls of the young to manly courage, they determined not to carry on a campaign, but nobly to bear down upon the enemy, and fighting hand to hand with all courage bring the matter to a conclusion, because the city, the sanctuary, and the temple were in danger. For their fear for wives and children, and furthermore for family and relatives, was less important to them; but greatest and first was their fear for the consecrated sanctuary. Also those who were shut up in the city were in no light distress, being troubled because of the encounter in the open country. When all were now waiting for the decision of the issue, and the enemy had already joined battle, and the army had been set in array, and the elephants[a] brought back to a convenient post,[b] and the cavalry deployed on the flanks, Maccabaeus, perceiving the presence of the [c]troops, and the various weapons with which they were equipped, and the savageness of the [d]elephants, holding up his hands to heaven called upon the Lord who works wonders, knowing that success comes not by weapons, but that, according to how the Lord judges, he gains the victory for those who are worthy. And calling upon God, he said this: "You, O Sovereign Lord, sent your angel in the time of King Hezekiah of Judea, and he killed of the [e]army of Sennacherib as many as one hundred eighty-five thousand. So now also, O Sovereign of the heavens, send a good angel before us to bring terror and trembling. Through the greatness of your arm let them be stricken with dismay who with blasphemy have come here against your holy people." As he finished these words, Nicanor and his company advanced with trumpets and victory songs; but Judas and his company joined battle with the enemy with invocation and prayers. Fighting with their hands and praying to God with their hearts, they killed no less than thirty-five thousand men, being made exceedingly glad by the manifestation of God. When the engagement was over and they were returning again with joy, they recognized Nicanor lying dead in full armor. Then there was shouting and noise, and they blessed the Sovereign Lord in the language of their ancestors. He who in all things was in body and soul the foremost champion of his fellow-citizens, he who kept through life the good will of his youth toward his countrymen, ordered that Nicanor's head be cut off with his hand and arm, and that they be brought to Jerusalem. When he had arrived there and had called his countrymen together and set the priests before the altar, he sent for those who were in the citadel. Showing the head of the vile Nicanor and the hand of that profane man, which with proud brags he had stretched out against the holy house of the Almighty, and cutting out the tongue of the impious Nicanor, he said that he would give it in pieces to the birds, and hang up these rewards of his folly near the sanctuary. They all, looking up to heaven, blessed the Lord who had manifested himself, saying, "Blessed is he who has preserved his own place undefiled!" He hung Nicanor's head and shoulder from the citadel, a clear sign evident to all of the help of the Lord. They all ordained with a common decree to in no way let this day pass undistinguished, but to mark with honor the thirteenth day of the twelfth month (it is called Adar in the Syrian language), the day before the day of Mordecai. This then having been the account of the attempt of Nicanor, and the city having from those times been held by the Hebrews, I also will here make an end of my book. If I have written well and to the point in my story, this is what I myself desired; but if its poorly done and mediocre, this is the best I could do. For as it is [f]distasteful to drink wine alone and likewise to drink water alone, [g]while the mingling of wine with water at once gives full pleasantness to the flavor; so also the fashioning of the language delights the ears of those who read the story. Here is the end.

[a] *15:20* Gr. animals.
[b] *15:20* Or, stationed for convenient action
[c] *15:21* Gr. multitudes.
[d] *15:21* Gr. animals.
[e] *15:22* Gr. camp.
[f] *15:39* Or, hurtful
[g] *15:39* Gr. but even as.

The Third Book of the Maccabees

The Third Book of the Maccabees is recognized as Deuterocanonical Scripture by the Greek Orthodox and Russian Orthodox Churches. It is considered to be apocrypha by most other church traditions.

1

Now Philopater, on learning from those who came back that Antiochus had made himself master of the places which belonged to himself, sent orders to all his infantry and cavalry, took with him his sister Arsinoe, and marched out as far as the parts of Raphia, where Antiochus and his forces encamped. And one Theodotus, intending to carry out his design, took with him the bravest of the armed men who had been before committed to his trust by Ptolemy, and got through at night to the tent of Ptolemy, to kill him on his own responsibility, and so to end the war. But Dositheus, called the son of Drimulus, by birth a Jew, afterward a renegade from the laws and observances of his country, conveyed Ptolemy away, and made an obscure person lie down in his stead in the tent. It turned out that this man received the fate which was meant for the other. A fierce battle then took place. The men of Antiochus were prevailing. Arsinoe continually went up and down the ranks, and with dishevelled hair, with tears and entreaties, begged the soldiers to fight bravely for themselves, their children, and wives, and promised that if they proved conquerors, she would give them each two minas of gold. It thus fell out that their enemies were defeated in hand-to-hand encounter, and that many of them were taken prisoners. Having vanquished this attempt, the king then decided to proceed to the neighboring cities, and encourage them. By doing this, and by making donations to their temples, he inspired his subjects with confidence. The Jews sent some of their council and of their elders to him. The greetings, welcoming gifts, and congratulations of the past, given by them, filled him with the greater eagerness to visit their city. Having arrived at Jerusalem, sacrificed, and offered thank-offerings to the Greatest God, and done whatever else was suitable to the sanctity of the place, and entered the inner court, he was so impressed with the magnificence of the place, and so wondered at the orderly arrangements of the temple, that he considered entering the sanctuary itself. When they told him that this was not permissible, none of the nation, not even the priests in general, but only the supreme high priest of all, and he only once in a year, was allowed to go in, he would by no means give way. Then they read the law to him, but he persisted in intruding, exclaiming that he ought to be allowed. He said, "Even if they were deprived of this honor, I shouldn't be." He asked why, when he entered all the other temples, did none of the priests who were present forbid him. He was thoroughly answered by someone, that he did wrong to boast of this. "Well, since I have done this," said he, "be the cause what it may, shall I not enter with or without your consent?" When the priests fell down in their sacred vestments imploring the Greatest God to come and help in time of need, and to avert the violence of the fierce aggressor, and when they filled the temple with lamentations and tears, then those who had been left behind in the city were scared, and rushed out, uncertain of the event. Virgins, who had been shut up within their chambers, came out with their mothers, scattering dust and ashes on their heads, and filling the streets with outcries. Women who had recently been arrayed for marriage left their bridal chambers, left the reserve that befitted them, and ran around the city in a disorderly manner. New-born babes were deserted by the mothers or nurses who waited upon them—some here, some there, in houses, or in fields; these now, with an ardor which could not be checked, swarmed into the Most High temple. Various prayers were offered up by those who assembled in this place because of the unholy attempt of the king. Along with these there were some of the citizens who took courage and would not submit to his obstinacy and his intention of carrying out his purpose. Calling out to arms, and to die bravely in defense of the law of their fathers, they created a great uproar in the place, and were with difficulty brought back by the aged and the elders to the station of prayer which they had occupied before. During this time, the multitude kept on praying. The elders who surrounded the king tried in many ways to divert his arrogant mind from the design which he had formed. He, in his hardened mood, insensible to all persuasion, was going onward with the view of carrying out this design. Yet even his own officers, when they saw this, joined the Jews in an appeal to Him who has all power to aid in the present crisis, and not wink at such haughty lawlessness. Such was the frequency and the vehemence of the cry of the assembled crowd, that an indescribable noise ensued. Not the men only, but the very walls and floor seemed to sound out, all things preferring death rather than to see the place defiled.

2

Now it was that the high priest Simon bowed his knees near the holy place, spread out his hands in reverent form, and uttered the following prayer: "O Lord, Lord, King of the heavens, and Ruler of the whole creation, Holy among the holy, sole Governor, Almighty, give ear to us who are oppressed by a wicked and profane one, who celebrates in his confidence and strength. It is you, the Creator of all,

the Lord of the universe, who are a righteous Governor, and judge all who act with pride and insolence. It was you who destroyed the former workers of unrighteousness, among whom were the giants, who trusted in their strength and daring, by covering them with a measureless flood. It was you who made the Sodomites, those workers of exceedingly iniquity, men notorious for their vices, an example to later generations, when you covered them with fire and brimstone[a]. You made known your power when you caused the bold Pharaoh, the enslaver of your people, to pass through the ordeal of many and diverse inflictions. You rolled the depths of the sea over him when he pursued with chariots and with a multitude of followers, and gave a safe passage to those who put their trust in you, the Lord of the whole creation. These saw and felt the works of your hands, and praised you, the Almighty. You, O King, when you created the immeasurable and measureless earth, chose this city. You made this place sacred to your name, even though you need nothing. You glorified it with your illustrious presence, after constructing it to the glory of your great and honorable name. You promised, out of love for the people of Israel, that if we fall away from you, become afflicted, and then come to this house and pray, you would hear our prayer. Truly you are faithful and true. When you often aided our fathers when hard pressed and humiliated, and delivered them out of great dangers, see now, holy King, how through our many and great sins we are crushed and made subject to our enemies, and have become weak and powerless. In our low condition, this bold and profane man seeks to dishonor this your holy place, consecrated out of the earth to the name of your Majesty. Your dwelling place, the heaven of heavens, is indeed unapproachable to men. But since it seemed good to you to exhibit your glory among your people Israel, you sanctified this place. Don't punish us by means of the uncleanness of their men, and don't chastise us by means of their profanity, lest the lawless ones should boast in their rage, and exult in exuberant pride of speech, and say, 'We have trampled upon the holy house, as idolatrous houses are trampled upon.' Blot out our iniquities, do away with our errors, and show your compassion in this hour. Let your mercies quickly go before us. Grant us peace, that the downcast and broken hearted may praise you with their mouth." At that time God, who sees all things, who is beyond all Holy among the holy, heard that prayer, so suitable, and scourged the man who was greatly uplifted with scorn and insolence. Shaking him back and forth as a reed is shaken with the wind, he threw him down on the pavement, powerless, with limbs paralyzed, and by a righteous judgment deprived of the ability to speak. His friends and bodyguards, seeing the swift recompense which had suddenly overtaken him, struck with exceeding terror, and fearing that he would die, speedily removed him. When in course of time he had come to himself, this severe punishment caused no repentance within him, but he departed with bitter threatenings. He proceeded to Egypt, grew worse in wickedness through his previously mentioned companions in wine, who were lost to all goodness, and not satisfied with countless acts of impiety, his audacity so increased that he raised evil reports there, and many of his friends, watching his purpose attentively, joined in furthering his will. His purpose was to inflict a public stigma upon our race. Therefore he erected a stone pillar in the courtyard, and caused the following inscription to be engraved upon it: "Entrance to this temple is to be refused to all those who would not sacrifice. All the Jews were to be registered among the slaves. Those who resisted are to be forcibly seized and put to death. Those who are thus registered are to be marked on their persons by the ivy-leaf symbol of Dionysus, and to be reduced to these limited rights." To do away with the appearance of hating them all, he had it written underneath, that if any of them should elect to enter the community of those initiated in the rites, these should have equal rights with the Alexandrians. Some of those who were over the city, therefore, abhorring any approach to the city of piety, unhesitatingly gave in to the king, and expected to derive some great honor from a future connection with him. A nobler spirit, however, prompted the majority to cling to their religious observances, and by paying money that they might live unmolested, these sought to escape the registration, cheerfully looking forward to future aid, they abhorred their own apostates, considering them to be national foes, and depriving them of common fellowship and mutual help.

3

On discovering this, so incensed was the wicked king, that he no longer confined his rage to the Jews in Alexandria. Laying his hand more heavily upon those who lived in the country, he gave orders that they should be quickly collected into one place, and most cruelly deprived of their lives. While this was going on, a hostile rumor was uttered abroad by men who had banded together to injure the Jewish race. The pretext of their charge was that the Jews kept them away from the ordinances of the law. Now the Jews always maintained a feeling of unwavering loyalty toward the kings, yet, as they worshiped God and observed his law, they made certain distinctions,

[a] *2:5* or, sulfur

and avoided certain things. Hence they appeared hateful to some people, although, as they adorned their conversation with works of righteousness, they had established themselves in the good opinion of the world. What all the rest of mankind said was, however, disregarded by the foreigners, who said much of the exclusiveness of the Jews with regard to their worship and meats. They alleged that they were unsociable men, hostile to the king's interests, refusing to associate with him or his troops. By this way of speaking, they brought much hatred on them. This unexpected uproar and sudden gathering of people was observed by the Greeks who lived in the city, concerning men who had never harmed them. Yet to aid them was not in their power, since all was oppression around, but they encouraged them in their troubles, and expected a favorable turn of affairs. He who knows all things will not, they said, disregard so great a people. Some of the neighbors, friends, and business associates of the Jews even called them secretly to an interview, pledged them their assistance, and promised to do their very utmost for them. Now the king, elated with his prosperous fortune, and not regarding the superior power of God, but thinking to persevere in his present purpose, wrote the following letter to the prejudice of the Jews: "King Ptolemy Philopater, to the commanders and soldiers in Egypt, and in all places, health and happiness! I am doing well, and so, too, are my affairs. Since our Asiatic campaign, the particulars of which you know, and which by the aid of the gods, not lightly given, and by our own vigor, has been brought to a successful conclusion according to our expectation, we resolved, not with strength of spear, but with gentleness and much humanity, as it were to nurse the inhabitants of Coele-Syria and Phoenicia, and to be their willing benefactors. So, having bestowed considerable sums of money upon the temples of the several cities, we proceeded even as far as Jerusalem, and went up to honor the temple of these wretched beings who never cease from their folly. To outward appearance they received us willingly, but belied that appearance by their deeds. When we were eager to enter their temple, and to honor it with the most beautiful and exquisite gifts, they were so carried away by their old arrogance as to forbid us the entrance, while we, out of our forbearance toward all men, refrained from exercising our power upon them. Thus, exhibiting their enmity against us, they alone among the nations lift up their heads against kings and benefactors, as men unwilling to submit to any reasonable thing. We then, having endeavored to make allowance for the madness of these people, and on our victorious return treating all people in Egypt courteously, acted in a manner which was befitting. Accordingly, bearing no ill will against their kinsmen, but rather remembering our connection with them, and the numerous matters with sincere heart from a remote period entrusted to them, we wished to venture a total alteration of their state, by giving them the rights of citizens of Alexandria, and to admit them to the everlasting rites of our solemnities. All this, however, they have taken in a very different spirit. With their innate malignity, they have spurned the fair offer, and constantly inclining to evil, have rejected the inestimable rights. Not only so, but by using speech, and by refraining from speech, they abhor the few among them who are heartily disposed toward us, ever deeming that their infamous way of life will force us to do away with our reform. Having then received certain proofs that these Jews bear us every sort of ill will, we must look forward to the possibility of some sudden tumult among ourselves when these impious men may turn traitors and barbarous enemies. Therefore, as soon as the contents of this letter become known to you, in that same hour we order those Jews who dwell among you, with wives and children, to be sent to us, vilified and abused, in chains of iron, to undergo a cruel and shameful death, suitable to enemies. For by the punishment of them in one body we perceive that we have found the only means of establishing our affairs for the future on a firm and satisfactory basis. Whoever protects a Jew, whether it be old man, child, or nursing baby, shall with his whole house be tortured to death. Whoever informs against the Jews, besides receiving the property of the person charged, shall be presented with two thousand drachmas [a] from the royal treasury, shall be made free, and shall be crowned. Whatever place shelters a Jew shall be made unapproachable and shall be put under the ban of fire, and be forever rendered useless to every living being for all time to come." The king's letter was written in the above form.

4

Wherever this decree was received, the people kept up a revelry of joy and shouting, as if their long-pent-up, hardened hatred would now show itself openly. The Jews suffered great throes of sorrow and wept much, while their hearts, all things around being lamentable, were set on fire as they bewailed the sudden destruction which was decreed against them. What home, or city, or any inhabited place, or what streets were there, which their condition didn't fill with wailing and lamentation? They were sent out unanimously by the generals in various cities, with

[a] *3:28* a drachma was about a day's pay for an agricultural laborer

such stern and pitiless feeling that the exceptional nature of the infliction moved even some of their enemies. These, influenced by sentiments of common humanity, and reflecting upon the uncertain issue of life, shed tears at their miserable expulsion. A multitude of aged hoary-haired old men were driven along with halting bending feet, urged onward by the impulse of a violent, shameless force to quick speed. Girls who had entered the bridal chamber quite lately, to enjoy the partnership of marriage, exchanged pleasure for misery; and with dust scattered upon their myrrh-anointed heads, were hurried along unveiled; and, in the midst of outlandish insults, set up with one accord a lamentable cry instead of the marriage hymn. Bound and exposed to public gaze, they were hurried violently on board ship. The husbands of these, in the prime of their youthful vigor, instead of crowns, wore ropes round their necks. Instead of feasting and youthful celebration, they spent the rest of their nuptial days in wailing, and saw only the grave at hand. They were dragged along by unyielding chains, like wild animals. Of these, some had their necks thrust into the benches of the rowers, while the feet of others were enclosed in hard fetters. The planks of the deck above them blocked out the light and shut out the day on every side, so that they might be treated like traitors during the whole voyage. They were carried like this in this vessel, and at the end of it arrived at Schedia. The king had ordered them to be cast into the vast hippodrome, which was built in front of the city. This place was well adapted by its situation to expose them to the gaze of all comers into the city, and of those who went from the city into the country. Thus they could hold no communication with his forces. They weren't deemed worthy of any civilized accommodation. When this was done, the king, hearing that their kindred in the city often went out and lamented the melancholy distress of these victims, was full of rage, and commanded that they should be carefully subjected to the same—and not one bit milder—treatment. The whole nation was now to be registered. Every individual was to be specified by name, not for that hard servitude of labor which we have a little before mentioned, but that he might expose them to the before-mentioned tortures; and finally, in the short space of a day, might exterminate them by his cruelties. The registering of these men was carried on cruelly, zealously, assiduously, from the rising of the sun to its going down, and was not brought to an end in forty days. The king was filled with great and constant joy, and celebrated banquets before the temple idols. His erring heart, far from the truth, and his profane mouth gave glory to idols, deaf and incapable of speaking or aiding, and uttered unworthy speech against the Greatest God. At the end of the above-mentioned interval of time, the registrars brought word to the king that the multitude of the Jews was too great for registration, inasmuch as there were many still left in the land, of whom some were in inhabited houses, and others were scattered about in various places, so that all the commanders in Egypt were insufficient for the work. The king threatened them, and charged them with taking bribes, in order to contrive the escape of the Jews, but was clearly convinced of the truth of what had been said. They said, and proved, that paper and pens had failed them for the carrying out of their purpose. Now this was an active interference of the unconquerable Providence which assisted the Jews from heaven.

5

Then he called Hermon, who had charge of the elephants. Full of rage, altogether fixed in his furious design, he commanded him, with a quantity of unmixed wine with handfuls of incense infused, to drug the elephants early on the following day. These five hundred elephants were, when infuriated by the copious drinks of frankincense, to be led up to the execution of death upon the Jews. The king, after issuing these orders, went to his feasting, and gathered together all those of his friends and of the army who hated the Jews the most. The master of the elephants, Hermon, fulfilled his commission punctually. The servants appointed for the purpose went out about evening and bound the hands of the miserable victims, and took other precautions for their security at night, thinking that the whole race would perish together. The heathen believed the Jews to be destitute of all protection, for chains bound them. They invoked the Almighty Lord, and ceaselessly implored with tears their merciful God and Father, Ruler of all, Lord of every power, to overthrow the evil purpose which had gone out against them, and to deliver them by extraordinary manifestation from that death which was in store for them. Their earnest entreaty went up to heaven. Then Hermon, who had filled his merciless elephants with copious drinks of mixed wine and frankincense, came early to the palace to report on these preparations. He, however, who has sent his good creature sleep from all time by night or by day thus gratifying whom he wills, diffused a portion of it now upon the king. By this sweet and profound influence of the Lord, he was held fast, and thus his unjust purpose was quite frustrated, and his unflinching resolve greatly falsified. But the Jews, having escaped the hour which had been fixed, praised their holy God, and again prayed him who is easily reconciled to display the power of his powerful hand to the arrogant Gentiles. The middle of the tenth hour had nearly arrived, when the person who

sent invitations, seeing the guests who were invited present, came and shook the king. He gained his attention with difficulty, and hinting that the mealtime was getting past, talked the matter over with him. The king listened to this, and then turning aside to his drinking, commanded the guests to sit down before him. This done, he asked them to enjoy themselves, and to indulge in mirth at this somewhat late hour of the banquet. Conversation grew on, and the king sent for Hermon, and inquired of him, with fierce denunciations, why the Jews had been allowed to outlive that day. Hermon explained that he had done his bidding over night; and in this he was confirmed by his friends. The king, then, with a barbarity exceeding that of Phalaris, said, "They might thank his sleep of that day. Lose no time, and get ready the elephants against tomorrow, as you did before, for the destruction of these accursed Jews." When the king said this, the company present were glad, and approved. Then each man went to his own home. They didn't employ the night in sleep, but in contriving cruel mockeries for those deemed miserable. The morning cock had just crowed, and Hermon, having harnessed the brutes, was stimulating them in the great colonnade. The city crowds were collected together to see the hideous spectacle, and waited impatiently for the dawn. The Jews, breathless with momentary suspense, stretched out their hands and prayed the Greatest God, in mournful strains, again to help them speedily. The sun's rays were not yet shining and the king was waiting for his friends when Hermon came to him, calling him out, and saying that his desires could now be realized. The king, receiving him, was astonished at his unusual invitation. Overwhelmed with a spirit of oblivion about everything, inquired about the object of this earnest preparation. But this was the working of that Almighty God who had made him forget all his purpose. Hermon and all his friends pointed out the preparation of the animals. They are ready, O king, according to your own strict injunction. The king was filled with fierce anger at these words, for, by the Providence of God regarding these things, his mind had become entirely confused. He looked hard at Hermon, and threatened him as follows: "Your parents, or your children, were they here, would have given a large meal to these wild animals, not these innocent Jews, who have loyally served me and my forefathers. Had it not been for familiar friendship, and the claims of your office, your life should have gone for theirs." Hermon, being threatened in this unexpected and alarming manner, was troubled in his eyes, and his face fell. The friends, too, stole out one by one, and dismissed the assembled multitudes to their respective occupations. The Jews, having heard of these events, praised the glorious God and King of kings, because they had obtained this help, too, from him. Now the king arranged another banquet in the same way, and proclaimed an invitation to mirth. He summoned Hermon to his presence, and said, with threats, "How often, O wretch, must I repeat my orders to you about these same persons? Once more, arm the elephants for the extermination of the Jews tomorrow!" His kinsmen, who were reclining with him, wondered at his instability, and thus expressed themselves: "O king, how long do you test us, as of men bereft of reason? This is the third time that you have ordered their destruction. When the thing is to be done, you change your mind, and recall your instructions. Because of this, the feeling of expectation causes tumult in the city. It swarms with factions, and is continually on the point of being plundered." The king, just like another Phalaris, a prey to thoughtlessness, made no account of the changes which his own mind had undergone, issuing in the deliverance of the Jews. He swore a fruitless oath, and determined immediately to send them to hades, crushed by the knees and feet of the elephants. He would also invade Judea, level its towns with fire and the sword, destroy that temple which the heathen might not enter, and prevent sacrifices ever after being offered up there. Joyfully his friends broke up, together with his kinsmen; and, trusting in his determination, arranged their forces in guard at the most convenient places of the city. The master of the elephants urged the animals into an almost maniacal state, drenched them with incense and wine, and decked them with frightful devices. About early morning, when the city was filled with an immense number of people at the hippodrome, he entered the palace and called the king to the business in hand. The king's heart teemed with impious rage; and he rushed forth with the mass, along with the elephants. With unsoftened feelings and pitiless eyes, he longed to gaze at the hard and wretched doom of the previously mentioned Jews. But the Jews, when the elephants went out at the gate, followed by the armed force. When they saw the dust raised by the throng, and heard the loud cries of the crowd, thought that they had come to the last moment of their lives, to the end of what they had tremblingly expected. They gave way, therefore, to lamentations and moans. They kissed each other. Those nearest of kin to each other hung around one another's necks—fathers hugging their sons and mothers their daughters. Other women held their infants to their breasts, which drew what seemed their last milk. Nevertheless, when they reflected upon the help previously granted them from heaven, they prostrated themselves with one accord, removed even the sucking children from the breasts, and sent

up an exceedingly great cry asking the Lord of all power to reveal himself, and have mercy upon those who now lay at the gates of hades.

6

Then Eleazar, an illustrious priest of the country, who had attained to length of days, and whose life had been adorned with virtue, caused the elders who were around him to cease to cry out to the holy God, and prayed this: "O king, mighty in power, most high, Almighty God, who regulates the whole creation with your tender mercy, look at the seed of Abraham, at the children of the sanctified Jacob, your sanctified inheritance, O Father, now being wrongfully destroyed as foreigners in a foreign land. You destroyed Pharaoh with his army of chariots when that lord of this same Egypt was uplifted with lawless daring and loud-sounding tongue. Shedding the beams of your mercy upon the race of Israel, you overwhelmed him and his proud army. When Sennacherim, the grievous king of the Assyrians, exulting in his countless army, had subdued the whole land with his spear and was lifting himself against your holy city with boastings grievous to be endured, you, O Lord, demolished him and displayed your might to many nations. When the three friends in the land of Babylon of their own will exposed their lives to the fire rather than serve vain things, you sent a moist coolness through the fiery furnace, and brought the fire on all their adversaries. It was you who, when Daniel was hurled, through slander and envy, as a prey to lions down below, brought him back again unharmed to light. When Jonah was pining away in the belly of the sea-born monster, you looked at him, O Father, and recovered him to the sight of his own. Now, you who hate insolence, you who abound in mercy, you who are the protector of all things, appear quickly to those of the race of Israel, who are insulted by abhorred, lawless gentiles. If our life during our exile has been stained with iniquity, deliver us from the hand of the enemy, and destroy us, O Lord, by the death which you prefer. Don't let the vain-minded congratulate vain idols at the destruction of your beloved, saying, 'Their god didn't deliver them.' You who are All-powerful and Almighty, O Eternal One, behold! Have mercy on us who are being withdrawn from life, like traitors, by the unreasoning insolence of lawless men. Let the heathen cower before your invincible might today, O glorious One, who have all power to save the race of Jacob. The whole band of infants and their parents ask you with tears. Let it be shown to all the nations that you are with us, O Lord, and have not turned your face away from us, but as you said that you would not forget them even in the land of their enemies, so fulfill this saying, O Lord." Now, at the time that Eleazar had ended his prayer, the king came along to the hippodrome with the wild animals, and with his tumultuous power. When the Jews saw this, they uttered a loud cry to heaven so that the adjacent valleys resounded and caused an irrepressible lamentation throughout the army. Then the all-glorious, all-powerful, and true God, displayed his holy countenance, and opened the gates of heaven, from which two angels, dreadful of form, came down and were visible to all but the Jews. They stood opposite, and filled the enemies' army with confusion and cowardice, and bound them with immoveable shackles. A cold shudder came over the person of the king, and oblivion paralyzed the vehemence of his spirit. They turned back the animals on the armed forces who followed them; and the animals trampled them and destroyed them. The king's wrath was converted into compassion; and he wept at the things he had devised. For when he heard the cry, and saw them all on the verge of destruction, with tears he angrily threatened his friends, saying, "You have governed badly, and have exceeded tyrants in cruelty. You have labored to deprive me, your benefactor, at once of my dominion and my life, by secretly devising measures injurious to the kingdom. Who has gathered here, unreasonably removing each from his home, those who, in fidelity to us, had held the fortresses of the country? Who has consigned to unmerited punishments those who in good will toward us from the beginning have in all things surpassed all nations, and who often have engaged in the most dangerous undertakings? Loose, loose the unjust bonds! Send them to their homes in peace, begging pardon for what has been done. Release the sons of the almighty living God of heaven, who from our ancestors' times until now has granted a glorious and uninterrupted prosperity to our affairs." He said these things, and they, released the same moment, having now escaped death, praised God their holy Savior. The king then departed to the city, and called his financier to himself, and asked him provide a seven days' quantity of wine and other materials for feasting for the Jews. He decided that they should keep a cheerful festival of deliverance in the very place in which they expected to meet with their destruction. Then they who were before despised and near to hades, yes, rather advanced into it, partook of the cup of salvation, instead of a grievous and lamentable death. Full of exultation, they apportioned the place intended for their fall and burial into banqueting booths. Ceasing their miserable strain of woe, they took up the subject of their fatherland, singing in praise to God their wonder-working Savior. All groans and all wailing were laid aside. They formed dances as a sign of peaceful joy. So the king also collected a number of guests for the occasion, and

returned unceasing thanks with much magnificence for the unexpected deliverance afforded him. Those who had marked them out as for death and for carrion, and had registered them with joy, howled aloud, and were clothed with shame, and had the fire of their rage ingloriously put out. But the Jews, as we just said, instituted a dance, and then gave themselves up to feasting, glad thanksgiving, and psalms. They made a public ordinance to commemorate these things for generations to come, as long as they should be sojourners. They thus established these days as days of mirth, not for the purpose of drinking or luxury, but because God had saved them. They requested the king to send them back to their homes. They were being enrolled from the twenty-fifth of Pachon to the fourth of Epiphi, a period of forty days. The measures taken for their destruction lasted from the fifth of Epiphi till the seventh, that is, three days. The Ruler over all during this time manifested his mercy gloriously, and delivered them all together unharmed. They feasted upon the king's provision up to the fourteenth day, then asked to be sent away. The king commended them, and wrote the following letter, of magnanimous import for them, to the commanders of every city:

7

"King Ptolemy Philopator to the commanders throughout Egypt, and to all who are set over affairs, joy and strength. We, too, and our children are well. God has directed our affairs as we wish. Certain of our friends out of malice vehemently urged us to punish the Jews of our realm in a body, with the infliction of a monstrous punishment. They pretended that our affairs would never be in a good state till this took place. Such, they said, was the hatred borne by the Jews to all other people. They brought them fettered in grievous chains as slaves, no, as traitors. Without enquiry or examination they endeavored to annihilate them. They buckled themselves with a savage cruelty, worse than Scythian custom. For this cause we severely threatened them; yet, with the clemency which we usually extend to all men, we at length permitted them to live. Finding that the God of heaven cast a shield of protection over the Jews so as to preserve them, and that he fought for them as a father always fights for his sons, and taking into consideration their constancy and fidelity toward us and toward our ancestors, we have, as we ought, acquitted them of every sort of charge. We have dismissed them to their several homes, telling all men everywhere to do them no wrong, or unrighteously revile them about the past. For know this, that should we conceive any evil design, or in any way aggrieve them, we shall ever have as our adversary, not man, but the highest God, the ruler of all might. From Him there will be no escape, as the avenger of such deeds. Farewell."

When they had received this letter, they didn't hurry to depart immediately. They petitioned the king to be allowed to inflict fitting punishment upon those of their race who had willingly transgressed the holy god, and the law of God. They alleged that men who had for their bellies' sake transgressed the ordinances of God, would never be faithful to the interests of the king. The king admitted the truth of this reasoning, and commended them. Full power was given them, without warrant or special commission, to destroy those who had transgressed the law of God boldly in every part of the king's dominions. Their priests, then, as it was appropriate, saluted him with good wishes, and all the people echoed with the "Hallelujah!" Then they joyfully departed. Then they punished and shamefully destroyed every polluted Jew that fell in their way, slaying this way, in that day, more than three hundred men, and esteeming this destruction of the wicked a season of joy. They themselves having held closely to their God to death, and having enjoyed a full deliverance, departed from the city garlanded with sweet-flowered wreaths of every kind. Uttering exclamations of joy, with songs of praise, and melodious hymns, they thanked the God of their fathers, the eternal Savior of Israel. Having arrived at Ptolemais, called from the specialty of that district "Rose-bearing", where the fleet, in accordance with the general wish, waited for them seven days, they partook of a banquet of deliverance, for the king generously granted them all the means of securing a return home. They were accordingly brought back in peace, while they gave utterance to appropriate thanks; and they determined to observe these days during their sojourn as days of joyfulness. These they registered as sacred upon a pillar, when they had dedicated the place of their festivity to be one of prayer. They departed unharmed, free, abundant in joy, preserved by the king's command, by land, by sea, and by river, each to his own home. They had more weight than before among their enemies, and were honored and feared. No one in any way robbed them of their goods. Every man received back his own, according to inventory, those who had obtained their goods, giving them up with the greatest terror. For the greatest God made perfect wonders for their salvation. Blessed be the Redeemer of Israel forever! Amen.

The Fourth Book of the Maccabees

The Fourth Book of the Maccabees appears in an appendix to the Greek Septuagint. It is considered to be apocrypha by most church traditions. It is preserved here for its supplementary historical value.

1

1 As I am going to demonstrate a most philosophical proposition, namely, that religious reasoning is absolute master of the emotions. I would willingly advise you to give the utmost heed to philosophy. 2 For reason is necessary to everyone as a step to science. In addition, it embraces the praise of self-control, the highest virtue. 3 If, then, reasoning appears to hold the mastery over the emotions which stand in the way of temperance, such as gluttony and lust, 4 it surely also and manifestly rules over the affections which are contrary to justice, such as malice, and of those which are hindrances to courage, such as wrath, pain, and fear. 5 Perhaps some may ask, "How is it, then, that reasoning, if it rules the emotions, isn't also master of forgetfulness and ignorance?" They attempt a ridiculous argument. 6 For reasoning does not rule over its own emotions, but over those that are contrary to justice, courage, temperance, and self-control; and yet over these, so as to withstand, without destroying them. 7 I might prove to you from many other considerations, that religious reasoning is sole master of the emotions; 8 but I will prove it with the greatest force from the fortitude of Eleazar, and seven kindred, and their mother, who suffered death in defense of virtue. 9 For all these, treating pains with contempt even to death, by this contempt, demonstrated that reasoning has command over the emotions. 10 For their virtues, then, it is right that I should commend those men who died with their mother at this time on behalf of nobility and goodness; and for their honors, I may count them blessed. 11 For they, winning admiration not only from men in general, but even from the persecutors, for their courage and endurance, became the means of the destruction of the tyranny against their nation, having conquered the tyrant by their endurance, so that by them their country was purified. 12 But we may now at once enter upon the question, having commenced, as is our custom, with laying down the doctrine, and so proceed to the account of these people, giving glory to the all-wise God. 13 Therefore the question whether reasoning is absolute master of the emotions. 14 Let's determine, then, what reasoning is and what emotion is, and how many forms of emotion there are, and whether reasoning rules over all of these. 15 Reasoning is intellect accompanied by a life of righteousness, putting foremost the consideration of wisdom. 16 Wisdom is a knowledge of divine and human things, and of their causes. 17 This is contained in the education of the law, by means of which we learn divine things reverently and human things profitably. 18 The forms of wisdom are self-control, justice, courage, and temperance. 19 The leading one of these is self-control, by whose means, indeed, it is that reasoning rules over the emotions. 20 Of the emotions, pleasure and pain are the two most comprehensive; and they also by nature refer to the soul. 21 There are many attendant affections surrounding pleasure and pain. 22 Before pleasure is lust; and after pleasure, joy. 23 Before pain is fear; and after pain is sorrow. 24 Wrath is an affection, common to pleasure and to pain, if any one will pay attention when it comes upon him. 25 There exists in pleasure a malicious disposition, which is the most complex of all the affections. 26 In the soul, it is arrogance, love of money, thirst for honor, contention, faithlessness, and the evil eye. 27 In the body, it is greediness, indiscriminate eating, and solitary gluttony. 28 As pleasure and pain are, therefore, two growths out of the body and the soul, so there are many offshoots of these emotions. 29 Reasoning, the universal farmer, purging and pruning each of these, tying up, watering, and transplanting, in every way improves the materials of the morals and affections. 30 For reasoning is the leader of the virtues, but it is the sole ruler of the emotions. Observe then first, through the very things which stand in the way of temperance, that reasoning is absolute ruler of the emotions. 31 Now temperance consists of a command over the lusts. 32 But of the lusts, some belong to the soul and others to the body. Reasoning appears to rule over both. 33 Otherwise, how is it that when urged on to forbidden meats, we reject the gratification which would come from them? Isn't it because reasoning is able to command the appetites? I believe so. 34 Hence it is, then, that when craving seafood, birds, four-footed animals, and all kinds of food which are forbidden to us by the law, we withhold ourselves through the mastery of reasoning. 35 For the affections of our appetites are resisted by the temperate understanding, and bent back again, and all the impulses of the body are reined in by reasoning.

2

1 Is it any wonder? If the lusts of the soul, after participation with what is beautiful, are frustrated, 2 on this ground, therefore, the temperate Joseph is praised in that by reasoning, he subdued, on reflection, the indulgence of the senses. 3 For, although young, and ripe for sexual intercourse, he nullified by reasoning the stimulus of his emotions. 4 It isn't merely the stimulus of sensual indulgence, but that of every desire, that reasoning is able to

master. 5 For instance, the law says, “You shall not
covet your neighbor’s wife, nor anything that
belongs to your neighbor.” 6 Now, then, since it is the
law which has forbidden us to desire, I shall much
the more easily persuade you, that reasoning is able
to govern our lusts, just as it does the affections
which are impediments to justice. 7 Since in what
way is a solitary eater, a glutton, and a drunkard
reclaimed, unless it is clear that reasoning is lord of
the emotions? 8 Therefore, a man who regulates his
course by the law, even if he is a lover of money,
immediately puts pressure on his own disposition by
lending to the needy without interest, and cancelling
the debt on the seventh year. 9 If a man is greedy, he
is ruled by the law acting through reasoning, so that
he doesn’t glean his harvest crops or vintage. In
reference to other points we may perceive that it is
reasoning that conquers his emotions. 10 For the law
conquers even affection toward parents, not
surrendering virtue on their account. 11 It prevails
over love for one’s wife, rebuking her when she
breaks the law. 12 It lords it over the love of parents
toward their children, for they punish them for vice.
It domineers over the intimacy of friends, reproving
them when wicked. 13 Don’t think it is a strange
assertion that reasoning can on behalf of the law
conquer even enmity. 14 It doesn’t allow cutting
down the fruit trees of an enemy, but preserves them
from the destroyers, and collects their fallen ruins.
15 Reason appears to be master of the more violent
emotions, like love of empire, empty boasting, and
slander. 16 For the temperate understanding repels all
these malignant emotions, as it does wrath; for it
masters even this. 17 Thus Moses, when angered
against Dathan and Abiram, did nothing to them in
wrath, but regulated his anger by reasoning. 18 For
the temperate mind is able, as I said, to be superior to
the emotions, and to correct some and destroy others.
19 For why else did our most wise father Jacob blame
Simeon and Levi for having irrationally slain the
whole race of the Shechemites, saying, “Cursed be
their anger!”? 20 For if reasoning didn’t possess the
power of subduing angry affections, he would not
have said this. 21 For at the time when God created
man, he implanted within him his emotions and
moral nature. 22 At that time he enthroned the mind
above all as the holy leader, through the medium of
the senses. 23 He gave a law to this mind, by living
according to which it will maintain a temperate, just,
good, and courageous reign. 24 How, then, a man may
say, if reasoning is master of the emotions, has it no
control over forgetfulness and ignorance?

3

1 The argument is exceedingly ridiculous, for
reasoning doesn’t appear to rule over its own
affections, but over those of the body, 2 in such a way
as that any one of you may not be able to root out
desire, but reasoning will enable you to avoid being
enslaved to it. 3 One may not be able to root out anger
from the soul, but it is possible to withstand anger.
4 Any one of you may not be able to eradicate malice,
but reasoning has force to work with you to prevent
you yielding to malice. 5 For reasoning is not an
eradicator, but an antagonist of the emotions. 6 This
may be more clearly comprehended from the thirst of
King David. 7 For after David had been attacking the
Philistines the whole day, he with the soldiers of his
nation killed many of them; 8 then when evening
came, sweating and very weary, he came to the royal
tent, around which the entire army of our ancestors
was encamped. 9 Now all the rest of them were at
supper; 10 but the king, being very much thirsty,
although he had numerous springs, could not by their
means quench his thirst; 11 but a certain irrational
longing for the water in the enemy’s camp grew
stronger and fiercer upon him, undid and consumed
him. 12 Therefore his bodyguards being troubled at
this longing of the king, two valiant young soldiers,
respecting the desire of the king, fully armed
themselves, and taking a pitcher, got over the
ramparts of the enemies. 13 Unperceived by the
guardians of the gate, they went throughout the
whole camp of the enemy in quest. 14 Having boldly
discovered the fountain, they filled out of it the drink
for the king. 15 But he, though parched with thirst,
reasoned that a drink regarded of equal value to
blood would be terribly dangerous to his soul.
16 Therefore, setting up reasoning in opposition to his
desire, he poured out the drink to God. 17 For the
temperate mind has power to conquer the pressure of
the emotions, to quench the fires of excitement,
18 and to wrestle down the pains of the body, however
excessive, and through the excellency of reasoning,
to spurn all the assaults of the emotions. 19 But the
occasion now invites us to give an illustration of
temperate reasoning from history. 20 For at a time
when our fathers were in possession of undisturbed
peace through obedience to the law and were
prosperous, so that Seleucus Nicanor, the king of
Asia, both assigned them money for divine service,
and accepted their form of government, 21 then
certain people, bringing in new things contrary to the
public harmony, in various ways fell into calamities.

4

1 For a certain man named Simon, who was in
opposition to an honorable and good man who once
held the high priesthood for life, named Onias. After
slandering Onias in every way, Simon couldn’t injure
him with the people, so he went away as an exile,
with the intention of betraying his country. 2 When
coming to Apollonius, the military governor of Syria,
Phoenicia, and Cilicia, he said, 3 “Having good will

to the king's affairs, I have come to inform you that
tens of thousands in private wealth is laid up in the
treasuries of Jerusalem which do not belong to the
temple, but belong to King Seleucus." 4 Apollonius,
acquainting himself with the particulars of this,
praised Simon for his care of the king's interests, and
going up to Seleucus informed him of the treasure.
5 Getting authority about it, and quickly advancing
into our country with the accursed Simon and a very
heavy force, 6 he said that he came with the
commands of the king that he should take the private
money of the treasury. 7 The nation, indignant at this
proclamation, and replying to the effect that it was
extremely unfair that those who had committed
deposits to the sacred treasury should be deprived of
them, resisted as well as they could. 8 But
Appolonius went away with threats into the temple.
9 The priests, with the women and children, asked
God to throw his shield over the holy, despised place,
10 and Appolonius was going up with his armed force
to seize the treasure, when angels from heaven
appeared riding on horseback, all radiant in armor,
filling them with much fear and trembling.
11 Apollonius fell half dead on the court which is
open to all nations, and extended his hands to heaven,
and implored the Hebrews, with tears, to pray for him,
and take away the wrath of the heavenly army. 12 For
he said that he had sinned, so as to be consequently
worthy of death, and that if he were saved, he would
proclaim to all people the blessedness of the holy
place. 13 Onias the high priest, induced by these
words, although for other reasons anxious that King
Seleucus wouldn't suppose that Apollonius was slain
by human device and not by Divine punishment,
prayed for him; 14 and he being thus unexpectedly
saved, departed to report to the king what had
happened to him. 15 But on the death of Seleucus the
king, his son Antiochus Epiphanes succeeded to the
kingdom—a terrible man of arrogant pride. 16 He,
having deposed Onias from the high priesthood,
appointed his brother Jason to be high priest, 17 who
had made a covenant, if he would give him this
authority, to pay yearly three thousand six hundred
and sixty talents. 18 He committed to him the high
priesthood and rulership over the nation. 19 He both
changed the manner of living of the people, and
perverted their civil customs into all lawlessness.
20 So that he not only erected a gymnasium on the
very citadel of our country, but neglected the
guardianship of the temple. 21 Because of that,
Divine vengeance was grieved and instigated
Antiochus himself against them. 22 For being at war
with Ptolemy in Egypt, he heard that on a report of
his death being spread abroad, the inhabitants of
Jerusalem had exceedingly rejoiced, and he quickly
marched against them. 23 Having subdued them, he
established a decree that if any of them lived
according to the ancestral laws, he should die.
24 When he could by no means destroy by his decrees
the obedience to the law of the nation, but saw all his
threats and punishments without effect, 25 for even
women, because they continued to circumcise their
children, were flung down a precipice along with
them, knowing beforehand of the punishment.
26 When, therefore, his decrees were disregarded by
the people, he himself compelled by means of
tortures every one of this race, by tasting forbidden
meats, to renounce the Jewish religion.

5

1 The tyrant Antiochus, therefore, sitting in public
state with his assessors upon a certain lofty place,
with his armed troops standing in a circle around him,
2 commanded his spearbearers to seize every one of
the Hebrews, and to compel them to taste swine's
flesh and things offered to idols. 3 Should any of
them be unwilling to eat the accursed food, they were
to be tortured on the wheel and so killed. 4 When
many had been seized, a foremost man of the
assembly, a Hebrew, by name Eleazar, a priest by
family, by profession a lawyer, and advanced in
years, and for this reason known to many of the
king's followers, was brought near to him.
5 Antiochus, seeing him, said, 6 "I would counsel you,
old man, before your tortures begin, to taste the
swine's flesh, and save your life; for I feel respect for
your age and hoary head, which since you have had
so long, you appear to me to be no philosopher in
retaining the superstition of the Jews. 7 For therefore,
since nature has conferred upon you the most
excellent flesh of this animal, do you loathe it? 8 It
seems senseless not to enjoy what is pleasant, yet not
disgraceful; and from notions of sinfulness, to reject
the gifts of nature. 9 You will be acting, I think, still
more senselessly, if you follow vain conceits about
the truth. 10 You will, moreover, be despising me to
your own punishment. 11 Won't you awake from
your trifling philosophy, give up the folly of your
notions, and regaining understanding worthy of your
age, search into the truth of an expedient course?
12 Won't you respect my kindly admonition and have
pity on your own years? 13 For bear in mind that if
there is any power which watches over this religion
of yours, it will pardon you for all transgressions of
the law which you commit through compulsion."
14 While the tyrant incited him in this manner to the
unlawful eating of meat, Eleazar begged permission
to speak. 15 Having received permission to speak, he
began to address the people as follows: 16 "We, O
Antiochus, who are persuaded that we live under a
divine law, consider no compulsion to be so forcible
as obedience to that law. 17 Therefore we consider
that we ought not to transgress the law in any way.

18 Indeed, were our law (as you suppose) not truly divine, and if we wrongly think it divine, we would have no right even in that case to destroy our sense of religion. 19 Don't think that eating unclean meat is a trifling offense. 20 For transgression of the law, whether in small or great matters, is of equal importance; 21 for in either case the law is equally slighted. 22 But you deride our philosophy, as though we lived in it irrationally. 23 Yet it instructs us in self-control, so that we are superior to all pleasures and lusts; and it trains us in courage, so that we cheerfully undergo every grievance. 24 It instructs us in justice, so that in all our dealings we render what is due. It teaches us piety, so that we properly worship the one and only God. 25 That is why we don't eat the unclean; for believing that the law was established by God, we are convinced that the Creator of the world, in giving his laws, sympathizes with our nature. 26 Those things which are suitable for our souls, he has directed us to eat; but those which are not, he has forbidden. 27 But, tyrant-like, you not only force us to break the law, but also to eat, that you may ridicule us as we thus profanely eat. 28 But you won't have this cause of laughter against me, 29 nor will I transgress the sacred oaths of my forefathers to keep the law. 30 No, not if you pluck out my eyes, and consume my entrails. 31 I am not so old, and void of courage as to not be youthful in reason and in defense of my religion. 32 Now then, prepare your wheels, and kindle a fiercer flame. 33 I will not so pity my old age, as on my account to break the law of my country. 34 I will not play false to you, O law, my instructor, or forsake you, O beloved self-control! 35 I will not put you to shame, O philosopher Reason, or deny you, O honored priesthood and knowledge of the law. 36 Mouth! You shall not pollute my old age, nor the full stature of a perfect life. 37 My ancestors will receive me as pure, not having feared your compulsion, even to death. 38 For you will rule like a tyrant over the ungodly, but you will not lord it over my thoughts about religion, either by your arguments, or through deeds."

6

1 When Eleazar had in this manner answered the exhortations of the tyrant, the spearbearers came up, and rudely dragged Eleazar to the instruments of torture. 2 First, they stripped the old man, adorned as he was with the beauty of piety. 3 Then tying back his arms and hands, they disdainfully flogged him. 4 A herald opposite cried out, "Obey the commands of the king!" 5 But the high-minded and truly noble Eleazar, as one tortured in a dream, ignored it. 6 But raising his eyes on high to heaven, the old man's flesh was stripped off by the scourges, and his blood streamed down, and his sides were pierced through. 7 Falling on the ground from his body having no power to endure the pains, he still kept his reasoning upright and unbending. 8 Then one of the harsh spearbearers rushed at him and began to kick him in the side to force him to get up again after he fell. 9 But he endured the pains, despised the cruelty, and persevered through the indignities. 10 Like a noble athlete, the old man, when struck, vanquished his torturers. 11 His face sweating, and he panting for breath, he was admired even by the torturers for his courage. 12 Therefore, partly in pity for his old age, 13 partly from the sympathy of acquaintance, and partly in admiration of his endurance, some of the attendants of the king said, 14 "Why do you unreasonably destroy yourself, O Eleazar, with these miseries? 15 We will bring you some meat cooked by yourself, and you can save yourself by pretending that you have eaten swine's flesh." 16 Eleazar, as though the advice more painfully tortured him, cried out, 17 "Let us who are children of Abraham not be so evil advised as by giving way to make use of an unbecoming pretense. 18 For it would be irrational, if having lived up to old age in all truth, and having scrupulously guarded our character for it, we would now turn back 19 and ourselves become a pattern of impiety to the young, as being an example of eating pollution. 20 It would be disgraceful if we would live on some short time, and that scorned by all men for cowardice, 21 and be condemned by the tyrant for cowardice by not contending to the death for our divine law. 22 Therefore you, O children of Abraham, die nobly for your religion. 23 You spearbearers of the tyrant, why do you linger?" 24 Beholding him so high-minded against misery, and not changing at their pity, they led him to the fire. 25 Then with their wickedly contrived instruments they burned him on the fire, and poured stinking fluids down into his nostrils. 26 He being at length burned down to the bones, and about to expire, raised his eyes Godward, and said, 27 "You know, O God, that when I might have been saved, I am slain for the sake of the law by tortures of fire. 28 Be merciful to your people, and be satisfied with the punishment of me on their account. 29 Let my blood be a purification for them, and take my life in exchange for theirs." 30 Thus speaking, the holy man departed, noble in his torments, and even to the agonies of death resisted in his reasoning for the sake of the law. 31 Confessedly, therefore, religious reasoning is master of the emotions. 32 For had the emotions been superior to reasoning, I would have given them the witness of this mastery. 33 But now, since reasoning conquered the emotions, we befittingly award it the authority of first place. 34 It is only fair that we should allow that the power belongs to reasoning, since it masters external miseries. 35 It would be ridiculous if it weren't so. I prove that

reasoning has not only mastered pains, but that it is also superior to the pleasures, and withstands them.

7

1 The reasoning of our father Eleazar, like a first-rate pilot, steering the vessel of piety in the sea of emotions, 2 and flouted by the threats of the tyrant, and overwhelmed with the breakers of torture, 3 in no way shifted the rudder of piety until it sailed into the harbor of victory over death. 4 No besieged city has ever held out against many and various war machines as that holy man did when his pious soul was tried with the fiery trial of tortures and rackings and moved his besiegers through the religious reasoning that shielded him. 5 For father Eleazar, projecting his disposition, broke the raging waves of the emotions as with a jutting cliff. 6 O priest worthy of the priesthood! You didn't pollute your sacred teeth, nor make your appetite, which had always embraced the clean and lawful, a partaker of profanity. 7 O harmonizer with the law, and sage devoted to a divine life! 8 Of such a character ought those to be who perform the duties of the law at the risk of their own blood, and defend it with generous sweat by sufferings even to death. 9 You, father, have gloriously established our right government by your endurance; and making of much account our past service, prevented its destruction, and by your deeds, have made credible the words of philosophy. 10 O aged man of more power than tortures, elder more vigorous than fire, greatest king over the emotions, Eleazar! 11 For as father Aaron, armed with a censer, hastening through the consuming fire, vanquished the flame-bearing angel, 12 so, Eleazar, the descendant of Aaron, wasted away by the fire, didn't give up his reasoning. 13 What is most wonderful is that though he was an old man, though the labors of his body were now spent, his muscles were relaxed, and his sinews worn out, he recovered youth. 14 By the spirit of reasoning, and the reasoning of Isaac, he rendered powerless the many-headed rack. 15 O blessed old age, and reverend hoar head, and life obedient to the law, which the faithful seal of death perfected. 16 If, then, an old man, through religion, despised tortures even to death, then certainly religious reasoning is ruler of the emotions. 17 But perhaps some might say, "It is not all who conquer emotions, as not all possess wise reasoning." 18 But those who have meditated upon religion with their whole heart, these alone can master the emotions of the flesh: 19 they who believe that to God they don't die; for, as our forefathers, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, they live to God. 20 This circumstance, then, is by no means an objection, that some who have weak reasoning are governed by their emotions, 21 since what person, walking religiously by the whole rule of philosophy, and believing in God, 22 and knowing that it is a blessed thing to endure all kinds of hardships for virtue, would not, for the sake of religion, master his emotion? 23 For only the wise and brave man is lord over his emotions. 24 This is why even boys, trained with the philosophy of religious reasoning, have conquered still more bitter tortures; 25 for when the tyrant was manifestly vanquished in his first attempt, in being unable to force the old man to eat the unclean thing,

8

1 then, indeed, vehemently swayed with emotion, he commanded to bring others of the adult Hebrews, and if they would eat of the unclean thing, to let them go when they had eaten; but if they objected, to torment them more grievously. 2 The tyrant having given this charge, seven kindred were brought into his presence, along with their aged mother. They were handsome, modest, well-born, and altogether comely. 3 When the tyrant saw them encircling their mother as in a dance, he was pleased with them. Being struck with their becoming and innocent manner, smiled at them, and calling them near, said, 4 "O youths, with favorable feelings, I admire the beauty of each of you. Greatly honouring so numerous a band of kindred, I not only counsel you not to share the madness of the old man who has been tortured before, 5 but I beg you to yield, and to enjoy my friendship; for I possess the power, not only of punishing those who disobey my commands, but of doing good to those who obey them. 6 Put confidence in me, then, and you will receive places of authority in my government, if you forsake your national way of life, 7 and, conforming to the Greek way of life, alter your rule and revel in youth's delights. 8 For if you provoke me by your disobedience, you will compel me to destroy every one of you with terrible punishments by tortures. 9 Have mercy, then, upon your own selves, whom I, although an enemy, am compassionate for your age and attractive appearance. 10 Won't you consider this: that if you disobey, there will be nothing left for you but to die in torture?" 11 When he had said this, he ordered the instruments of torture to be brought forward, that fear might prevail upon them to eat unclean meat. 12 When the spearman brought forward the wheels, the racks, the hooks, racks, caldrons, pans, finger-racks, iron hands and wedges, and bellows, the tyrant continued: 13 "Fear, young men, and the righteousness which you worship will be merciful to you if you transgress because of compulsion." 14 Now they having listened to these words of persuasion, and seeing the fearful instruments, not only were not afraid, but even answered the arguments of the tyrant, and through their good reasoning destroyed his power. 15 Now let's consider the matter. Had any of them been weak-spirited and

cowardly among them, what reasoning would they have employed but these? 16 "O wretched that we are, and exceedingly senseless! When the king exhorts us, and calls us to his bounty, should we not obey him? 17 Why do we cheer ourselves with vain counsels, and venture upon a disobedience bringing death? 18 Shall we not fear, O kindred, the instruments of torture and weigh the threatenings of torment and shun this vain-glory and destructive pride? 19 Let's have compassion upon our age and relent over the years of our mother. 20 Let's bear in mind that we will be dying as rebels. 21 Divine Justice will pardon us if we fear the king through necessity. 22 Why withdraw ourselves from a most sweet life, and deprive ourselves of this pleasant world? 23 Let's not oppose necessity, nor seek vain-glory by our own torture. 24 The law itself wouldn't arbitrarily put us to death because we dread torture. 25 Why has such angry zeal taken root in us, and such fatal obstinacy approved itself to us, when we might live unmolested by the king?" 26 But the young men didn't say or think anything of this kind when about to be tortured. 27 For they were well aware of the sufferings, and masters of the pains. 28-29 So that as soon as the tyrant had ceased counselling them to eat the unclean, they all with one voice, as from the same heart said,

9

1 "Why do you delay, O tyrant? For we are more ready to die than to transgress the injunctions of our fathers. 2 We would be disgracing our fathers if we didn't obey the law, and take knowledge for our guide. 3 O tyrant, counselor of law-breaking, do not, hating us as you do, pity us more than we pity ourselves. 4 For we consider your escape to be worse than death. 5 You try to scare us by threatening us with death by tortures, as though you had learned nothing by the death of Eleazar. 6 But if aged men of the Hebrews have died in the cause of religion after enduring torture, more rightly should we younger men die, scorning your cruel tortures, which our aged instructor overcame. 7 Make the attempt, then, O tyrant. If you put us to death for our religion, don't think that you harm us by torturing us. 8 For we through this ill-treatment and endurance will gain the rewards of virtue. 9 But you, for the wicked and despotic slaughter of us, will, from the Divine vengeance, endure eternal torture by fire." 10 When they had said this, the tyrant was not only exasperated against them for being disobedient, but enraged with them for being ungrateful. 11 So, at his bidding, the torturers brought the oldest of them, and tearing through his tunic, bound his hands and arms on each side with thongs. 12 When they had labored hard without effect in scourging him, they hurled him on the wheel. 13 The noble youth, extended upon this, became dislocated. 14 With every member disjointed, he denounced the tyrant, saying, 15 "O most accursed tyrant, and enemy of heavenly justice, and cruel-hearted, I am no murderer, nor sacrilegious man, whom you torture, but a defender of the Divine law." 16 And when the spearmen said, "Consent to eat, that you may be released from your tortures," 17 he answered, "Not so powerful, O accursed lackeys, is your wheel, as to stifle my reasoning. Cut my limbs, and burn my flesh, and twist my joints. 18 For through all my torments I will convince you that the children of the Hebrews are alone unconquered on behalf of virtue." 19 While he was saying this, they heaped up fuel, and setting fire to it, strained him on the wheel still more. 20 The wheel was defiled all over with blood. The hot ashes were quenched by the droppings of gore, and pieces of flesh were scattered about the axles of the machine. 21 Although the framework of his bones was now destroyed, the high-minded and Abrahamic youth didn't groan. 22 But, as though transformed by fire into immortality, he nobly endured the rackings, saying, 23 "Imitate me, O kindred. Never desert your station, nor renounce my brotherhood in courage. Fight the holy and honorable fight of religion, 24 by which means our just and paternal Providence, becoming merciful to the nation, will punish the pestilent tyrant." 25 Saying this, the revered youth abruptly closed his life. 26 When all admired his courageous soul, the spearmen brought forward him who was second oldest, and having put on iron gauntlets with sharp hooks, bound him to the rack. 27 When, on enquiring whether he would eat before he was tortured, they heard his noble sentiment. 28 After they with the iron gauntlets had violently dragged all the flesh from the neck to the chin, the panther-like animals tore off the very skin of his head, but he, bearing with firmness this misery, said, 29 "How sweet is every form of death for the religion of our fathers!" Then he said to the tyrant, 30 "Don't you think, most cruel of all tyrants, that you are now tortured more than I, finding your arrogant conception of tyranny conquered by our perseverance in behalf of our religion? 31 For I lighten my suffering by the pleasures which are connected with virtue. 32 But you are tortured with threatenings for impiety. You won't escape, most corrupt tyrant, the vengeance of Divine wrath."

10

1 Now this one endured this praiseworthy death. The third was brought along, and exhorted by many to taste and save his life. 2 But he cried out and said, "Don't you know that the father of those who are dead is my father also, and that the same mother bore me, and that I was brought up in the same way? 3 I don't renounce the noble relationship of my kindred. 4 Now then, whatever instrument of vengeance you have, apply it to my body, for you aren't able to touch

my soul, even if you want to." 5 But they, highly incensed at his boldness of speech, dislocated his hands and feet with racking engines, and wrenching them from their sockets, dismembered him. 6 They dragged around his fingers, his arms, his legs, and his ankles. 7 Not being able by any means to strangle him, they tore off his skin, together with the extreme tips of his fingers, and then dragged him to the wheel, 8 around which his vertebral joints were loosened, and he saw his own flesh torn to shreds, and streams of blood flowing from his entrails. 9 When about to die, he said, 10 "We, O accursed tyrant, suffer this for the sake of Divine education and virtue. 11 But you, for your impiety and blood shedding, will endure unceasing torments." 12 Thus having died worthily of his kindred, they dragged forward the fourth, saying, 13 "Don't share the madness of your kindred, but respect the king and save yourself." 14 But he said to them, "You don't have a fire so scorching as to make me play the coward. 15 By the blessed death of my kindred, and the eternal punishment of the tyrant, and the glorious life of the pious, I will not repudiate the noble brotherhood. 16 Invent, O tyrant, tortures, that you may learn, even through them, that I am the brother of those tormented before." 17 When he had said this, the blood-thirsty, murderous, and unholy Antiochus ordered his tongue to be cut out. 18 But he said, "Even if you take away the organ of speech, God still hears the silent. 19 Behold, my tongue is extended, cut it off; for in spite of that you won't silence our reasoning. 20 We gladly lose our limbs on behalf of God. 21 But God will speedily find you, since you cut off the tongue, the instrument of divine melody."

11

1 When he had died, disfigured in his torments, the fifth leaped forward, and said, 2 "I don't intend, O tyrant, to get excused from the torment which is on behalf of virtue. 3 But I have come of my own accord, that by my death you may owe heavenly vengeance and punishment for more crimes. 4 O you hater of virtue and of men, what have we done that you thus revel in our blood? 5 Does it seem evil to you that we worship the Founder of all things, and live according to his surpassing law? 6 But this is worthy of honors, not torments, 7 if you had been capable of the higher feelings of men, and possessed the hope of salvation from God. 8 Behold now, being alien from God, you make war against those who are religious toward God." 9 As he said this, the spearbearers bound him and drew him to the rack, 10 to which binding him at his knees, and fastening them with iron fetters, they bent down his loins upon the wedge of the wheel; and his body was then dismembered, scorpion-fashion. 11 With his breath thus confined, and his body strangled, he said, 12 "A great favor you bestow upon us, O tyrant, by enabling us to manifest our adherence to the law by means of nobler sufferings." 13 He also being dead, the sixth, quite a youth, was brought out. On the tyrant asking him whether he would eat and be delivered, he said, 14 "I am indeed younger than my brothers, but in understanding I am as old; 15 for having been born and reared to the same end. We are bound to die also on behalf of the same cause. 16 So that if you think it is proper to torment us for not eating the unclean, then torment!" 17 As he said this, they brought him to the wheel. 18 Extended upon this, with limbs racked and dislocated, he was gradually roasted from beneath. 19 Having heated sharp spits, they approached them to his back; and having transfixed his sides, they burned away his entrails. 20 He, while tormented, said, "O good and holy contest, in which for the sake of religion, we kindred have been called to the arena of pain, and have not been conquered. 21 For religious understanding, O tyrant, is unconquered. 22 Armed with upright virtue, I also will depart with my kindred. 23 I, too, bearing with me a great avenger, O inventor of tortures, and enemy of the truly pious. 24 We six youths have destroyed your tyranny. 25 For isn't your inability to overrule our reasoning, and to compel us to eat the unclean, your destruction? 26 Your fire is cold to us. Your racks are painless, and your violence harmless. 27 For the guards not of a tyrant but of a divine law are our defenders. Through this we keep our reasoning unconquered."

12

1 When he, too, had undergone blessed martyrdom, and died in the cauldron into which he had been thrown, the seventh, the youngest of all, came forward, 2 whom the tyrant pitying, though he had been dreadfully reproached by his kindred, 3 seeing him already encompassed with chains, had him brought nearer, and endeavored to counsel him, saying, 4 "You see the end of the madness of your kindred, for they have died in torture through disobedience. You, if disobedient, having been miserably tormented, will yourself perish prematurely. 5 But if you obey, you will be my friend, and have a charge over the affairs of the kingdom." 6 Having thus exhorted him, he sent for the boy's mother, that, by showing compassion to her for the loss of so many sons, he might incline her, through the hope of safety, to render the survivor obedient. 7 He, after his mother had urged him on in the Hebrew tongue, (as we will soon relate) said, 8 "Release me that I may speak to the king and all his friends." 9 They, rejoicing exceedingly at the promise of the youth, quickly let him go. 10 He, running up to the pans, said, 11 "Impious tyrant, and most blasphemous man, were you not ashamed, having received prosperity and a kingdom from God, to kill

His servants, and to rack the doers of godliness? 12 Therefore the divine vengeance is reserving you for eternal fire and torments, which will cling to you for all time. 13 Weren't you ashamed, man as you are, yet most savage, to cut out the tongues of men of like feeling and origin, and having thus abused to torture them? 14 But they, bravely dying, fulfilled their religion toward God. 15 But you will groan as you deserve for having slain without cause the champions of virtue. 16 Therefore," he continued, "I myself, being about to die, 17 will not forsake my kindred. 18 I call upon the God of my fathers to be merciful to my race. 19 But you, both living and dead, he will punish." 20 Thus having prayed, he hurled himself into the pans; and so expired.

13

1 If then, the seven kindred despised troubles even to death, it is admitted on all sides that righteous reasoning is absolute master over the emotions. 2 For just as if they had eaten of the unholy as slaves to the emotions, we would have said that they had been conquered by them. 3 Now it is not so. But by means of the reasoning which is praised by God, they mastered their emotions. 4 It is impossible to overlook the leadership of reflection, for it gained the victory over both emotions and troubles. 5 How, then, can we avoid according to these men mastery of emotion through right reasoning, since they didn't withdraw from the pains of fire? 6 For just as by means of towers projecting in front of harbors men break the threatening waves, and thus assure a still course to vessels entering port, 7 so that seven-towered right-reasoning of the young men, securing the harbour of religion, conquered the tempest of emotions. 8 For having arranged a holy choir of piety, they encouraged one another, saying, 9 "Brothers, may we die brotherly for the law. Let us imitate the three young men in Assyria who despised the equally afflicting furnace. 10 Let's not be cowards in the manifestation of piety." 11 One said, "Courage, brother!" and another, "Nobly endure!" 12 Another said, "Remember of what stock you are;" and by the hand of our father Isaac endured to be slain for the sake of piety. 13 One and all, looking at each other serene and confident, said, "Let's sacrifice with all our heart our souls to God who gave them, and employ our bodies for the keeping of the law. 14 Let's not fear him who thinks he kills; 15 for great is the trial of soul and danger of eternal torment laid up for those who transgress the commandment of God. 16 Let's arm ourselves, therefore, in the self-control, which is divine reasoning. 17 If we suffer like this, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob will receive us, and all the fathers will commend us. 18 As each one of the kindred was hauled away, the rest exclaimed, "Don't disgrace us, O brother, nor falsify those who died before you!" 19 Now you are not ignorant of the charm of brotherhood, which the Divine and all wise Providence has imparted through fathers to children, and has engendered through the mother's womb. 20 In which these brothers having remained an equal time, and having been formed for the same period, and been increased by the same blood, and having been perfected through the same principle of life, 21 and having been brought forth at equal intervals, and having sucked milk from the same springs, hence their brotherly souls are reared up lovingly together, 22 and increase the more powerfully by reason of this simultaneous rearing, and by daily companionship, and by other education, and exercise in the law of God. 23 Brotherly love being thus sympathetically constituted, the seven kindred had a more sympathetic mutual harmony. 24 For being educated in the same law, and practicing the same virtues, and reared up in a just course of life, they increased this harmony with each other. 25 For the same ardor for what is right and honorable increased their goodwill and harmony toward each other. 26 For it acting along with religion, made their brotherly feeling more desirable to them. 27 And yet, although nature, companionship, and virtuous morals increased their brotherly love, those who were left endured to see their kindred, who were mistreated for their religion, tortured even to death.

14

1 More that this, they even urged them on to this mistreatment; so that they not only despised pains themselves, but they even got the better of their affections of brotherly love. 2 Reasoning is more royal than a king, and freer than freemen! 3 What a sacred and harmonious concert of the seven kindred as concerning piety! 4 None of the seven youths turned cowardly or shrank back from death. 5 But all of them, as though running the road to immortality, hastened on to death through tortures. 6 For just as hands and feet are moved sympathetically with the directions of the soul, so those holy youths agreed to death for religion's sake, as through the immortal soul of religion. 7 O holy seven of harmonious kindred! For as the seven days of creation, about religion, 8 so the youths, circling around the number seven, annulled the fear of torments. 9 We now shudder at the recital of the affliction of those young men; but they not only saw, and not only heard the immediate execution of the threat, but undergoing it, persevered; and that through the pains of fire. 10 What could be more painful? For the power of fire, being sharp and quick, speedily dissolved their bodies. 11 Don't think it wonderful that reasoning ruled over those men in their torments, when even a woman's mind despised more manifold pains. 12 For the mother of those seven youths endured the

rackings of each of her children. 13 Consider how comprehensive is the love of offspring, which draws every one to sympathy of affection, 14 where irrational animals possess a similar sympathy and love for their offspring with men. 15 The tame birds frequenting the roofs of our houses defend their fledglings. 16 Others build their nests, and hatch their young, on the tops of mountains and in the precipices of valleys, and the holes and tops of trees, and keep away the intruder. 17 If not able to do this, they fly circling round them in agony of affection, calling out in their own note, and save their offspring in whatever manner they are able. 18 But why should we point attention to the sympathy toward children shown by irrational animals? 19 Even bees, at the season of honey-making, attack all who approach, and pierce with their sting, as with a sword, those who draw near their hive, and repel them even to death. 20 But sympathy with her children didn't turn away the mother of the young men, who had a spirit kindred with that of Abraham.

15

1 O reasoning of the sons, lord over the emotions, and religion more desirable to a mother than children! 2 The mother, when two things were set before her, religion and the safety of her seven sons for a time, on the conditional promise of a tyrant, 3 rather elected the religion which according to God preserves to eternal life. 4 In what way can I describe ethically the affections of parents toward their children, the resemblance of soul and of form impressed into the small type of a child in a wonderful manner, especially through the greater sympathy of mothers with the feelings of those born of them! 5 For by how much mothers are by nature weak in disposition and prolific in offspring, by so much the fonder they are of children. 6 Of all mothers, the mother of the seven was the fondest of children, who in seven childbirths had deeply engendered love toward them. 7 Through her many pains undergone in connection with each one, she was compelled to feel sympathy with them; 8 yet, through fear of God, she neglected the temporary salvation of her children. 9 Not only so, but on account of the excellent disposition to the law, her maternal affection toward them was increased. 10 For they were both just and temperate, and courageous, high-minded, fond of their kindred, and so fond of their mother that even to death they obeyed her by observing the law. 11 Yet, though there were so many circumstances connected with love of children to draw on a mother to sympathy, in the case of none of them were the various tortures able to pervert her principle. 12 But she inclined each one separately and all together to death for religion. 13 O holy nature and parental feeling, and reward of bringing up children, and unconquerable maternal affection! 14 At the racking and roasting of each one of them, the observant mother was prevented by religion from changing. 15 She saw her children's flesh dissolving around the fire, and their extremities quivering on the ground, and the flesh of their heads dropped forward down to their beards, like masks. 16 O you mother, who was tried at this time with bitterer pangs than those at birth! 17 O you only woman who have produced perfect holiness! 18 Your firstborn, expiring, didn't turn you, nor the second, looking miserable in his torments, nor the third, breathing out his soul. 19 You didn't weep when you saw each of their eyes looking sternly at their tortures, and their nostrils foreboding death! 20 When you saw children's flesh heaped upon children's flesh that had been torn off, heads decapitated upon heads, dead falling upon the dead, and a choir of children turned through torture into a burying ground, you didn't lament. 21 Not so do siren melodies or songs of swans attract the hearers to listening, O voices of children calling on your mother in the midst of torments! 22 With what and what manner of torments was the mother herself tortured, as her sons were undergoing the wheel and the fires! 23 But religious reasoning, having strengthened her courage in the midst of sufferings, enabled her to forego, for the time, parental love. 24 Although seeing the destruction of seven children, the noble mother, after one embrace, stripped off her feelings through faith in God. 25 For just as in a council room, seeing in her own soul vehement counselors, nature and parentage and love of her children, and the racking of her children, 26 she holding two votes, one for the death, the other for the preservation of her children, 27 didn't lean to that which would have saved her children for the safety of a brief space. 28 But this daughter of Abraham remembered his holy fortitude. 29 O holy mother of a nation, avenger of the law, defender of religion, and prime bearer in the battle of the affections! 30 O you nobler in endurance than males, and more courageous than men in perseverance! 31 For like Noah's ship, bearing the world in the world-filling flood, bore up against the waves, 32 so you, the guardian of the law, when surrounded on every side by the flood of emotions, and assaulted by violent storms which were the torments of your children, bore up nobly against the storms against religion.

16

1 If, then, even a woman, and that an aged one, and the mother of seven children, endured to see her children's torments even to death, it must be admitted that religious reasoning is master even of the emotions. 2 I have proved, then, that not only men have obtained the mastery of their emotions, but also that a woman despised the greatest torments. 3 The lions around Daniel were not so fierce, nor the

furnace of Misael burning with most vehement fires as that natural love of children burned within her, when she saw her seven sons tortured. 4 But with the reasoning of religion the mother quenched emotions so great and powerful. 5 For we must consider also this: that, had the woman been faint hearted, as being their mother, she would have lamented over them, and perhaps might have spoken thus: 6 "Ah! I am wretched and many times miserable, who having born seven sons, have become the mother of none. 7 O seven useless childbirths, and seven profitless periods of labor, and fruitless givings of suck, and miserable nursings at the breast. 8 Vainly, for your sakes, O sons, have I endured many pangs, and the more difficult anxieties of rearing. 9 Alas, of my children, some of you unmarried, and some who have married to no profit, I will not see your children, nor have the joy of being a grandmother. 10 Ah, that I who had many and fair children, should be a lone widow full of sorrows! 11 Nor, should I die, will I have a son to bury me." But with such a lament as this, the holy and God-fearing mother wept for none of them. 12 Nor did she divert any of them from death, nor grieve for them as for the dead. 13 But as one possessed with an adamant mind, and as one bringing forth again her full number of sons to immortality, she rather urged them to death on behalf of religion. 14 O woman, soldier of God for religion, you, aged and a female, have conquered through endurance even a tyrant; and even though weak, have been found more powerful in deeds and words. 15 For when you were seized along with your children, you stood looking at Eleazar in torture, and said to your sons in the Hebrew tongue, 16 "O sons, the contest is noble, to which you being called as a witness for the nation, strive zealously for the laws of your country. 17 For it would be disgraceful if this old man endured pains for the sake of righteousness, and that you who are younger would be afraid of the tortures. 18 Remember that through God, you obtained existence and have enjoyed it. 19 Therefore, you ought to bear every affliction because of God. 20 For him also our father Abraham was zealous to sacrifice Isaac our progenitor, and didn't shudder at the sight of his own paternal hand descending down with the sword upon him. 21 The righteous Daniel was cast to the lions; and Ananias, Azarias, and Misael were hurled into a fiery furnace, yet they endured through God. 22 You, then, having the same faith toward God, don't be troubled. 23 For it is unreasonable that they who know religion wouldn't stand up against troubles. 24 With these arguments, the mother of seven, exhorting each of her sons, encouraged and persuaded them not to transgress God's commandment. 25 They saw this, too, that those who die for God, live to God, like Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and all the patriarchs.

17

1 Some of the spearbearers said that when she herself was about to be seized for the purpose of being put to death, she threw herself on the pile, rather than let them touch her body. 2 O you mother, who together with seven children destroyed the violence of the tyrant, and rendered void his wicked intentions, and exhibited the nobleness of faith! 3 For you, like a house bravely built on the pillar of your children, bore the shock of tortures without swaying. 4 Cheer up, therefore, O holy-minded mother! Hold the firm hope of your steadfastness with God. 5 Not so gracious does the moon appear with the stars in heaven, as you are established as honorable before God, and fixed in the sky with your sons whom you illuminated with religion to the stars. 6 For your bearing of children was after the manner of a child of Abraham. 7 If it were lawful for us to paint as on a tablet the religion of your story, the spectators wouldn't shudder at seeing the mother of seven children enduring for the sake of religion various tortures even to death. 8 It would have been a worthwhile thing to have inscribed on the tomb itself these words as a memorial to those of the nation, 9 "Here an aged priest, and an aged woman, and seven sons, are buried through the violence of a tyrant, who wished to destroy the society of the Hebrews. 10 These also avenged their nation, looking to God, and enduring torments to death." 11 For it was truly a divine contest which was carried through by them. 12 For at that time virtue presided over the contest, approving the victory through endurance, namely, immortality, eternal life. 13 Eleazar was the first to contend. The mother of the seven children entered the contest, and the kindred contended. 14 The tyrant was the antagonist; and the world and living men were the spectators. 15 Reverence for God conquered, and crowned her own athletes. 16 Who didn't admire those champions of true legislation? Who were not amazed? 17 The tyrant himself, and all their council, admired their endurance, 18 through which, they also now stand beside the divine throne and live a blessed life. 19 For Moses says, "All the saints are under your hands." 20 These, therefore, having been sanctified through God, have been honored not only with this honor, but that also by the fact that because of them, the enemy didn't overcome our nation. 21 That tyrant was punished and their country purified. 22 For they became the ransom to the sin of the nation. The Divine Providence saved Israel, which was afflicted before, by the blood of those pious ones and the death that appeased wrath. 23 For the tyrant Antiochus, looking to their courageous virtue and to their endurance in torture,

proclaimed that endurance as an example to his soldiers. 24 They proved to be to him noble and brave for land battles and for sieges; and he conquered and stormed the towns of all his enemies.

18

1 O Israelite children, descendants of the seed of Abraham, obey this law and in every way be religious, 2 knowing that religious reasoning is lord of the emotions, and those not only inward but outward. 3 Therefore those people who gave up their bodies to pains for the sake of religion were not only admired by men, but were deemed worthy of a divine portion. 4 The nation through them obtained peace, and having renewed the observance of the law in their country, drove the enemy out of the land. 5 The tyrant Antiochus was both punished on earth, and is punished now that he is dead; for when he was quite unable to compel the Israelites to adopt foreign customs, and to desert the manner of life of their fathers, 6 then, departing from Jerusalem, he made war against the Persians. 7 The righteous mother of the seven children spoke also as follows to her offspring: "I was a pure virgin, and didn't go beyond my father's house, but I took care of the rib from which woman was made. 8 No destroyer of the desert or ravisher of the plain injured me, nor did the destructive, deceitful snake make plunder of my chaste virginity. I remained with my husband during the time of my maturity. 9 When these, my children, arrived at maturity, their father died. He was blessed! For having sought out a life of fertility in children, he was not grieved with a period of loss of children. 10 He used to teach you, when yet with you, the law and the prophets. 11 He used to read to you about the slaying of Abel by Cain, the offering up of Isaac, and the imprisonment of Joseph. 12 He used to tell you of the zealous Phinehas, and informed you of Ananias, Azarias, and Misael in the fire. 13 He used to glorify Daniel, who was in the den of lions, and pronounce him blessed. 14 He used to remind you of the scripture of Esaias, which says, "Even if you pass through the fire, it won't burn you." 15 He chanted to you David, the hymn writer, who says, "Many are the afflictions of the just." 16 He declared the proverbs of Solomon, who says, "He is a tree of life to all those who do His will." 17 He used to confirm what Ezekiel said: "Will these dry bones live?" 18 For he didn't forget the song which Moses taught, proclaiming, "I will kill, and I will make alive." 19 This is our life and the length of our days. 20 O that bitter, and yet not bitter, day when the bitter tyrant of the Greeks, quenching fire with fire in his cruel caldrons, brought with boiling rage the seven sons of the daughter of Abraham to the rack, and to all his torments! 21 He pierced the balls of their eyes, and cut out their tongues, and put them to death with varied tortures. 22 Therefore divine retribution pursued and will pursue the pestilent wretch. 23 But the children of Abraham, with their victorious mother, are assembled together to the choir of their father, having received pure and immortal souls from God. 24 To him be glory forever and ever. Amen.